

A MEMOIR

THE ESCAPE



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The Escape

Eric Zachary Ryder

Prologue

When I was a child, I never thought I'd live to be 16. When I hit 16, I couldn't even imagine what it would be like to be 21. Maybe everyone's like that. I've never actually asked anyone.

I was a 16-year-old runaway living in one of the worst neighborhoods in Providence, Rhode Island, in the late 1970s, surrounded by an assortment of characters who sometimes seemed almost too clichéd to be real. I was broke, perpetually stoned, occasionally in trouble, and mostly figuring things out as I went along. Somehow, I came out the other side reasonably intact.

Whenever I've told anyone the stories about my years in Providence, the response has always been the same: 'You have to write a book!' I've been hearing that ever since—for almost fifty years.

I started writing it out in my 20s, 30s, 40s, and 50s, always in fits and starts. Then life would get in the way, the momentum would disappear, and I'd put it aside for another decade. I've lost or destroyed all of those early attempts, thankfully.

I have the time now, and I'm writing this Prologue after finally finishing the stories that follow. Writing them was a lot of fun, but getting them right took a lot of work. Much of that came from my obsession with *accuracy*. Part of the reason I finally wrote all of this down was simply to preserve the memories while I still could. It wasn't about creating a good *story*. It was about getting *my story right*—the facts and details, the sights and sounds and smells, and how I felt in the moments I was living them. There wouldn't be much point in preserving memories I'd made up.

Unfortunately, to get to the "fun" part—which is a debatable word for some of it, in some cases—I have to give you the backstory that got me there. This was not always... comfortable... for me to revisit. There are some scenes that kept me awake at night after I wrote them. There are things I debated putting in here because I'm embarrassed by them. Or

they're not very flattering. But leaving them out would defeat the whole purpose.

This was never just about sharing my truly crazy experiences during a few years at the end of my teens. Writing it turned out to be a bit cathartic, too, just as others who have gone down this path told me it would be.

Like most people, I'm not perfect. I wasn't perfect as a child. I'm not perfect as an adult. Well... almost, but that doesn't count. I made mistakes. I said or did stupid things. Things I regret. Some things almost immediately after I'd said or done them.

So... buckle up.

I titled the book *The Escape* because it fits in so many different ways. I won't list them out, as I think you'll see them as you go along for the ride.

The First Time

I was seven years old the first time I ran away from home. The fact that I said "first" probably tells you there was more than one—and you'd be right. I wasn't alone in that first escape, though; my three siblings came with me. You could say it was a child mutiny, of sorts.

It was a hazy late-summer afternoon. Hot and humid. Since we were in it for the long haul, though, we packed up a few blankets and food - crackers, bread, peanut butter and jelly - and while my parents were busy upstairs, we snuck out of the house and "ran away"—all the way to the end of the street, or about a hundred feet from home. Beyond the end of the street was a small field with trees, rocks, tall grass, and brambly bushes. One of the bushes had a hollowed-out center that made a perfect "fort". We were all laughing and excited... Pioneers! Blazing a trail to a new destiny! Who knew where we'd end up? Anything seemed better than living in that house. Pretty much anything, anyway. I guess drowning in quicksand might have been a little worse. Or being burned at the stake like Joan of Arc. That would suck more.

Anyway, I know I was seven because we had recently moved into our first house from our old apartment. That made my co-conspirators between 5 and 8 years old. Mark was a year older than me. I was next, then my sister Leslie, and finally Alex. We were all one year apart in age.

It seems incredible to me now, objectively speaking, that children this young would run away from home—and actually be serious about it.

We'd been gone less than an hour when suddenly we spotted both my parents standing at the top of the embankment on the side of the road, about fifty feet away. Side by side, quietly staring down at us.

They said nothing.

I have no idea how long they had been there, watching.

They didn't wave. They didn't yell. They just stood there, silently studying us. My mother had her hands on her hips, looking down at us with that familiar expression of hers—angry and disapproving, almost disgusted, but also calculating, as if she were deciding how to handle this little "situation." You could almost see the wheels turning in her head.

The whole scene has always reminded me of an old black-and-white episode of *The Twilight Zone* or *The Outer Limits*. Something was really off; this wasn't how parents were supposed to act. Then again, this wasn't how their kids were supposed to act.

We all froze. Time froze. Even the birds seemed to go quiet. It was probably only three or four seconds that seemed like minutes, and all I could hear was the muffled traffic on Park Avenue, a block away.

Once they saw that we saw them—and had silently telegraphed their command to return to base—they just turned and walked back to the house, confident we'd follow. We were, of course, totally panicked about what would happen when we got home. They had found our pathetically obvious hiding place in no time; they probably heard us carrying on and having a good time right from our driveway. If we didn't go back sooner rather than later, it would only be worse for us when we did.

We slowly packed up our things. None of us said a word. The 100-foot walk home is a bit of a blur to me now, but I vividly recall walking back *into* the house. It was strangely quiet. They weren't downstairs, where the back door opened into the dining room. They were upstairs in the living room, and, oddly, the TV wasn't on. The Felix the Cat clock swung its tail on the wall, its eyes darting left, then right, as if surveilling all that went on. Once the door was shut and we were standing there trying to figure out what to do next, my mother's voice came floating down the stairs from her designated spot on the couch.

"Come upstairs. All of you."

She sounded calm. Almost... reasonable? That was new... and gave me a tiny bit of hope that this would all be OK. I mean, we were only gone an hour...

I followed Mark upstairs. We went up in order of our birth; Mark, Me, Leslie, Alex. I suppose it seemed like the right order; first to come into the world, first to be taken out. My legs hadn't received that same glimmer of hope my brain had and were shaking so hard I had trouble walking. I had to hold onto the railing to keep from falling as we silently shuffled upstairs.

We assembled in a row perpendicular to the couch, all eyes on her. My father was sitting in his recliner, interested, but not involved. Yet.

"I'm not going to talk about the worry you put us through for the last hour. We'll talk about that later," she said. I stole a quick look at my father, who remained impassive but present, like he was just awaiting the order to start exercising his belt.

"I want to know why you ran away. Mark, you start first, and then I want all of you to tell me why."

Mark looked at me, the instigator of the mutiny, but I just looked down, paralyzed with fear and grateful for the extra minute to figure out what I could say that would piss my mother off the least—and maybe lessen whatever punishment was coming, if that was even possible.

"None of the other kids at school have to spend all day every other Saturday cleaning the house," he sputtered out, trying to look brave.

We were barely old enough to wrestle a mop and a heavy pail of water around, never mind being responsible for cleaning an entire three-story house on our hands and knees. Two of us cleaned it every other Saturday, switching off with the other two. By the time we finished, most of Saturday was gone.

"OK... Eric? Is that your position, too? I work you too hard? No other kids have to do chores?" —which is not what Mark said.

I could barely speak, and at first just nodded my head a little, but then managed to draw on Mark's bravery, as lame as it was.

"I guess so. It hurts to scrub the floor on our hands and knees, and... and... other kids at least have a mop, or something. And they don't have to make milk and do their own laundry. Their mothers do it for them."

That last part was a really dumb thing to add. She was getting angrier by the second.

"Oh. I see. So everyone's Mom does everything for them, and they don't have any chores"—which is not what I said.

"No, no, I mean, they have chores, but not as many, and..." I trailed off. The trap had already sprung, and anything else I said would just make it worse.

"And what?"

"Nothing. That's all."

"Leslie? Do you agree with Mark and Eric? I'm working you too hard?"

Leslie looked at Mark and me with a look that said, "I got nothin'," then just nodded her head.

"Alex? Did you just go along for the ride?" She was cutting him some slack because he was the youngest.

"Yes," was all he said.

I remember being surprised that we didn't go straight to the usual beating, but we didn't escape that fate. On cue, my father stood up and took off his belt. This sent all of us into a panic as he took us, one by one, into the den right off the living room—probably because there was a little more room in there, not out of any concern for privacy—and proceeded to beat the living daylights out of us. First the pants came down. Then the underwear. It's surprising how much protection that one thin layer of cotton actually provided.

The first blow was always the most shocking. The pain was so overwhelming that my brain needed a second to process what had just happened. My first reaction wasn't even to cry. It was sheer panic; a terrifying realization: This is only the first one. How do I survive the rest of this?

*

A common enough scene in our house was a chorus of crying and screaming children, punctuated by the sharp whistle of a belt whipping through the air. Waiting your turn was a form of psychological torture; we'd already be crying, knowing exactly what was coming next. We'd yell through our tears, begging the administering parent to stop hurting whichever one of us was getting it. If it was my father, my mother would occasionally egg him on, calling out, "Hit him harder!"

My father never argued. His face would turn red with the effort, his legs spreading into a wider stance as he swung the belt. He was a working man. Even though he owned the company, he wore the same forest-green work shirt as everyone else, with a "Sonny" patch sewn above the left breast pocket. He looked exactly like what he was: a blue-collar guy who worked with his hands every day.

This wasn't a spanking. It was serious physical abuse. Of course, we didn't know that then. We thought every kid grew up this way.

Even now, it blows my mind that a grown man could, and would, beat a small child's bare backside with all of his strength for what felt like five straight minutes, until we were in so much pain we couldn't breathe and cry at the same time.

*

My mother was no stranger to using the belt, either, but her spankings were... spankings. Not "beatings." That is, unless she was using a wire

hanger or the first thing she could get her hands on. Then it could be just as bad as the belt, or worse.

But running away en masse apparently warranted something more severe. I suspect it was because her entire set of children had decided things were so bad under her authoritarian regime that it was better to risk being eaten by wolves out in the forest than spend another minute in her house.

Maybe that didn't square very well with her image of herself as the perfect mother.

Back then, a lot of kids were spanked for any infraction. It wasn't until I was an adult that I realized just how different our house was.

Other punishments included the dreaded “kneeling on the grate”—a metal floor heat register with sharp, upturned vents. Kneeling there bare-kneed in our underwear for ten or fifteen minutes would sometimes leave our knees bleeding, the thin metal digging into our flesh while we tried desperately not to sit back on our ankles, because trying to ease the pain only earned you another beating. Standing in the corner was also tortuous. Any little offense could land you there for hours—sometimes all four kids at once.

Another complication was that my brother Mark had been diagnosed with Type 1 diabetes when he was five. This had far-reaching effects on my own life. My mother protected him to the point where even if she suspected he had done something punishable, she wouldn't confront him directly, but would ask the four kids, “Who took the cookies?” or “Who ate the cake?” Mark, of course, said nothing, and the rest of us had no clue that he had done whatever it was. So we would all be punished until someone confessed.

This could mean kneeling in the corner for hours on end, on a beautiful summer afternoon. I remember looking around the dining room, where we were all facing our respective corners, whispering to each other.

"Did you do it?"

And everyone said, "No!"

After a while, it became clear that no one was going to confess and that someone had to admit to it, whether they did it or not. Staring at the corner, trying not to shuffle around too much and get beaten for it, the bargaining would begin.

"Who's gonna take the blame?"

We had this conversation more than a few times over those early years, and it demanded some serious negotiation. If we ever wanted to get out of the corner and go play, someone was going to have to take the spanking. Since none of us would admit to it, it became a horse trade of desserts and allowance money. Because I was protective of my younger siblings, and because Mark was stubborn and would never give in, I usually "took the blame."

I was extremely hesitant to put myself through the brutal pain, but I knew it would be over in a few minutes. I'd be sore for days, but at least I could get out of that maddening corner and go outside to feel the sunshine on my face. I would also be a little richer in hard, cold cash and desserts.

So, the next step was the tough part: yelling up the stairs, "Mommy, I did it." She would call something back down to the effect of, "Are you sure?" - which didn't strike me as altogether odd then, but it does now. I would say, "Yes." Then she would call me upstairs and tell me to get my father's belt out of his closet. Walking up that one flight was like walking myself to the electric chair from Death Row. Then the walk across the hardwood floor of my parents' bedroom and into my father's closet, with his work clothes, the smell of his aftershave, and an assortment of leather belts hanging on the back of the door.

I was told to pick the thick one.

Knees knocking, I walked back across the bedroom and into the living room and handed her the belt.

When it was over, everyone went back to whatever they had been doing before.

But the story doesn't end there...

*

Sometime in my 30s, I think it was, I was living in California and Mark was still in Providence when I came back east for a visit. We went out to a diner for lunch near his apartment, and once we ordered, we got to talking about our childhoods and some of the shit we'd been through.

"I have to tell you something that I already told Leslie and Alex. You're the last to know, because you're the hardest one to admit this to, given the circumstances."

"You know all those times where we were all punished and no one confessed and someone had to 'take the blame'? And that someone was typically you?"

"Yeeeeeaaahhh....?"

"I'm the one who did all of those things."

I just stared at him for a few long seconds, then glanced away, trying to process what he'd just said. I was stunned... Finally, my adult brain kicked in—my logical adult brain—and the reality dawned on me. *Of course he did.* It suddenly all made sense.

It amazes me that none of the other three of us kids ever figured it out at the time. But he was the one who couldn't have sugar. He was the one who constantly cheated on his diet and ate sugar anyway. And he was the little bastard who loved to torture us. If we'd done something we could get in trouble for—swearing, for instance—he'd hold it over our heads. "I'm telling Mommy you swore!" Quickly followed by, "Unless you eat this

handful of dry Friskies cat food." He thought it was hilarious when we eventually did. Because he absolutely would rat on us if he felt like it. Which he did on more than one occasion if he didn't get his way.

But the story doesn't end here, either.

Then he told me, "Mom knew it was me all along."

"WHAT??!!"

He looked contrite and remorseful, and quietly said, "She knew it was me. She told me this. She said she didn't want to single me out as being the obvious culprit because she knew how hard it was for me to not be able to eat sweet stuff like the rest of you. So she was hoping I would confess and not have to put her through accusing me all the time, when it really could have been any of us. But the odds were strong in her mind that it was me. And it was. I just didn't have the balls to take the beating for it, and I felt justified because I couldn't have it and you guys could. I've felt guilty my whole adult life over this and... I'm truly sorry, and I hope you can forgive me..."

Then he looked away and suddenly started crying.

My shock and anger quickly turned to compassion. I came around to his side of the booth, sat next to him, and gave him a long hug. I felt bad for him. He had a much harder life than I had. Some of what he did to me growing up was horrific and affected me in ways I'm still dealing with today. But he got dealt a far worse hand than I did, and he was just a kid. We all were.

But my mother wasn't.

How can a mother brutally punish one of her kids for something she knows they didn't do, while allowing the guilty one to get away scot-free? Perhaps "knew" is too strong. Maybe she couldn't prove it. Maybe it was only a hunch. But she knew her children. She knew I was lying when I

said I'd done it. I wasn't very convincing. That's why she always asked, "Are you sure?"

I blocked most of my childhood trauma out by the time I was 20 or so. Unfortunately, some scenes, such as this one, survived.

After that first time, I ran away alone. Other than one or two attempts by my sister, I was the only one who ever did it again.

And I ran away a lot.

Not So Sweet

Baltimore

When Leslie was five years old, my mother pulled her out of kindergarten and sent her to Baltimore to stay with my mother's aunt and uncle.

I remember standing at the window of our first-floor apartment as my mother got everything packed and ready for what we all thought was maybe a two-week trip. I watched her load Leslie's little suitcase into the trunk, and then Leslie and Mark climbed into the back seat of her blue 1965 Mustang convertible. My mother's best friend, Teri, got into the passenger seat.

I watched them pull away and don't remember thinking much of anything about it. Why would I? She was going on a trip. She'd come home... soon.

About 500 miles later, my mother brought Leslie to the front door of her Aunt Dotty and Uncle Jimmy's house. Leslie didn't know Dotty. Her shoes were untied, and Dotty wasn't having that. Right there on the doorstep, she started teaching Leslie how to tie her shoes.

Within about five minutes, Leslie had figured it out. She turned around to show my mother what she'd learned. But my mother was... gone.

No one had told Leslie she was staying. No one had told her how long she'd be there or when she'd be going home.

Back home, after she'd been gone for a few weeks, we started asking my mother when Leslie was coming back. She eventually told us that she would be staying for the entire school year, which pretty much blew our little minds. In kid time, that was a very long time. We were never told *why*. I don't recall what the story was at the time, but it turned out that it wasn't the truth.

Leslie had only been in kindergarten for about a week when my mother pulled her out because she cried too much. Around the same time, my mother was seeing a psychiatrist named Dr. Jones. Leslie went with her to his office and sat in the waiting room playing with dolls while my mother talked to him. Years later, my mother told her that Dr. Jones had recommended sending her somewhere quieter for a while.

There was certainly plenty going on in our house. Mark had recently been diagnosed with Type 1 diabetes, my parents were constantly fighting, and Leslie was having some kind of seizures. We also found out I'd been walking around half blind my entire life without realizing it, until I got to first grade and couldn't read the chalkboard. My mother had four young kids and was clearly having trouble dealing with all of it. So, apparently, sending one of them away for a while seemed like a good idea.

Except "a while" turned into the entire school year. Leslie didn't come home for Christmas, her birthday, or anything else. She stayed in Baltimore until the following summer.

Oddly enough, I remember being a little envious of her. She got to go away and live somewhere else for almost a year. At that age, getting away from our house for that long sounded pretty damned good to me.

Things at home were a little different while Leslie was gone. My mother was still her usual nightmare self for the most part, but she seemed a little calmer for a while. It doesn't seem like much of a leap to think she probably felt guilty about separating Leslie from her three brothers, if nothing else. There was more breathing room, or something. Less tension. A little less drama from my mother. It wasn't as though everything suddenly became wonderful. Let's not get carried away here.

By the time Leslie came home the following summer, things pretty quickly settled back into our family's version of "normal." It wasn't

anything Leslie was doing. Whatever had changed for a while was in my mother, not her.

I recently learned something else about my mother's relationship with Leslie. At my father's funeral, Teri told her that my mother had always been jealous of her because Leslie was Daddy's little girl. As Leslie put it, she'd also had the nerve to be born the day before my father's birthday.

I'd always assumed Leslie had gotten the better end of the deal, being shipped off for a nine-month vacation in the not-very-deep South. After talking to her about it while writing this book, I found out it wasn't really that simple.

My mother's uncle Jimmy was the bright spot. He was a university professor, and Leslie adored him. He was her *Father Knows Best* version of a dad. When he came home, she'd run to him, sit on his lap, and comb his hair. She remained attached to him long after she returned home and was heartbroken when he died while she was in ninth grade.

My mother's aunt Dotty, on the other hand, was strict and rigid, and Leslie was constantly in trouble with her. She'd get whacked with a wooden spoon or be made to sit on a tall kitchen chair as punishment. Their older daughter, Joyce, had very little to do with her, and Leslie felt like she was mostly an annoyance to her. Their younger daughter, Janey, was nicer and occasionally took her places with her boyfriend, Tom. Even playing outside wasn't necessarily much fun. The kid next door used to bite her.

She did take ballet lessons, which helped distract her from missing home. She missed us—her brothers—and wondered why she hadn't gone home.

She had a birthday while she was there and got a new bicycle, which she later learned had come from my parents. She learned how to ride without training wheels in Baltimore.

There was something else I knew nothing about until Leslie told me recently. My mother once told her she'd sent her away because she was afraid she was going to kill her.

Those were my mother's own words.

Leslie was terrified of her at that age. On one occasion, my mother slapped her so hard while she was sitting in a high chair that she nearly went flying out of it. Our Aunt Kathy witnessed it along with our grandmother.

Whether my mother genuinely believed she might hurt Leslie badly enough to kill her, I have no way of knowing. Maybe sending her to Baltimore really was, in my mother's mind, a way of protecting her. I don't know.

When Leslie finally came home the following summer, she'd picked up a Baltimore accent, which I thought was pretty cool. Though the neighborhood kids made fun of her for it.

And life went on.

Candy

We started stealing candy and Hostess products from the local supermarkets when we were little—probably seven or younger. We also got caught and thoroughly beaten for it... the few times we got caught. We actually got pretty good at stealing. I was very good at it.

One winter night, when I was around six, my mother sent seven-year-old Mark and five-year-old Leslie to the grocery store two blocks away to pick up a gallon of milk and a loaf of bread. I was sitting at the dinner table doing my second grade homework when they walked back through the door, bringing a sharp gust of cold New England air with them. They were both wearing the "snorkel" jackets popular in the '60s, which zipped all the way up to form the underside of a hood, making you look like you

were navigating the world from inside a fabric periscope. I noticed a package of cupcakes just visible in my sister's pocket.

"What's that in your pocket?" I asked loudly.

Both of them snapped their heads toward me with a look of horror that has been burned into my guilty brain ever since. My mother came out of the bedroom, half-dressed, to investigate this matter of Top Priority.

"What do you have in your pockets?" she demanded. "Empty them out onto the table."

We all knew immediately what was coming. Slowly, they emptied their pockets onto the table, revealing a package of pink Hostess SnoBalls and two chocolate cupcakes. We had no money of our own, so obviously these were stolen goods.

"Where did you get these?! What have I told you about stealing?!"

They just stood there, frozen, trying to figure out what to say. But, they knew they were screwed.

She disappeared back into her bedroom and came back with a wire hanger. They still had their heavy snorkel jackets on, but they didn't have that same luxury from the waist down. They stumbled across the linoleum screaming while she whipped them with the hanger. I just sat there, horrified by what I'd set in motion.

I've felt guilty about that night ever since. It was a selfish and thoughtless thing to do, and I regretted it as soon as the words came out of my mouth. But, I know exactly why I did it; I was jealous. They had cupcakes, and I didn't. That's really all there was to it. I apologized to both of them more than once over the years.

At some point after that, I got caught stealing candy myself and was thoroughly beaten for it, of course. It wasn't with a wire hanger, though I; remember that much. Given that I'd previously ratted Leslie and Mark out

for stealing the SnoBalls and cupcakes, I suppose karma had its way with me.

The next day, we sat down for dinner as usual, and my mother made an Important Proclamation:

"Since you guys like candy so much, I've decided that's what you'll be having for all of your meals from now on."

We looked at each other, hardly believing our ears. Candy? Three times a day? We were secretly thrilled, but we quickly put on our game faces, trying to appear solemn and defeated as we accepted this horrible "punishment."

Then she placed a bowl in front of each of us. We looked down into this Bowl of Magical Treats, only to find an assortment of cheap neon-colored hard candies—the generic kind your grandmother keeps in a dusty dish by the couch. It was the sort of candy that tastes fine for a bite or two before turning your stomach.

"You are not allowed to leave the table until you eat all of it," she said.

Dinner, so to speak, took forever. Breakfast, lunch, and dinner the next day were exactly the same. The whole thing lasted about two days before she apparently decided she'd made her point. Maybe she realized it wouldn't look very good if the neighbors discovered she and my father were eating meat and potatoes while the four kids were being fed nothing but cheap hard candy.

We wanted sugar so badly that if she'd actually given us the kind of candy we liked, we'd have happily eaten it three meals a day. Somehow, we all made it to adulthood with all—or at least most—of our teeth intact, unlike my father, who had every tooth in his mouth pulled out in his early forties and wore dentures for the rest of his life.

Slaves

In our house, the kids were convenient slaves whose job was to scrub the floors on our hands and knees, vacuum, dust, and wash, dry, and put away the dishes after every meal. We didn't have a dishwasher. As we grew, the list expanded: do laundry, mow the lawn, paint the house, wash the car, and even chop wood like Abraham Lincoln once we got a wood stove.

Of course, there was nothing unusual about kids having chores, especially in a family that was always struggling financially. My parents both worked hard, money was tight, and there were four kids in the house. We were expected to pitch in, and there's nothing particularly remarkable about that. But the amount of work expected of us went way beyond normal chores, and as we got older, we even cooked most of the dinners, served cocktails, and fetched snacks for our parents while they watched TV.

Food was another matter. They ate real butter; the kids got margarine. They drank real milk; we had to "make milk" from powdered "milk"—the most disgusting food product ever invented by man. It was easy to make it lumpy, too thick, or too thin. It tasted like what I imagined watery wallpaper paste tasted like. If you forgot to mix it the night before, it was warm for your cereal, making breakfast taste like warm, wet cardboard.

Lunches were the cheapest lunch meat available—things like mortadella, which is basically bologna with big hunks of disgusting fat in it. I threw away the sandwich half the time and just ate the four cookies we were allowed, and maybe the piece of fruit, if there was one. Needless to say, none of us were fat—and none of us ever became fat, either. I suppose that was a silver lining.

It's one thing to be low-income, but it's another to treat yourself to "real" food while giving your kids the cheap, tasteless alternatives. My father would wolf down a sleeve of Oreos while watching TV, occasionally

flipping the kids a single cookie each. We were like four circus seals lined up on a couch, waiting for the trainer to throw us a fish. Tossing us one apiece left him with nine cookies in the sleeve. Giving us two each would have left him with only five.

The math always favored him, of course.

As soon as we were old enough to carry a stack of fifty newspapers, we had paper routes. At one point, my brother and I had 110 houses to deliver to every day, on top of all the chores we were already doing.

Then there were the trips into the woods before Christmas to collect princess pine. We used green wire to attach the greenery to old coat hangers, decorated them, and turned them into Christmas wreaths. My mother would then force us to set up a stand on a street corner, selling them for \$25 apiece. It was a mortifying experience whenever a classmate's car pulled up to the intersection. She also dragged us out for neighborhood Christmas caroling, which was another great way to guarantee being humiliated at school. No one else did these things. No other classmates rang doorbells and sang Christmas carols or sold shit they made on the side of the road.

To round out the embarrassment, my mother often dressed us funny—or "trendy"—and gave us bad haircuts. One time, when I was fourteen, she forced me to go to junior high dressed in tight, multicolored plaid polyester bell-bottoms. My nickname that week became "Leotard Lynch." After that, I started hiding a pair of jeans in a bag in the woods behind our house, along the path we took to school. I'd change before I even left the neighborhood.

For some reason, I became the chosen one for her trendy outfit modeling. A few years earlier, around 1968, she made me wear Nehru shirts because that's what the Beatles were wearing at the time. I had a green one and a blue one, ensuring I could be humiliated twice as often. Out of a school of hundreds of students, I was the only one wearing them.

Combine that with cheap black plastic-framed glasses—which were occasionally broken and then repaired with thick white tape in classic nerd style—and it's easy to see why I got my ass kicked almost daily.

To make matters much worse, the boys all got brush cuts at the end of the school year so we could look like idiots for the entire summer, while my poor sister got a "pixie cut" to look like a boy. Number of other kids at summer camp or in the neighborhood with brush cuts? Zero. Thankfully, the forced haircuts stopped around age twelve, along with the physical abuse - those turned into being grounded for weeks, which really drove me crazy, and was the catalyst for most of the times I took off, at that point.

Our childhood was essentially just one humiliation after another, day after day, year after year. Like most kids, we just wanted to fit in and not be singled out as different. Somehow, my mother never got that memo.

The Cool Mom

I started smoking pot around fourteen and a half. Oddly enough, before too long my mother seemed to have semi-accepted it. It was 1975, and smoking weed was all the rage, even for adults—or at least among the adults who wanted to be “hip,” like my mother.

I landed a part-time job after school and on weekends at the American Tourister luggage factory, working in the shipping department. One Friday afternoon during summer break, my friend Chris was supposed to borrow his mother’s new car - a Mustang II - so the two of us could take a weekend road trip to Cape Cod. I'd been looking forward to it all week. When my shift ended, I walked out to the lot looking for the Mustang, only to see my mother pulling up in the family station wagon instead. That wasn't a good sign.

"Chris called and said he couldn't get his mother's car," she said, when I got in the car. "I know you were really looking forward to this trip, but maybe this will help."

And she handed me a lit joint.

I was totally blown away—though I took the joint, of course. Inspired by the absurdity of the moment, I dug a brand-new “roach stone” out of my pocket—a small ceramic holder I’d bought at a head shop just the day before. The joint fit into a little hole in one end of the stone and you took a hit from the other, so you could smoke it down to nothing without burning your fingertips.

I didn’t know what to say except, “Thanks.” I fitted the joint into the stone, took a hit, and passed it back to her, giving her instructions on how to hold it. She took a hit, handed it back to me, and pulled away from the curb while my now-buzzing brain tried to process this whole crazy scene.

It was a surreal 10 minute drive home. Just before we reached our driveway, she pulled two more joints out of her large purse and handed

them over. "Here. Take these. But promise me you won't smoke them with your brothers or sister." I gladly took them and kept my word, which was easy since none of them smoked weed... yet. Mark used to say it was all in my head when I said I got high. Ironically, within a year or two, he became a daily smoker for the rest of his life, while I quit entirely when I was around 19.

Later that same summer, we were on a family vacation in Ogunquit, Maine. There were a few years in there when both my parents were working, and though they were still struggling financially, they somehow managed to afford a two-week vacation if they planned it carefully.

My father and the other kids had already headed out to the beach, but my mother asked me to stay behind at the motel because she needed a few more minutes to get ready. As I waited, she rummaged through her suitcase, tossing clothes aside, before finally asking, "Eric, have you seen my pot?" She asked it like this was the kind of thing we always talked about. She might as well have said, "Eric, have you seen my .357 Magnum?"

"Uh, no. I haven't seen your 'pot,'" I said, surprised once more by how casually we were talking about marijuana.

A minute later, she pulled a quart-sized Ziploc bag out from under her clothes with about a quarter-pound of weed inside. "Aha! Found it!" She gave me a triumphant look, packed it back into her suitcase, and we walked down to the beach. Just like that. No explanation.

And this time, no offering me any.

The third and last pot story happened during a family Labor Day weekend BBQ. My mother invited all of our relatives and their friends over to the house. There were about ten adults sitting in a circle on lawn chairs in the backyard, including my father, his brother, my mother's sister, and even my grandmother and great-grandmother. I was upstairs in my

bedroom with the window open, reading a book, when my mother called up to me from the lawn.

"Eric! Put your speakers in the window and put on your Black Sabbath album!"

Confused, but happy, I quickly put the speakers in the window and pushed in the 8-track. As Black Sabbath echoed across the backyard, I leaned out the window to see what the old folks thought. That's when I caught the sweet smell of burning weed. I looked around the circle of would-be hipsters and realized they were passing around a joint. My father. His brother. My mother's sister. Their friends. Everybody except my grandmother and great-grandmother were taking hits. These weren't hippies. They were ordinary, working-class New England adults. It was the first—and last—time I ever saw anything like it.

It was easy to look at moments like that and mistake my mother for someone progressive. Whenever I told people those stories, they'd say, "Wow... your mother sounds pretty cool." In some ways, she was.

In the ways that mattered most... ummm... not so much.

*

A few months later, my mother took us all to Lincoln Mall to do some Christmas shopping. I don't recall where my father was, but probably working, on the road, or at the bar. When we got home, I walked upstairs to my bedroom and found my new stereo destroyed. Someone had taken a full-sized wood-chopping axe to it. One swing split each speaker, carving deep gashes through the woofers. A few other whacks chopped into the top of the wooden cabinet, taking the entire top off. Amazingly, the electronics inside still worked, so I could at least listen to my music through headphones.

Nothing else in the house had been touched.

The few dollars in coins sitting on my shelf were still there.

Nothing was stolen.

It was a real head-scratcher. My mother came up with a theory that the grandson of our elderly neighbor had broken in - a guy I went to school with. According to her, it was revenge because a few of my friends had swiped a roll of dimes from the old man's kitchen table after finding his back door unlocked. I had been with them that day, but I stayed outside when they discovered the back door of the old guy's house was unlocked, and just waltzed right on in, like they owned the place. I didn't even know they'd taken the dimes until later. When I found out, I tracked down the guy who had them, got them back, and personally returned them to the neighbor. Still, I got some of the blame because they were my friends and I'd technically been there. Luckily, the police never got involved because the money was returned.

It wasn't until more than ten years later that my brother Mark finally enlightened me over a beer.

"I'm the one who took the axe to your stereo," he said, completely blowing my mind.

"But... Why?" was all I could come up with.

"Mom sent me home to do it, under some pretext about running an errand for her, while we were all at Lincoln Mall that day Christmas shopping." He then told me about it being some sort of "lesson" about breaking and entering people's houses - like I was a budding career criminal doing these every week, or something, and disregarding the fact that I had no idea anything had been stolen and that there was no "breaking in" involved and that I didn't even go in the house and even objected to these guys even doing it when they did. But when they came out within a minute, empty handed, I figured no harm, no foul.

So. I was pretty shocked on a few fronts there. One, that my mother conspired with my brother to do this; and two, that he not only did it, but kept it a secret for 15 years.

Who does something like this to prove some point that didn't need proving?

Life On The Run

My mother's need to control us didn't stop at home. It followed us to school and onto the playground, where the four Lynch kids were known as a group long before anyone got to know us individually. Between the clothes, the haircuts, and everything else, it was hard to be seen as anything other than one of the Lynch kids. Getting beat up almost every day, either at home, on the way to school, at school, on the way home, or at the park right behind our house... didn't help.

I couldn't help wondering if there was something wrong with me. I was just a regular kid. Granted, a regular kid who wore thick black-framed glasses, had a brush cut every summer, and sometimes wore funny clothes—but none of those were my choice.

Over the years leading up to the day I left home for good, I stayed away for increasingly longer stretches. First it was days. Then weeks. Finally, when I was sixteen, the days on the run added up to months. Oddly enough, I still attended school as much as I could. During one stint, I slept in the woods directly behind the school for two weeks. I kept my sleeping bag hidden there, packed with toiletries, snacks, and even my learner's permit / temporary drivers license, until someone eventually found my stash and took the whole kit and kaboodle. It still amazes me that my mother never thought to check with the school to see if I was attending classes. Every day I expected the police to walk into class and drag me out in front of everyone. I was hiding in plain sight.

I slept in old school buses, burnt-out buildings, up in the rafters of my parents' garage, and in the bed of an old truck parked next door. I slept in houses under construction, abandoned cars and old school buses, and just about anywhere I could find with a roof over it.

For a while, I stayed in a garden shed behind a friend's house, curled up next to the lawnmower while the heavy fumes of oil, gasoline, turpentine, and freshly mown grass lulled me to sleep. Another time, I

slept in a sleeping bag behind my friend Danny's couch. He lived with his divorced father in an apartment in an old tenement building. The beat-up, unused couch was in a spare bedroom with a bunch of junk in it. The couch was covered with a thick sheet of opaque plastic, and the room smelled like old cardboard boxes and dust. I would have dinner with him and his father and hang out for the evening. Then, right after the father went to bed, I'd pretend to leave—loudly calling out goodbye to my friend, then opening and shutting the front door loud enough to be heard—before quietly sneaking back across the kitchen linoleum and into the back bedroom. His father left for work long before I had to get ready for school, so I could safely shower, grab a quick bite to eat, and get dressed.

I'd lie there all night listening to the refrigerator cycling on and off in the kitchen, barely getting any sleep. After about two weeks, his father found my sleeping bag behind the couch, and I was back on the move.

During a brutal winter cold snap, I spent two weeks sleeping inside a metal Salvation Army box. Back then, the donation bins just had an open square slot in the side, protected by a curved metal hood to keep out the rain. There was no pull-down receiver to take your bags and boxes and slide them in for you when you shut it. Squeezing my way into that curved snout at two in the morning was tight - and risky; the bin sat on the edge of a brightly lit parking lot, completely exposed to the main road just fifty feet away. There was nothing to hide me from a passing police cruiser or even an observant driver.

Once I was inside, there was a not-unpleasant odor of different laundry detergents, plastic trash bags, and cardboard boxes. I could also easily hear the few cars on the road that passed by.

However, it was quite dark inside, so it was a matter of blindly feeling my way around, opening bags, feeling around for something that felt like a good candidate for warmth. I was able to pull out enough clothes to bury myself under and ended up surprisingly warm and relatively

comfortable. In fact, it was probably the most comfortable place I'd ever slept in while on the run.

Having said that, I barely slept in these makeshift beds, and that metal box was no different. But at least I was warm.

*

What I wanted more than anything else was freedom. Freedom from my parents. Freedom from constantly looking over my shoulder for the police. Freedom from literally running away from both. I wanted the chance to build a life of my own. It would be easy to say I was naive, but I wasn't. I just felt like I could make it on my own.

I also wanted to leave behind the identity other people had built for me. Even though I was past most of that by the time I turned 16, I still carried some of the baggage with me. I liked the idea of a fresh start in a place where nobody knew my name. The problem was, I had to evade the police and my parents for over two years still, until I turned 18 and became a legal adult. Only then could I go wherever I wanted and do whatever I pleased, without answering to anyone except maybe an employer. And if I didn't like the job, I could just quit, knowing that nobody had the legal right to drag me to a jail cell or back to my parents' house—which, to me, was the same thing.

One thing I did know: there was no way in hell I was going back.

Mom's Back Story

My mother's own childhood turned out to be far stranger than I ever imagined—especially considering I didn't come to discover the details of it until I was in my late twenties. Growing up, I always wondered—but for some reason, never thought to ask—why she called my great-grandmother “Mom” and her actual mother “Martha.” It never occurred to me that she spent her entire childhood believing her mother was her sister and her grandmother was her mother!

When I first learned that, my knee-jerk reaction was, “That's crazy talk. No way that's tr—oh...” Suddenly, it all made sense.

Back then, it wasn't unheard of for a family to hide an unmarried daughter's pregnancy. In my grandmother's case, she was only sixteen. She was sent off to stay with a distant relative, supposedly for school or health reasons, while my great-grandmother told the neighbors that she was the one expecting. Maybe my great-grandmother even stuffed a pillow under her dress toward the end. I have no idea how they pulled it off, but before long, my grandmother returned home with her new “sister.”

As I recall, my mother didn't discover the truth until she was about fifteen years old. By then, of course, that was just her reality. She'd spent her entire childhood thinking her mother was her sister. The two remained close for the rest of their lives, more like sisters than mother and daughter. Go figure.

My grandmother married ten years later, but not to my mother's biological father, who was several years older than she was and had long since disappeared from the picture. Eventually, my mother did meet him once or twice in adulthood. Neither my mother nor my grandmother ever seemed particularly angry with him, but I've always suspected there was far more to that story than anyone was willing to talk about. It's still a mystery to me.

With her new husband, my grandmother soon had another daughter, my mother's half-sister, who was ten years younger than my mother. Six and seven years later, my grandmother then had two sons, Tim and Francis. Because they were just two and three years older than I was, they felt much more like brothers to me than uncles. Tim was only two years older than me, but somehow those two years put us on opposite sides of a generational line. He was just old enough to catch the tail end of the hippie movement. I grew up in whatever came just after it, though I still had one foot in the hippie camp and one foot out.

*

My grandfather—or, technically, my step-grandfather—was a no-nonsense, zero-fun old man. When we went to visit in the summer, he could often be found in the driver's seat of his Honda Civic, seat all the way back, listening to the baseball game on the radio—or taking a nap. He had zero interest in the four of us kids, which seemed odd, given his own two sons were just a few years older than us.

He was a plumber by trade, but he also owned ten acres of land. He grew sweet corn on four acres and all kinds of vegetables on another quarter acre. The rest of the land was just a forest of old-growth pine trees. He also kept chickens in a coop behind the house. Needless to say, we ate a lot of fresh vegetables, eggs, and corn during harvest season.

I remember walking out into those towering green corn stalks, snapping the ears of corn off and carrying them back to the house for dinner. Or picking a big, ripe tomato off the vine, rinsing it with a garden hose, and eating it like an apple, shaking a little salt onto it after every few bites. There was nothing like tomatoes fresh off the vine. Damned good.

*

My mother was sent to a Catholic girls' boarding school for first grade and remained there throughout high school. I always suspected her stepfather had everything to do with that.

When most of the other girls went home for the summer, she was one of the unlucky few who stayed behind. She did get away for some weekends and occasional trips, so it wasn't like it was a prison, but... it wasn't home.

Summers were lonely, with only a few other girls stuck there with her. She spent her time reading or going to the movies with the other girls. But she was bitter that her "parents" would just leave her there. Her younger sister, luckily, never ended up in a boarding school.

Every day was a steady diet of Catholic doctrine. Church three times a day, plus catechism classes during the school year.

Habits, and Bibles, and Sins, oh my!!

Whatever else I might say about my mother, she was very smart and very driven, graduating Valedictorian of her class. She also came away with a lifelong disdain for organized religion and never went to church services again after graduating. Oddly, though, she felt the need to give her kids some grounding in religion and would suit us up in our little Sunday church suits, give us 35 cents for the basket, and send us two blocks down the street to Our Lady Queen of Martyrs Church for some good old-fashioned indoctrination. Neither of my parents went, except to watch us all make our First Communion. As I recall, I was forced to go to the prep classes for this with Mark because, well... diabetes. My job from the age of five was to be his human Life Alert device, of sorts.

Since we were all hopelessly sugar-deprived as kids, thirty-five cents for "the basket" was way too valuable to give away to some stupid church when it could be used to actually *buy* candy instead of stealing it. So I started dropping the coins in the basket and then taking out "change," usually about 75 cents to a dollar in coins. The basket passers never caught on. It was my first entry into a life of crime. I figured the Church wasn't exactly hurting for money.

Our Catholic indoctrination came to an end once Mark and I started Confirmation classes. This is a Catholic milestone you do when you're 15 or 16, and you pick a middle name. Blah blah blah. Mark got thrown out of class. I don't recall why. I had run away after the first few weeks of these classes and was happy to miss them. When I was eventually caught and dragged home, I wasn't about to start the classes over again, and I'd be gone for good before the next ones started.

*

My relationship with my mother was always complicated. There were things about her I genuinely admired. She was an attractive woman, even though she struggled with her weight her entire life. She'd lose fifty pounds, gain sixty back, then go on another diet and do it all over again. The whole yo-yo thing. She had a great artistic eye, and knew how to work a room. She was involved in various ways in the women's movement and became president of the local chapter of the National Association of Women Business Owners back in the 70s. She was a great public speaker, worked hard, and took absolutely no crap from anyone. She was the undisputed Queen Bee of our extended family.

She loved her kids... but perhaps a bit too much—a polite way of saying “narcissistically controlling.” She took a real interest in our studies and our lives, but everything ultimately had to be done her way, and once she'd made up her mind about something, there was no changing it. She also had a sharp sense of humor, though she tended to laugh harder and longer at her own jokes than anyone else did. We always felt obligated to laugh along with her, just to stay on her good side.

*

One evening at dinner, when my siblings and I were all between the ages of eight and eleven, the subject of raising families came up. My mother looked across the table and said casually:

"You know, if I had to do it all over again, I wouldn't have had kids. No offense to you guys. You know I love you. But I would have enjoyed a completely different life without the endless responsibilities, and all. It hasn't always been easy."

I'd say it had *never* been easy, but OK.

Whenever I tell people this story today—especially women—they're usually horrified that a mother would say something like that to her young children. Yet, sitting there at the dinner table, I instantly got it. She wasn't angry or trying to hurt us; she said it like she was simply just stating a fact.

"I don't blame you!" I remember saying. And I really meant it. I got it. It all made perfect sense.

What she said that night stuck with me, and I eventually came to exactly the same conclusion about my own life. I never had children because I looked at the reality of parenthood and knew I didn't want that kind of responsibility.

In the end, I didn't even want the responsibility of owning a dog, let alone raising children. Oddly enough, I actually love both kids and dogs, and for some reason, they tend to like me, too. I like that what you see is pretty much what you get with both of them. They just want your attention. Dogs, of course, primarily want you to hand over food—which drives me a little crazy—but when meals are out of the picture, they are great companions.

Every woman I've ever been with has eventually told me the exact same thing: "You'd be a great dad!" I probably would have been. But it wasn't a lifestyle I wanted full-time. You can't send them back if you get sick of them. And you can't send them back if you just... don't like them.

My Father

My father's father owned the city dump. Literally. In those days, it was basically a recycling center, taking in nothing but metal, cardboard, and paper to sell as scrap. My father and his brother quickly realized they preferred making money over sitting in a classroom. Neither was stupid; they just had no interest in college. Or high school, for that matter. The money, apparently, was decent. My father—tall, dark hair, and considered handsome—drove a brand-new car every year or two.

Eventually, he fell for my mother, and the two of them had a pretty good time together—at least until the children arrived to spoil the party. They both raced stock cars in the Stock Car Racing Club of America and won seventeen trophies between them. My mother, it turned out, won just over half of them—including the biggest one. I remember hearing stories about 1950's beach barbecues, big parties, and a tight circle of friends whose names I never knew or have long since forgotten.

Surprise Baby Number One wasn't planned, and I don't think she was particularly happy about it, though she accepted it. At the time, she was attending the Rhode Island School of Design and had real artistic talent. Graduating would have to wait.

That first baby was my brother, Mark. Nine months after he was born, I arrived—ten weeks premature—though I was, apparently, "planned." A year after that, my sister came along as Surprise Baby Number Two. After my sister was born, doctors told my mother she couldn't have any more children, which suited her just fine. Then, a year later, my younger brother Alex was born as Surprise Baby Number Three. Oops.

After Alex, my mother finally opted for a hysterectomy, putting an end to the surprise babies.

By the time there were four kids in the house, my father was drinking heavily, while my mother was overwhelmed and constantly after him to help with the kid-chaos. My earliest memories are of him tentatively

walking through the front door drunk. He'd take about half a second to gauge my mother's mood, then I'd watch him jam into the bathroom real quick, shutting the door behind him just in time for an airborne dinner plate to shatter against it. Huge fights. Lots of drama. She always did most, if not all, of the yelling.

The kids all shared one bedroom—triple bunks for the boys and a single twin for my sister. I slept on the top bunk, and one night I somehow rolled off it in my sleep. It was a long way down to the hardwood floor, and it hurt like hell. My father heard the crash and came running in, picked five-year-old me up, and asked where it hurt.

"All over," I groaned.

He chuckled and gently lifted me back onto my bunk. It's a little sad that this stands out as one of the few real father-and-son moments we ever shared. There was also the time he taught me how to ride a bike.

*

My mother was miserable being stuck at home with four children while Dad spent his evenings at the local bar. Over the years, she said more than once that she should have married a doctor—or at least someone more in her intellectual league—but for whatever reason, she stayed.

Divorce certainly came up during their many arguments, and on more than one occasion, my father would just disappear for a few days, staying at his mother's house just a few blocks away.

For all the neutral-to-bad things I could say about his parenting, I never doubted how much he loved... my mother. Which was cool. I respect that.

But for reasons I'll never fully understand, he put up with an awful lot of yelling and verbal abuse without ever giving up on her. He took far more than he deserved from her, and I have no doubt he would have taken a bullet for her.

At the dinner table, my father was usually just a passive presence. He was there, but most of the time he might as well not have been, with one or two notable exceptions.

Still, I loved him.

He was my hero in the way little boys tend to view their fathers—a tall, quiet, genuinely manly guy. I very much respected him... but I was also a little afraid of him.

I never viewed him as some submissive, wimpy guy. He wasn't. He was strong, but when it came to my mother, he usually just gave in. He seemed willing to do almost anything to avoid an argument with her. I've sometimes wondered if watching that happen over and over is where my sensitivity to unfairness came from. I don't have a problem with authority, per se. If a police officer asks for my license or a boss tells me to do something at work, that's just life. What I can't tolerate is being treated with contempt or condescension. And I despise bullies and tyrants.

*

Probably my best memory of my father was when I was fourteen and he took me with him to Cape Cod on a work trip. He drove a big delivery van for a company called New Era, restocking gardening supplies at stores throughout New England.

It was just him and me—a first and a last, come to think of it. Just a father and one of his three sons. The drive to the Cape took about two and a half hours through a cold moonless night, with the AM radio playing music and news. I remember the low drone of the engine, the glow of the dashboard, and the lights of strip malls, old motels, and tourist billboards passing by outside.

We spent the hours driving talking about all kinds of things. I learned little bits about his life before my mother, things I'd never known about him. He wasn't a talkative man, so having him open up to me like that felt

special. It was a side of him I'd never seen before. Away from my mother and the rest of the family, he just seemed more relaxed. A lot more relaxed.

We stayed the night at a Howard Johnson's Motel, and ate at the attached restaurant the next morning. It was a special sort-of treat, to me. It was a father-son bonding sort of thing.

Many years later, just a few years before he died, I told him how much that trip had meant to me. I'll never forget his response.

"Hmm. I don't remember that."

I didn't know what to say, so I didn't say anything.

But... it hurt a bit. Maybe a bit more than a bit.

There is another memory of my father from around that same time. Except this one isn't mine.

My younger brother Alex was about twelve when one of the worst incidents with my father happened. I was home that night, upstairs in bed, and didn't witness it myself.

By then, we kids slept upstairs in what had originally been a separate apartment where my great-grandmother—Nana—had lived for several years.

It was late, and we'd all gone to bed. My father came home drunk, which was hardly unusual, and yelled for Alex to come downstairs.

Alex came down through the sunroom and closed the door behind him. My father was standing in my parents' bedroom doorway, across the landing at the top of the stairs leading down to the kitchen.

He didn't say anything. He just stepped across the landing and punched Alex in the side of the head, the force of the punch knocking him down the stairs.

As far as I know, it was the first time my father had ever punched one of us. We'd been hit with the belt plenty of times. He'd also picked me up and thrown me against a wall once. But this was different. This wasn't punishment, even by the standards we'd grown up with. He was a grown man beating up an eleven-year-old kid with his fists.

Alex remembers getting up at the bottom and standing there crying. His nose was bleeding, and a large bruise was already forming on his cheek and the side of his head.

My father followed him down the stairs and came after him again.

"What are you crying for?" he said. "You wanna cry? I'll give you something to cry about!"

Alex remembers being slapped, punched, and thrown around the room. He doesn't know how many times my father hit him, only that it was a lot. By the time it was over, he was bleeding and hurting pretty much everywhere.

Only then did my father tell him why he'd done it.

"Do you know why I did this? Because you called your sister a queer."

That was it.

Alex had apparently called Leslie a "queer." Not in the gay or lesbian sense of the word. Back then, it was just another insult kids threw at each other. Leslie had told my father about it, and this was his response.

I have a vague memory of hearing some commotion two floors down. I don't remember going downstairs. Knowing us—and knowing my father when he was drunk—I doubt any of us would have risked going down and ending up on the receiving end ourselves.

I can't say exactly when this happened, but Alex was around twelve. I was around fourteen—the same age I was when my father took me to Cape Cod.

For me, he created one of the few memories of him that I would carry with me for the rest of my life.

For Alex, he created a far different one.

Mark

I believe Mark was in kindergarten when he was diagnosed with Type I diabetes. About a year after that, I found out I needed glasses, apparently another consequence of being born ten weeks premature. And pretty badly, as it turned out. It's funny how, as a kid, you just assume everyone sees the same world you do. Until someone puts a pair of glasses on you, you have no idea what you've been missing.

I first realized something was wrong in the first grade. The chalkboard was a total blur, and I'd have to get out of my chair and quietly creep forward several desks just to read what was on it. Miss Quinn—my teacher, who looked exactly like Aunt Bee from *The Andy Griffith Show*—spotted my strange movements pretty quickly. Off to the eye doctor I went.

We didn't have money to waste, so I got the nerdiest, cheapest black plastic frames available. I am surprised they didn't just give them away for free. I had no say in the matter.

So Mark stood out for one reason, and I stood out for another.

I was pushed into school a year early so I could walk the mile-and-a-half route with Mark, basically serving as his little walking Life Alert in case he had a diabetic reaction. By the second grade, we were getting beaten up almost every single day on the walk to and from school. Mark was targeted for being different, and my cheap, taped-up glasses made me an obvious second choice for whoever was beating him up. And there were always at least two of them. Every punch to the face meant another crack in my plastic frames, leaving me to stumble around in a blur until they were taped back together again.

It wasn't until decades later, sitting in a therapist's office, that the obvious finally hit me. Because I'd started school a year early, I was literally a year smaller, scrawnier, and younger than everyone in the room.

To make matters worse, most of the neighborhood bullies were another year or two older than that.

My mother also insisted that all four of us hang out together everywhere we went. My last name back then was Lynch—I would legally change it to Ryder twenty years later—so the local kids dubbed us "The Lynch Mob." Throw in the summertime brush cuts, and we didn't stand a chance.

Walking to and from school became a daily gauntlet. I could feel my stomach tighten the moment we left the driveway. We were always looking over our shoulders, checking behind trees and around corners, wondering who might be waiting for us that day.

*

Most of the punches I took from other kids started with Mark. He was my older brother, and he was gay—though I think I instinctively knew that long before I even knew the meaning of the word "gay." He was clearly *different*.

Because we were forced into the same grade, the neighborhood mistakenly assumed we were fraternal twins. He also never knew when to keep his mouth shut around the older, tougher boys. He'd mouth off, the situation would instantly escalate, and we'd both pay the price. And while Mark was being bullied by other kids, he was also a bully himself—at least to his siblings. He tormented the rest of us whenever our parents weren't looking.

I grew to hate him almost as much as I did my mother. People might think hate is too strong a word, but they didn't grow up in that house.

It felt like I spent most of my childhood getting hit by somebody—at home, at school, or down at the neighborhood park. My mother was the main disciplinarian simply because she was with us the most. I don't remember every incident, of course. There are things my sister has

reminded me of over the years that I didn't remember at all, and I'm sure there is much more that I blocked out.

But I do remember a few terrifying moments with my father. I'll never forget the time he grabbed me and threw me against the kitchen wall. My head slammed into the sheetrock, leaving a half-dollar-sized dent just an inch or two from the corner of the wooden windowsill. An impact on the corner of that windowsill with the back of my head could have killed me—and I think he knew it. His anger disappeared immediately. Ironically, a few seconds later, he discovered I'd been totally innocent of whatever he thought I'd done.

*

When I was ten or eleven, we were playing Monopoly in a dusty, unused workshop in the backyard, which came with the house when my parents bought it in 1967 (for \$19,000). Mark accused me several times of cheating and stealing money from the bank—which wasn't true. Finally, I snapped and lunged across the board, sending property cards and little plastic houses flying everywhere, landed squarely on top of him, and started punching him in the face. I landed three solid punches before I suddenly realized what I was doing. Because he was "diabetic" and I was too young to fully understand what all that meant, I was terrified I might actually kill him. I stopped, scrambled off him, and ran out of the workshop.

He chased after me, and I deliberately let him catch me. I let him land a few punches and pretended they hurt a lot more than they actually did, just to give him the satisfaction. It was a strange thing to do, but I think I needed to restore the natural order of things. Mark was the older brother. In kid logic, apparently, he was supposed to beat me up, not the other way around.

Vietnam

I was lucky enough to come of age just after the Vietnam War and the draft were over. I was fifteen when the war finally ended in 1975, but for several years before that, I was already planning my escape to Canada. There was absolutely no way I was going to be drafted and shipped halfway around the world to a jungle to be killed by strangers in a war that had nothing to do with me.

As far back as I can remember, dinner-table discussions, front-page newspaper headlines, and the CBS Evening News with Walter Cronkite were dominated by Vietnam. Every night on television there was the American body count. It really felt like the war would never end.

I remember being twelve years old, in the seventh grade. (Recall that I started school a year early, so I was a year younger than the normal seventh grader.) The school newspaper, which was written and printed by the ninth graders—fourteen- and fifteen-year-old kids—frequently carried stories about the war. In one issue, they printed a photo of American soldiers who had just taken out a North Vietnamese machine-gun nest. They were walking down a dirt road toward the photographer, big smiles on their faces. Each soldier held the severed head of a Vietnamese fighter by the hair. The dead faces were twisted into painful, rigid masks, with bloody veins hanging raggedly from their necks. Luckily, the student paper was printed in somewhat grainy black and white and not full-glossy color.

I couldn't believe a Catholic school, with kids as young as twelve, would print something that graphic in the school newspaper. Even more shocking were the smiles on the soldiers' faces. I remember wondering what a person had to go through to get to the point where they could do something like that and actually be proud of it.

The picture made me a little sick, but I'd be lying if I said I wasn't a little fascinated, too. For whatever reason, that image stuck with me. I can still see it clearly more than fifty years later.

Aline

By the time I hit fourteen, I had still never kissed a girl. I was in ninth grade and, a couple of years earlier, just before starting seventh grade, I'd finally used some of my paper route money to buy myself a pair of gold wire-frame glasses, ditching the nerdy black frames I'd been wearing since first grade. It was a marked improvement. I'd also started growing my hair out, and by then it was about shoulder length. Given that this was 1974, it was definitely in style.

I'm not sure how we met, but somehow I got to know a girl named Aline. Memorable for her unusual name, but even more for the scar she left on me.

Aline was cute, maybe 5'1" and thin, with long, straight blonde hair and flawless creamy-white skin. She was smart and a bit of a bookworm, a little eccentric, as I recall. She was in the band and played clarinet, and was also on the "Pep Squad," which was sort of drama class meets cheerleading. Something like that.

I walked her home from school one fall afternoon and she invited me in. We were alone, as her sister worked after school and her parents didn't get home from their jobs for another hour or two.

I only remember three little vignettes from that day, and not much about what happened before or after. I do have this sort of cinematic memory from around the same time of being in the school library with her, flirting around the ends of the bookshelves, slowly chasing each other from aisle to aisle.

The first memory is of the two of us in her somewhat dark living room, the sheer curtains of the front window letting in filtered late afternoon light. We were goofing around, and she had a wire hanger in her hand, laughing and using it like a sword to fend me off. At one point, she took a swing at me with it and the tip of the hook scraped across the top of my

right hand, drawing a few tiny droplets of blood and leaving an inch-long scrape.

That inch-long scrape left a white scar that was visible for decades. In fact, I can still see the faint white line today if I look closely enough.

The second vignette is from when it was time for me to leave. She walked me to the end of her driveway and jumped up on a foot-high stone wall separating the driveway from the front yard. Now she was my height.

It had all been very playful and physical, and here was the moment.

She stood there smiling at me. If she'd been holding two orange airport wands and waving me in, the signal couldn't have been much clearer.

I froze.

I liked her, but I was terrified I was reading it wrong. So I said an embarrassed goodnight, turned, and walked away.

The third vignette, of course, was kicking myself the entire two-mile walk home.

That was pretty much the end of that "relationship." I don't remember exactly how it ended; I think it just fizzled out soon after. But I still have that little scar on my hand, just in case I need a reminder of how stupid I was.

Friends?

The brutal truth is that until the tenth grade, I had no friends. Zero. There were acquaintances, I guess you could call them—relatives and friends of the family. But the reality was I was... lonely, but not alone. When I was seven or eight years old, I remember begging my mother to let me spend time with kids outside the family instead of always making me tag along with my siblings. It's a strangely mature thing for a seven-year-old to say, but I'll never forget the exact words I used: "It's killing me, socially."

She dismissed me with, "Don't be ridiculous."

To be fair, looking at my life from the outside, she probably thought I was doing just fine. Having no friends didn't mean I sat staring at a bedroom wall all day. I still had what looked like a pretty normal suburban childhood. I rode my bike all over town, went ice skating in the winter, and went to the neighborhood park with my siblings. I was in Cub Scouts and played Little League baseball. From the outside, I probably looked like any other kid. But through all of it, I was still the outsider.

In gym class, I was the kid picked dead last for every team. Part of that was simply my age. As I mentioned, I'd started school a year early and hadn't yet hit the growth spurts of the kids a year older than me. I also lacked the natural coordination my younger brother seemed to have in spades. But I eventually realized I wasn't quite as bad at sports as I thought. A lot of the problem was how I handled pressure. Turns out *choking* was not the ideal way to handle it.

Oddly enough, during casual practices or exhibition games in Little League, I was a completely different player. Away from the pressure, I actually played pretty well. Well... maybe not that well, but I was certainly much better. I was once called in to pitch halfway through an exhibition game against Cumberland, our biggest rival. Somehow, everything clicked. I struck out every single batter over the next five innings, and

when the game ended, my teammates literally carried me off the field on their shoulders. My coach was ecstatic. Apparently, he'd just discovered a pitching prodigy!

Then he put me on the mound in a game that actually counted.

I think my first pitch went so high it practically cleared the eight-foot high backstop. I completely choked. I lasted less than two innings before the coach yanked me.

My road to the Baseball Hall of Fame abruptly veered off course, smashed into a concrete bridge abutment, and burst into a huge fireball of disappointment.

*

I don't think any single childhood incident shaped who I would become. It was years of being treated as though I'd done something wrong, or that I was inferior in some way, when I hadn't and I wasn't.

I never actually believed there was anything *wrong* with me. What I couldn't understand was why everyone else seemed to think there was. Years of being judged and ridiculed still left their mark, though. One thing it left me with was a fear of public speaking, something I struggled with well into adulthood—after oddly choosing a profession that required me to do quite a bit of it.

I could speak reasonably well from behind a podium, and I had no problem talking while sitting around a large conference table. It was standing up in front of a room full of people, completely exposed, with nothing to hide behind, I suppose, that practically paralyzed me. I'd get through it, but it wasn't easy.

Naturally, in a stroke of pure career irony, I ended up spending years in corporate training, standing in front of classrooms teaching customers how to use our software products. Every Monday was day one of public-

speaking hell. By Friday I was fine, and by the next Monday, a fresh batch of strangers walked in and the dread reset to zero.

Then again, fear of public speaking is pretty common, so I probably wasn't alone in that.

Get Smart

Things, of course, began to change as I got older. Though I still carried the stigma of my grade school years, I slowly started to find my footing. It turned out I was, apparently, "smart." Who knew? I was as surprised as anyone.

This had started back in the seventh grade, when I was admitted to a private Catholic school. The following year, I was pulled out when my parents could no longer afford the tuition. Money problems were nothing new in our house; layoffs were a regular part of life. To get into the school in the first place, I had to take the National Educational Development Test (NEDT), a standardized test given to students across the country.

When the results came back, my parents and I were asked to return to the school after hours to meet with the admissions officer, a Catholic priest.

I remember that meeting vividly. It was a dark, crisp fall evening, around seven o'clock. After dinner, my parents and I got into the family station wagon and made the fifteen-minute drive to the school.

There was something strange and slightly eerie about walking into the school after dark. It was an old, three-story brick building, built in the late 1800s, and at night its Victorian design took on a different character. The halls were quiet and just a little spooky without the usual noise and commotion of students. A guy named Father Francis met us and led us into his office. I remember being impressed by the room: dark wood paneling, floor-to-ceiling bookcases, a massive desk, and a small sitting area. A Tiffany-style lamp on his desk provided most of the light.

I sat alone on a small love seat, facing my parents and Father Francis across a coffee table. Once we were settled, he handed copies of the test results to my parents and slid one over to me.

I looked down at the paper and saw the number 87.

I looked up, a little confused. An 87 was a pretty good grade, I supposed, but it hardly seemed worthy of all this serious nighttime attention.

Father Francis could see that I wasn't getting it, and he chuckled.

"You didn't score an 87," he explained. "You scored higher than 87 percent of the students who took the test nationwide. That's one of the strongest scores we've ever seen from a Mount St. Charles applicant."

My parents were beaming—something I wasn't exactly accustomed to.

"We'd be delighted to enroll you here at Mount Saint Charles."

Something about hearing that flipped a switch. I'd never thought of myself as stupid, but I'd never thought of myself as particularly smart, either. I guess I just figured I was pretty ordinary. Though, looking back, there had been clues. In fifth grade, for reasons I couldn't have told you at the time, I was put into advanced math. The same thing happened again in sixth grade.

But this was different. Someone had actually told me I was smart. From that point forward, I earned straight A's throughout junior high, high school, college courses I took, and even later in corporate training. Not long afterward, I took a formal IQ test and scored 143.

Ever since then, I've believed that if you tell a kid they're smart—and give them a reason to believe it—you just might change the way they see themselves. I don't know if I would have figured it out on my own eventually, but apparently that's what happened to me.

I'm not saying I suddenly became smart because someone told me I was. Whatever ability I had was already there. I just hadn't given it much thought.

*

The long and short of it was that I grew taller and discovered I was smarter than I'd thought. But I was hardly some nerdy whiz kid. I earned excellent grades, but I've never considered myself some kind of brainiac. I'm clearly not. I think a more accurate assessment is simply that I discovered I was "not an idiot."

Which is a comforting thing to know, right?

I also discovered that being funny was a pretty good way to fit in. I became something of a class clown, but my thing was subtle jokes, dry wit, and irony—the kind of humor that sometimes took half a second to register. I wasn't the kid making fart sounds or throwing paper airplanes when the teacher wasn't looking.

But despite the good grades and the laughs, I think I still carried a fair amount of insecurity and a need to be accepted. For much of my life, some part of me assumed people didn't really like me, even when I knew perfectly well that they did.

Which is probably why I've never forgotten something that happened at the end of a math class in the tenth grade.

The bell had rung, and everyone was shuffling out the door to their lockers. One of the guys in class, who had sometimes joined in when the other kids beat me up years earlier, suddenly turned around and held out his hand.

"Hey, I'm sorry for all the times I beat you up when we were younger," he said. "You're a cool guy."

It was a little thing, but I've never forgotten it. Someone who had once helped make my life miserable was now telling me I was a cool guy.

Go figure.

Power Shift

By the end of tenth grade and through the summer, I was hanging out with a guy named Marc—with a “c.” Unlike most of the people I'd hung around with before, Marc actually felt like a real friend. The first time I got high was at Rocky Point Amusement Park, sitting in Marc's VW Bug. Outside, the air smelled like fried food and the ocean. Inside, it was nothing but pot smoke. If we'd opened the windows, the car would have looked like it was on fire. I loved it! I used to tell people I'd smoke pot until I was ninety-five. As it turned out, I quit well before that, after seriously overdoing it for the next several years.

*

Later that summer, while I was on the run, I snuck back into the house to grab some clothes. I climbed the stairs, not realizing Mark was home. His bedroom door was open, and as I reached the top landing, I saw him standing beside his bed. He must have heard me coming.

"You're not supposed to be here," he said.

"I'm just here to grab some clothes, and then I'm leaving," I replied.

His face immediately turned red, and he took a step toward me.

"Get out. Now."

I was slightly hungover, already pissed off, and in no mood for this, but I kept my cool as best I could.

"If you move one inch closer, I swear to God I'll throw you right through that fucking window."

He stopped.

We stood there looking at each other for a few seconds. For the first time in our lives, I don't think he saw me as his little brother anymore. He knew I meant it. Besides, I was taller than him now.

I walked into my bedroom, grabbed a few clothes and a couple of books, then went back down the stairs and out the front door.

I spent that night and the next few days wandering around town, ducking every police car I saw, before eventually making my way back to another new friend's house, Chris. I'd stayed there several nights before, telling his parents mine had said it was okay. To make it convincing, I'd even pretend to call home from their kitchen phone.

"Hi, Mom... yeah, I'm at Chris's house. They invited me to stay over tonight. Is that okay?"

I'd wait a few seconds.

"Okay. Thanks! I'll see you tomorrow."

Chris's parents didn't catch on right away. I got away with it several times before his mother finally grew suspicious and insisted on speaking to one of my parents. Cornered, I admitted I'd run away. I begged her not to call home, and she reluctantly agreed—but on one condition: she was driving me home immediately.

On the drive home, around nine that night, she couldn't have been nicer. She tried to reason with me, explaining how worried my parents must have been. I nodded along, playing the part of the agreeable, reformed teenager. She actually made a few good points, and I promised I'd give everything she'd said some serious thought.

We pulled up in front of my house. I thanked her for taking me in over the past few days and promised I'd try to work things out with my mother. I got out, shut the car door, and started up the driveway toward the house.

I turned back to watch her taillights as they disappeared around the corner, then immediately took off down the street to Park Avenue, and stuck out my thumb.

Remarkably, someone picked me up and I actually made it back to Chris's house before his mother did. I slipped into the backyard and

knocked on his bedroom window. A minute later, he opened it and looked down at me.

"What are you doing back here?" he said, laughing. "You can't sleep here. We'll get caught! Sorry, man."

I laughed. "Well, I didn't really know where else to go, but I understand. I'll figure something out."

I guess asking him to harbor a fugitive twice in one night was pushing my luck.

*

I wandered around the dark neighborhood looking for somewhere to sleep and eventually came across a house under construction. It was a two-story stick frame, partially sided but still wide open in places. Sitting inside was a brand-new white bathtub, apparently delivered a little ahead of schedule.

That bathtub became my (very uncomfortable) bed for the night—and for the next few nights.

*

The following evening, I went with Marc to another school friend's house. Her name was Judy, and she lived in Chris's neighborhood, not far from my new bathtub. There were just four of us in her parents' garage, sitting on folding chairs around a camping lantern perched on top of a dark blue plastic milk crate, drinking cheap Miller High Life. Nobody had any weed.

I was only two beers into the night when Marc looked over at me.

"What's it really like at your house?" he asked, very seriously. "Why do you keep running away?"

He wasn't judging me. He just seemed to genuinely care. The question—and the way he asked it—took me by surprise, for some reason, and...

Everything seemed to bubble up in me. The injustice. The pain. The humiliation. I couldn't put it into words, I suppose, and within a few seconds I just... started crying. And I couldn't stop.

I end up a heaving, sobbing mess for the next minute or so, my face buried in my hands. Everything I'd been holding in for years seemed to come out at once. Nobody had ever asked me that before. Nobody, including my own family, had ever cared enough to want to know *why*.

Of course, I was mortified that I had let down my guard like that. I stood up to leave, mostly because I was embarrassed. Marc got up immediately and steadied me. I honestly felt like I'd downed twelve beers instead of just two, and I staggered as he helped me out to his car.

By the time we reached the street, I'd pulled myself together a little, but I was still embarrassed. I didn't feel like getting in the car, so we leaned against the fender for a while, breathing in the crisp night air without saying much. Marc was very cool about it. He didn't press me for details or make a big deal out of what had just happened. I thanked him, told him I had a safe place to crash for the night, and walked the few dark blocks back to my bathtub.

*

By the following summer, I'd been back home for a while when the telephone rang. It was Mark. He had a summer job at a supermarket in Hyannisport, on Cape Cod, about two hours away. To my surprise, he sounded friendly. Ever since our confrontation in his bedroom, something between us had changed. We still had our issues- mostly that he was an asshole and I wasn't- but we were getting along noticeably better.

"The carnival at Our Lady Queen of Martyrs starts this weekend," he said. "Can you go down and buy me a book of raffle tickets? I'll pay you back when I get home in a few weeks."

The church we used to go to held a summer carnival every year, and it was a pretty big deal. For one weekend, the parking lot transformed into a little amusement park with a Ferris wheel, the Roundabout, spinning teacups, and all the usual carnival games. There were booths where you popped balloons with darts, knocked over milk bottles, or tossed wooden rings over Coke bottles to win stuffed animals. Floating above it all was the unmistakable smell of cotton candy, popcorn, and corn dogs.

The biggest attraction was a daredevil motorcycle rider who raced around the vertical walls of a giant wooden cylinder, somehow defying gravity while standing on the seat. As kids, we thought it was the coolest thing we'd ever seen.

In the weeks leading up to the carnival, a flatbed truck would cruise through the city neighborhoods carrying giant painted signs advertising the event while clowns tossed handfuls of candy to kids along the sidewalks. It was the good candy, too—a far cry from the hard-candy "meals" my mother had subjected us to years earlier.

That Saturday, I walked the mile down to the church grounds and dutifully bought two ten-dollar books of raffle tickets, five tickets to a book—one for Mark and one for me.

To my chagrin, he actually won the car. Of the two books, I happened to put Mark's name on the winning one. It was nothing more than a fifty-fifty coin flip. If I'd assigned the books the other way around, I'd have won instead. Of course, if I'd been dishonest, I could have put my own name on all ten tickets and Mark would never have known, doubling my odds of winning the car. But the thought never occurred to me. Surprisingly.

Mark was thrilled, though he never actually drove away in the grand prize—a brand-new 1976 Buick Skylark. To take possession of the car, he would have had to come up with nearly nine hundred dollars for taxes and registration, money he just didn't have. Fortunately, the church offered a

cash alternative. After taxes were withheld, he walked away with a check for \$3,600—plenty to buy a decent used car.

He ended up buying a 1970 Ford Fairlane convertible, brown with a cream-colored vinyl top. It was a nice-looking car in pristine condition, but it quickly turned into a money pit. Something was always breaking, and before long it seemed to spend more time in the shop than it did on the road.

When he got the check, he promised me a hundred-dollar consolation prize, as it were, though I never saw it. In fact, he never even paid me back the original ten dollars he owed me for the raffle tickets...

Mark and I actually got along much better once I wasn't living at home. Whatever hostility we'd had as kids seemed to fade as we got older and started living separate lives. With some distance, I also began to see our childhood differently. Mark had made plenty of my life miserable, but he'd grown up in the same house I had. He hadn't always escaped our mother's punishments, either. All four of us had been through our own version of the same shitty childhood.

Over the years, the car raffle story became a running joke between us. Whenever I told the story in his presence, I'd remind him, "And you never even gave me the ten bucks for the tickets!" He'd just laugh. By then, of course, I never seriously expected—or wanted—to see the ten dollars, never mind the extra hundred.

Nothing But Trouble

By the eleventh and twelfth grades, I had fallen in with the partying crowd. I let my hair grow long and started dealing a little weed, mostly to make pocket money for snacks, cheap alcohol, and more weed. It was a decidedly small-time operation: I would buy an ounce for forty bucks, roll sixty joints from it, and sell them for a dollar apiece at school. I also made a few lifelong friends during that era—including one I still hang out with more than fifty years later.

Around that time, I started getting into serious trouble with the law. I was hanging out with a group of idiots who did things like break into people's houses in broad daylight. I went along a few times, which was stupid enough on its own. I didn't plan the break-ins or steal anything myself, but I was there, and that was bad enough.

That became something of a pattern for the next few years. I was mostly just going along for the ride, hanging around people I had very little in common with and getting swept into whatever they happened to be doing.

*

One afternoon, after breaking into a suburban house in broad daylight, our unofficial leader, Ray—the oldest of the four of us—casually started going through the homeowners' kitchen cupboards.

"Ugh, I'm starving," he said. "Let's see what they've got in the fridge."

I was nervous as hell, given the homeowner could have walked through the front door at any second, but Ray didn't seem particularly concerned. He pulled out lunch meat, cheese, mustard, and bread... and made himself lunch. Unbelievable.

After we finally bailed out of that house—carrying nothing but a stolen blank checkbook and a heavy bag full of quarters—we ran straight down to the nearby railroad tracks. The grand plan was to hop onto a moving

train, ride it into Providence for the afternoon, and take the bus back home after "rolling a drunk" in the park outside the transit station. You know—a perfectly normal thing for kids to do during school hours.

This was a routine the other guys had pulled off before. They knew exactly when and where to go because they knew that this particular local drunk would have just received his monthly Social Security check that day.

We followed the tracks for a short distance before Jimmy suddenly yelled, "TRAIN!"

We scrambled off the tracks and into the tall weeds that ran alongside. The train wasn't moving very fast because it had just left the Woonsocket station, so we were able to run alongside it, grab onto a steel ladder, and haul ourselves into an open boxcar. I felt like an authentic Depression-era hobo. Who knew you could actually do something like this? I couldn't believe all four of us made it.

When we arrived in Providence about half an hour later, Jimmy and John headed off to find their mark in the park across from the station. Ray, meanwhile, had spotted two girls across the plaza.

"Hey, hey! How you girls doing?" Ray called out, stepping into their path. "You must be bored and looking for some entertainment, am I right? You want to smoke a joint?" It was the surefire, universal opener for all occasions in the 1970s.

The girls were every bit as classy as Ray, with his long, straight brown hair, cheap brown leather jacket, and a paunch more befitting a middle-aged man. I wasn't exactly thrilled with the girl I was left with after Ray took his pick, but I went along. He led all four of us upstairs into an abandoned section of a building next to the train station. The place was filthy, dark, and covered in cobwebs. Apparently, Ray knew exactly where he was going.

Outside, it was a beautiful early summer afternoon. The sun was shining, birds were singing, and the scent of flowers filled the air. It was a perfect day for love—or whatever version of it this was supposed to be. It certainly wasn't love for me.

The upper floor overlooked the tracks and appeared to have once been part of the station—or maybe an old block of apartments connected to it. A few of the rooms contained bare mattresses on rusted steel frames, surrounded by chunks of sheetrock, battered filing cabinets, broken office chairs, and empty pizza boxes. I'm surprised Ray didn't contract some horrible disease just sitting on one of those mattresses, never mind doing... anything else on them.

I don't recall smoking that joint, but I suppose we must have.

I do remember Ray disappeared into the adjoining room with the girl he'd picked, I was left to awkwardly play the part with mine. I tried, but I just couldn't fake any real interest in her. Instead, the two of us sat on one of the bare mattresses, making self-conscious small talk about the weather or something equally inane. We both kept glancing toward the thin wall separating the rooms, waiting for the noises to stop so we could get the hell out of there. In a strange way, the girl and I bonded over the fact that neither of us wanted to be there.

Finally—and I say that like it took a long time, though it was only a matter of minutes—Ray reappeared, looking pretty pleased with himself. The girl... not so much.

"Let's get out of here," Ray said.

Once we made it back out to the street, we offered a few lame, polite excuses about needing to be somewhere, left them on the sidewalk, and walked briskly in the opposite direction.

We searched the park for the other two guys and found them already deep in negotiation with their mark, who was lying on the grass, seriously

plastered. Ray walked right up to the guy, reached down, and pulled the wallet straight out of his back pocket.

"Hey! Give me back my wallet!" the man slurred, struggling to stand up.

To Ray's minor credit, he handed the wallet back after pocketing a couple of twenties, leaving the guy with the rest. Very considerate of him.

Next stop was the liquor store. Ray was eighteen and legally old enough to buy alcohol, so he picked up a bottle of whiskey and a six-pack of beer. We found a secluded section of the park and spent the next few hours drinking and smoking weed. By the time we caught the bus back to Woonsocket, we were all pretty buzzed.

When the bus dropped us back in town, we hung out at a park near Ray and Jimmy's house. I needed to wait until my buzz wore off before I dared walk through my own front door.

*

I finally made it home around supper time. As I walked up to the house, my sister passed me on her way out and whispered a quick warning: the police had been there looking for me.

Inside, my father was waiting. He was furious, but clearly trying to keep himself under control long enough to find out exactly what had happened before killing me—or so I suspected. The police had instructed him to bring me down to the station, which probably worked in my favor. I guess he figured dragging my lifeless corpse through the precinct doors would raise too many questions.

"First question," he said. "Were you with Ray Dionne and his brother today?"

"Yes."

"Did you break into a house and steal anything?"

"Yes and no. I was there, but I didn't take anything. I didn't know they were going to do it. I just went along."

"I'm hearing different stories about whether you were actually inside or not," my father said, studying me. "Jimmy says you weren't, and so does this other kid—Jimmy's friend. But Ray says you were there and didn't take anything."

"Ray is telling the truth."

"Okay. We're going down to the station right now. Your days of hanging out with Ray and his pals are officially over, got it?"

"Yes. I should've walked away when they said what they were going to do. It was stupid to go along."

On the drive to the station, I couldn't get over two things. First, all three guys had tried, in one way or another, to protect me. Jimmy and John claimed I hadn't even been inside, while Ray told the truth but made it clear I hadn't taken anything. To this day, I don't know why any of them covered for me.

The other surprise was my father. Considering the circumstances, he was handling the whole thing remarkably well. He was still furious, but I think he realized his options were becoming limited.

I was sixteen years old and getting straight A's, but I'd also been running away from home for years. My father simply couldn't control me the way he once had. I'd recently shot up to 6'2", which was an inch taller than he was, and while I was still skinny enough that he could have broken me in half if he'd wanted to, I didn't look like a little kid anymore. Hell, I was regularly buying liquor for half the punks who hung out outside the local bowling alley.

I think he understood that beating the rebellion out of me wasn't going to work anymore. He'd had plenty of trouble himself at my age. Strangely, the whole mess seemed to have brought us a millimeter closer.

When we arrived at the station, the detectives took my statement. In the end, they dropped the charges against me and the other two minors and charged Ray with the burglary. He was eighteen, after all, and the whole thing had been his idea.

He was later charged with Grand Theft, Sandwich, and sent to prison. He got into a lot of fights, accidentally killed someone, and eventually ended up in the electric chair.

Actually, I have no idea what happened to him. I never saw him again. But it wouldn't surprise me if that's how his story ended.

*

Not too long after that, I'd taken off yet again and was hanging out in front of the bowling alley with a bunch of other kids when someone got the idea to rob the liquor store in the strip mall next door. Not *armed-robbery* robbery, though.

The liquor store backed up to a golf course, and in the summer they often left the back door open with only the screen door locked. There were about eight of us. We went around back, one guy pulled the pins out of the screen door hinges, and got into the walk-in cooler. We could hear the clerk talking to customers and ringing the register out in front.

We formed a line across the back driveway, up a small hill, and down onto the golf course, passing cases of liquor from one guy to the next until we'd made off with four cases of whiskey and six cases of cherry vodka.

And we almost got away with it.

The next day, I found out that the youngest guy in the crew had gotten home too late, and his parents had somehow gotten him to confess to the whole stupid thing. Of the eight of us, for some crazy reason, only two said I'd been there. The others said I hadn't. Since more of them said I wasn't there than said I was, I was once again off the hook!

Which didn't stop me from enjoying several bottles of the cherry vodka over the next few days, courtesy of someone who had somehow gotten ahold of them.

The '62 Rambler

One Sunday morning not long after the Providence excursion, I was back on the streets. I'd run away a few days earlier and was sleeping wherever I could find cover. One particularly miserable night, I spent three or four hours hunkered down inside a four-foot-wide concrete utility pipe in Cold Spring Park, waiting for the sun to come up.

Unfortunately, I crossed paths with Jimmy later that morning, and we killed time hanging out in the park. Eventually, Jimmy got bored and had the bright idea of looking for a car with the keys left in the ignition so we could take it for a joyride. Yeah. Great idea. Granted, we'd gotten away with it once before, taking a car right out of the high school parking lot and bringing it back a few hours later.

Jimmy had explained his golden rule of joyriding: always return the car exactly where you found it, if possible, and in the same condition you found it. No harm, no foul. That first time, we'd driven around for a few hours and dutifully returned the car to the same parking spot. I still wonder if the owner ever realized someone had sort of borrowed it for a few hours.

It wasn't long before we spotted a car with the keys dangling from the ignition. We jumped inside and were hit by that familiar stale smell old cars always seemed to have.

Somehow, I ended up in the driver's seat. The engine started right up, but I couldn't figure out how to make the damn thing move.

"How the hell do you get this thing in gear?!"

We were starting to panic when I noticed a strange row of plastic buttons on the dashboard to the left of the steering column. The car was a 1962 Rambler with a push-button transmission, something I'd never seen or even heard of.

I barely even knew how to drive a normal car.

Eventually, I pushed the D button and then figured out you had to pull down a lever next to the buttons, with a P at the top of its slot. The Rambler lurched forward.

We pooled our money, picked up some beer, and spent the next six or seven hours cruising around the area.

Around 9:00 p.m., we were heading toward Providence on Route 146 when flashing red lights appeared in the rearview mirror. Ruh roh.

The moment I pulled the Rambler onto the shoulder, Jimmy threw his door open and bailed out, sprinting for the dark tree line a good two hundred feet away.

The cops jumped out of their cruiser, one of them drawing his gun.

"Stop!" he yelled.

Jimmy kept running. The officer fired a warning shot—presumably into the air and not at him.

The crack of the gunshot was all it took.

Jimmy froze, put his hands up, and slowly turned around. Then he started walking back toward the highway with his hands in the air.

When I turned to my left to open the driver's door to get out, the other officer was standing there with his gun drawn, pointed directly at my face. That was another surreal first for me—and thankfully, the last.

It was a hot and humid summer night, and I was sweating through my blue jean shirt as the officer slammed me against the side of the Rambler, cuffing my hands behind my back. Just as the handcuffs clicked shut, a loud hot rod packed with kids from school went roaring past.

"Hey, Eric!" someone yelled through an open window.

The story of my arrest made the rounds at school over the next few days and, to my amazement, my social stock actually went up.

*

At first, my parents seriously considered letting the court send me away to Juvenile Hall—kid prison. Who knows where my life might have gone from there.

Luckily, the judge granted me probation, largely because of my academic record. If I'd been a flunky, things probably would have gone very differently. My high school teachers genuinely liked me, and they knew I had a troubled home life. They went out of their way to give me makeup assignments and help me stay afloat. Thanks to them, I still managed to pass and make it through to my senior year—even though I hadn't attended a single class during the entire last quarter of the school year.

Oh, the places you'll go!!

*

Once you've been arrested for something like breaking and entering or auto theft, apparently you become someone the police think of whenever something similar happens anywhere in the city. It was a little ridiculous in my case. I was a wayward sixteen-year-old who'd fallen in with a small group of genuine troublemakers, but I certainly didn't think I gave off a "life of crime ahead of me" vibe, like they did.

One afternoon while I was on probation, I was walking down Park Avenue when an unmarked car suddenly pulled to the curb ahead of me. Two plainclothes detectives jumped out and approached me like something straight out of *Starsky & Hutch*, questioning me as if I were Huggy Bear, their go-to street informant.

"Ah, Mr. Lynch... Nice to see you," one of them said. "Hey, you wouldn't happen to know anything about a string of B&Es down off Fairmont Street, would you? Mostly through open windows? Jewelry, small stuff like that?"

"Uh... Nooo..."

"Are you sure? Three nights ago? Any of your friends, maybe? Maybe Ray Dionne...?"

"I don't hang out with those guys anymore. Haven't in a while."

"Okay, well... if you hear anything, give us a call," he said, handing me his business card.

I wanted to ask, "Are we being filmed here, Starsky? Do I look like an informant to you?" But I figured keeping my mouth shut was probably the wiser move, so I just nodded and walked away.

The funny thing was, I'd run away from home again a few days earlier and had been sleeping on the streets. If they'd known that, they could have taken me straight back to the station and called my parents to come get me. Instead, they handed me a business card and drove away.

*

My luck ran out a few days later. A different pair of undercover officers picked me up while walking down the street and took me back to the station, where I was locked in a holding cell. The holding area was small, with three cells arranged around it—one on the left, one straight ahead, and one on the right. Instead of iron bars, each cell had a heavy steel door with a small viewing window and a light switch just inside.

I was in the cell on the left. The center cell was empty and dark. The cell on the right was also empty, but someone had left the light on.

The desk sergeant called my parents, and my father was already on his way to pick me up. After about forty-five minutes in that cramped cell, my mild claustrophobia began to kick in. I desperately wanted out. Bored and restless, I banged on the door several times.

Looking through the little window in my door, I saw an officer approaching the holding area. He wasn't the same guy who had locked

me up, and, for some goofy reason, I reached over and flipped off my light before he saw me.

When he walked in, naturally he headed straight for the only cell with its light on. I watched through my window as he crossed over and peered inside.

Seeing nobody inside, he looked baffled. He unlocked the door, stepped into the cell, and actually got down on his hands and knees to look under the low cot, apparently figuring that was the only place I could be hiding.

Finding nothing but dust, he stood up and glanced back through the open doorway just as I flipped my light back on, my smiling face filling the little window.

It was straight out of a Three Stooges episode. Unfortunately, he didn't seem to appreciate the joke quite as much as I did. He came stomping across to my cell and yanked the door open.

"What do you want?" he demanded.

I looked at him innocently. "Could I get a glass of water...?"

"Your father will be here in a minute," he growled, slamming the door shut in my face.

*

That last ride home from the police station was a turning point. I realized that the next time I took off, it couldn't be impulsive. I needed an actual plan. I didn't want to be picked up and dragged back to my parents' house again, or spend another second in some jail cell. The next time I left, I wanted to stay gone.

That meant figuring out where I could live, how I could make enough money to eat, and how to keep the police from finding me. Most

important, I needed somewhere far enough from home that I wasn't going to keep running into people who knew me.

I still had almost two years to go before I turned eighteen. If I was going to make it that long, I'd have to get a hell of a lot better at this.

Elaine

It was Thanksgiving Day, 1976, when I met Elaine. Chris and I were hitchhiking on Hamlet Avenue near Main Street in Woonsocket when she and her sister picked us up. I wasn't on the run at the time, and I honestly don't remember why we weren't with our families that day. For whatever reason, we were on the move. I know we were headed to Chris' house. The ride got us about halfway there, and we walked the rest.

When she dropped us off, we were saying our thank-yous when she said, "Hang on a second..." She pulled a small pad and pen from her purse and wrote down her phone number.

"Give me a call!"

This was another one of those cases where the girl was forward enough to let me know she was interested, without me having to put myself out there. Which, of course, I loved.

She was eighteen, and I was sixteen. She loved my hair. I think that was really the main attraction, but we were also both into the same music—especially Led Zeppelin.

I called her the next day and we talked for two hours. Then talked almost every night for at least an hour over the next few days. Finally, late Saturday afternoon, she drove five miles from her house in Cumberland, the next town over, and picked me up. My parents were a bit leery about me dating an "older woman," but when they met her, she seemed nice enough and wasn't trappy at all.

Her parents, on the other hand—mainly her father—did not like her dating at all, never mind a long-haired guy like me. Her father was a strict disciplinarian and very, very controlling of his three daughters. He was ex-military and a real asshole. Elaine hated him, and from the way she described him, he sounded like the male version of my mother.

So we bonded over our desire to be free.

In fact, during the six months we dated, she moved in with her half brother and his wife. It wasn't an ideal living arrangement, since they didn't have a bedroom for her and she slept on a pullout sofa in the living room, but it worked for a while. The living room had a door, though no lock, so privacy was iffy at best.

*

Elaine had long, curly hair, but she literally ironed it straight every day. With a clothes iron. She smoked Marlboro Lights, drank Budweiser, loved marijuana, and really loved the pills that were sold as THC, which everyone just called "T." They came in varieties with names like "purple double barrel" and "orange double barrel." She often took two hits, though I stuck to one the few times I did it with her.

The first time, we took purple double barrel and went to see Led Zeppelin's *The Song Remains the Same* at a local theater. The drugs certainly made it a memorable experience, but it wasn't really my thing. I did it once or twice more with her, but that was it.

*

Over our time together, we made out in her car a lot. Sometimes for over an hour, mostly because we had nowhere else to go. We couldn't go to either of our parents' houses and expect any privacy, and since it was cold, we had to keep the car running for heat.

Finally, one Saturday afternoon, we were making out on her pullout couch with nobody else home. Things progressed, and we decided to risk the privacy of the living-room door.

We had been almost-having sex for approximately two seconds when her half brother opened the door and walked in.

So much for that.

I left shortly after, and within a week we were sitting outside on her front steps when she broke up with me. But the way she did it made it

OK. I was bummed out, for sure, but... not as much as I should have been, maybe. She was pretty wise for eighteen. What she said was...

"You are truly a free spirit kind of guy. Staying with me, here in this stupid city, would kill you. But this is what I know and this is where I want to stay. I know you don't. I love you. That's why I'm letting you go."

Funny enough, *Free Bird* was kind of our song. We both loved it and played it all the time. Make of that what you will.

I somewhat successfully held back a few tears as we kissed and said goodbye. And then... just walked away.

More than anything, I remember walking away thinking about what she'd said. I was sorry it was over, but in some strange way, I appreciated what she'd done. She wasn't just dumping me. At least in my sixteen-year-old mind, she was setting me free.

Decades later, in 2015, she found me on Facebook. She said she'd never forgotten me and that we still had some "unfinished business." Wink-wink, nudge-nudge. She also told me she was thinking about leaving her husband and had been looking at apartments.

At some point after we reconnected, Elaine denied ever giving me that whole "free spirit" speech. But I remember it distinctly.

*

What I didn't realize until much later was that she actually did leave her husband and get her own apartment not long after we started talking. Whether my suddenly reappearing in her life had anything to do with that, I don't know.

At the time, I'd recently been laid off and had actually accepted a job with Bank of America in Charlotte, North Carolina, not terribly far from where Elaine was living in Florida. I'd even signed paperwork on a townhouse in Fort Mill, South Carolina, close to where my brother, Alex, and his family lived.

Then, just before I was supposed to start, I got a much better offer near my home in Half Moon Bay. I backed out of the townhouse and quit the new job before I'd even started.

I kept in touch with Elaine over the next few months, and in May she told me she had just found out she had Stage 2 breast cancer. She was very optimistic, though. She'd had Stage 0 breast cancer a few years earlier and had beaten it, so she felt confident she'd beat it this time, too.

I later learned that around the same time, she moved back in with her husband.

I was busy with my new job, and between the time difference and her treatment schedule, our emails and calls slowly dropped off until they stopped. One day, after a few months had gone by without us connecting, I saw a post from her daughter on Facebook saying that Elaine had died. She'd never told me how bad it was, how much pain she was in, or that she'd spent some time in hospice at the end.

From the posts I see on her Facebook page, which is still there, I can see she was much loved by her family and friends. And, funny enough, she looked almost exactly as I remembered her. Still ironed her hair. Still smoked Marlboro Lights. Still loved her Budweiser, only now it was Bud Light. And still loved to smoke weed.

I didn't fully understand it when I was sixteen, but Elaine was right. I wasn't meant to stay.

The Dark Tower

While still living at home, I responded to an ad in the Providence Journal for a job as a second-shift dishwasher at the Marriott Hotel in Providence. It was early summer 1976. I was sixteen years old and about to enter my senior year at Woonsocket High School. The minimum age for the job was eighteen, so I lied on the application. Given my height and being reasonably mature-looking, I apparently passed for eighteen. When they asked for my driver's license, I told them I didn't have one and would be taking the bus to work. I also mentioned that I planned to move to Providence soon anyway. They were apparently desperate enough for kitchen help that they hired me on the spot.

My parents weren't thrilled with my hitchhiking to and from work every night—a thirty-minute drive each way that often had me getting home around 3:00 a.m. But I convinced them I'd be safe, and they reluctantly allowed it. I think they were just relieved I was working and earning money instead of hanging out with the local lowlifes. My father, especially, seemed resigned to the idea that I wasn't going to amount to much of anything.

Washing dishes at a major hotel was an insane amount of work, especially when they hosted banquets for hundreds of people. After one of those massive events—which seemed to happen every other night—three or four six-foot-tall rolling metal racks called "Queen Mary's" would line the narrow hallway leading to the kitchen. They'd be stacked with half-eaten food, slop-encrusted china, silverware, and glasses—a sight that could make you want to turn around and walk right back out the door. Especially on weekends when the main restaurant was still churning out its own endless stream of dirty dishes.

The heat in that kitchen was oppressive—a greasy, humid sauna. The only thing worse than the heat was cleaning the grease trap, where all the food scrapings ended up. About once a week, we'd have to wheel it out

the back door and empty it into a larger container that was collected by a restaurant service. That meant wrestling the heavy, sloshing container outside, dumping the rancid contents, and hosing down the mesh filter. The smell of rotting food and cooking oil was enough to make you gag. Dishwashing was grueling enough, but the grease trap was easily the worst part of the job.

Faced with those mountains of dirty dishes, I started turning the job into a game. How fast could I turn this mess into clean stacks? Was there a better order to do things in? Was there some way to make the whole operation move faster? Before long, I became almost obsessed with efficiency.

I didn't realize it at the time, but I'd repeat that pattern throughout my working life. Whenever a job seemed overwhelming, I'd start looking for ways to make it easier, faster, or more organized. It eventually led to some surprisingly quick promotions—not because I had some burning ambition to move into management. I just hated feeling like a job was beating me. I had to figure out how to beat it first.

*

On my first break that night, I followed the other kitchen staff—cooks, dishwashers, a few waiters—to the break room. We had fifteen minutes, and practically everyone immediately lit a cigarette and poured a cup of coffee. I'd always been against smoking; my father smoked two packs a day, and I never understood the compulsion. I didn't drink coffee either. Until then, that is.

Since everyone else was drinking coffee, I poured myself a cup and added cream and two sugars, the way my parents drank it. It was surprisingly good—better than the few cups I'd tried at home. Everyone around me was smoking, and someone offered me a cigarette. I'd never smoked one in my life, but I figured, *Well, everyone else is doing it. There must be something to it.* So I took it. I'd been smoking pot for more than a

year, so I rationalized that this was just another kind of smoke, conveniently ignoring all the years I'd spent making fun of people for smoking cigarettes.

I still wonder if I ever would have started smoking if I hadn't been drinking that hot coffee. It was a Newport Menthol, and somehow the combination made that first drag go straight into my lungs without making me gag or cough. It even gave me a little buzz, almost like taking a hit off a joint. That was all it took. Within two weeks, I was up to a pack a day.

I kept smoking until I was forty-two, when I finally quit through hypnotism. Surprisingly, it worked. I haven't had a cigarette since.

*

Over my first few nights at work, I got to know a guy everyone called "Stoner." No one knew his real name. If you asked, he'd tilt his head and say, "You know, people just call me Stoner, so that's the name I go by. My real name is meaningless, man. It's all a bunch of bullshit," and then laugh at the very idea that anyone needed a "legal name." It would be months before I finally found out what it actually was. Oddly enough, the only people I ever met who knew his real name were his fraternity brothers. The fact that Stoner had fraternity brothers at all was hard to reconcile with the guy standing in front of me. A clean-cut frat boy he was not.

He was twenty-three and worked as a line cook while attending the Johnson & Wales College of Culinary Arts.

Having later lived with him, I can't say I was terribly impressed with his cooking. Let's just say his culinary skills were still a work in progress.

Stoner was a pretty uncomplicated guy, a hippie who seemed to have wandered straight out of Woodstock—which, as it happened, he'd planned on attending but couldn't get to for some reason. He did,

however, make it to the other big outdoor music festival of the era at Watkins Glen.

He was about 5'10", with long, straight blond hair parted down the middle and usually tied back in a ponytail. He had a mustache with a soul patch underneath it, bright blue eyes set in a round face, and a distinctive nose. He was mellow and philosophical, with an almost childish innocence. Whenever I read the word "hippie," I immediately think of Stoner.

He made his own wine up in the attic, sold a little weed and other drugs on the side, and rode a Honda 750 LTD cruiser bike. In fact, he had three other motorcycles in various states of disrepair crammed into the basement; only the one was ever functional enough to be his daily driver.

Even though my shift officially ended at 2:00 a.m., I was often there until 3:00. After work one night, Stoner invited me and two other dishwashers back to his place for a little after-work partying.

His place was about a fifteen-minute walk from the hotel, across a bridge over Route 95, past rows of dark tenement buildings and the basketball court at Orms and Smith, then another couple of blocks to his apartment.

*

By Thanksgiving, I was well into my senior year and working at the Marriott only on weekends. But things at home hadn't gotten any better. The final blow came during another massive fight with my mother. I was downstairs in the boiler room, just off the dining room—a cramped, dark space that smelled of heating oil, laundry detergent, and must.

My mother was yelling at me, blocking my only way out. I tried to push past her, and she started hammering at me with her fists. I grabbed both her arms and, for a split second, thought about hitting her back in self-defense.

But as I held her arms, I looked over her left shoulder through the open doorway. My father was standing on the far side of the dining table, his hands resting heavily on the back of a wooden chair. He was completely still, just watching us.

"Don't do it," he said. His voice was flat, but the message was clear.

There was something in his eyes that looked like resignation—or maybe understanding. We both knew the rule: you don't hit women. I don't believe I ever would have hit her, even if my father hadn't been standing there. But the fact that I'd thought about it at all kinda shocked me.

I managed to twist free and bolted for the back exit. Oddly, my father didn't try to intervene. The inner door happened to be open, but the outer glass storm door was shut. I threw it open and shoved it hard behind me as I ran. Just before it slammed shut, I caught a quick glimpse of my mother's hand reaching for me. The glass exploded. I wondered if she'd just put her hand through it, but I kept running. I never looked back.

Later that night, after the house had gone quiet, I snuck back inside through the front entrance—the door that led up to the kids' apartment. Working quickly and quietly, I grabbed a rolled-up sleeping bag, a few changes of clothes, and some basic toiletries. My sister, Leslie, watched me. She seemed sympathetic, maybe even a little envious. I think she understood that this time was different from all the others. I had exactly fourteen months to go until I turned eighteen and would finally be Free.

*

There was one other problem. I was still on probation for the Rambler incident and required to report to my probation officer every month. I'd made my first two appointments, but now that I'd left home, I stopped reporting. I knew exactly what that meant: sooner or later, a warrant would be issued for my arrest.

From that point on, getting picked up by the police wouldn't just mean another ride home. Now I could be arrested for violating probation.

I walked out to the highway, hitchhiked to Providence, and made my way directly to Stoner's place. His neighborhood was rough enough that I quickly stashed my pack under the front stoop, sliding it out of sight behind a loose panel of wooden latticework. The apartment building itself was a dilapidated three-story tenement—one of dozens lining the street. The exterior stairs were rotting. If the building had an "Enter at Your Own Risk" sign, it wouldn't have seemed out of place.

I climbed to the third floor. His brown, peeling apartment door had a black-and-gold foil beer label stuck just below the peephole. It read, *The Dark Tower*.

I gave the door a quick knock. As far as Stoner knew, I was eighteen and living on my own. So did everyone else I was about to meet in Providence. It was a lie, but a necessary one.

Unfortunately, my grand escape hit an immediate wall. Stoner and his girlfriend, Felicia, were buried studying for midterms and couldn't have me crashing on their couch. That left me with nowhere to sleep for the next two weeks, while my parents were actively trying to find me.

*

After leaving Stoner's place, I descended the rotting stairs and crawled under the front stoop. I was sixteen years old, on the run, lying in the dirt under a run-down porch, with nothing but a sidewalk separating me from a street that was quiet at night but busy during the day.

By the time I got settled into my sleeping bag, it was 3:00 a.m. I wasn't sleeping, of course. I was just lying there, marinating in the musky smell of damp dirt, rotting wood, and peeling paint. I tried not to think about the rats and spiders whose space I was invading. I stared through the

lattice-work at the lone streetlight in front of the empty corner lot, feeling more alone than I ever had in my life.

It's all on me now.

*

Lying there under that porch, the reality of my situation fully sank in. I was sleeping in the dirt in a neighborhood where I didn't know anyone particularly well. I had no car, no place to shower, no place to sleep the next night, and nobody I could call for help. I had a sleeping bag, a few clothes, whatever money was in my pocket, and a job washing dishes at the Marriott.

Oddly, I wasn't panicking. It was more of a sober realization that this was what being truly on my own actually meant. Nobody was coming to rescue me. And I didn't want to be rescued anyway. Going home wasn't an option.

So I had to make it work.

I had to keep my job, avoid the police, stay hidden from my parents, and maintain the fiction that I was an eighteen-year-old living on my own. As far as I knew, if my new friends discovered I was really a sixteen-year-old runaway with a warrant hanging over me, they could get into trouble themselves. I couldn't risk that.

I liked Stoner, but I never saw him or the others as the kind of people I wanted to become. Right then, though, they were the only people I had. I needed to fit in.

Beyond that, I didn't have anything resembling a plan.

I stared through the lattice-work at that streetlight for a long time. Finally, I just handed the rest over to whatever higher power might be listening and hoped somehow it would all work out.

*

A few days into my homelessness, I found a payphone and called home. I fed my brother, Mark, a story that I'd quit my job at the Marriott and was living down by the beach in Narragansett. I made him swear not to tell Mom and Dad, figuring that was practically a guarantee he eventually would. More importantly, making it a secret made the story believable.

It worked. Surprisingly, Mark held out for two full weeks before he finally cracked. My parents spent the next several months focusing their search on beach towns an hour away, even alerting local police departments to keep an eye out for me. They had no idea I was living half that distance from home and still clocking in at the Marriott every day—only now, I was working full-time.

*

After two weeks of sleeping under Stoner's porch, I got a break. Two fellow students and fraternity brothers of Stoner's, Bob and Butch, were living with three other guys on the first floor of his tenement building. The semester was about to end, and the other three were moving back home to wherever they came from. Bob and Butch were staying in Providence, so the three of us rented a first-floor apartment just two doors down.

Bob was a six-foot-two, super-skinny redhead—a total Deadhead and a major pothead. He worked as a cook at the Marriott, which is how I knew him. Sober, he could be a condescending know-it-all who had an annoying habit of talking down to me. Stoned, though, he became a much more mellow and likable guy—which was fortunate, considering how much time we spent together, and the insane amount of weed we smoked every day.

Butch was a short, muscular guy who looked like a street fighter but was actually harmless unless provoked. He worked as a cook at the Holiday Inn. I genuinely liked Butch, and we got along pretty well.

Both were twenty-one, recent graduates of Johnson & Wales, working as cooks in major hotels and making barely enough money to live in a dump like this one. And both were apparently oblivious to the fact that their new sixteen-year-old roommate was a runaway.

*

By the time my parents eventually tracked me down, I was just six months away from Freedom. By then, I was holding down a job and paying my own rent, and they apparently decided there wasn't much point in dragging me home. My mom even brought me a casserole a few times.

The Apartment

The apartment we moved into was on the first floor of a decaying three-story house owned by Jim Greenberg—the consummate slumlord, with several rundown tenement buildings scattered around Providence. Built in 1912, the house was a few decades newer than Stoner's place but wasn't in much better shape. We climbed the uneven concrete steps, which leaned noticeably to the left, and went inside to inspect our new home.

The place had only two mid-sized bedrooms for the three of us. I expected a battle over who got the single room, but Bob and Butch unexpectedly volunteered to share if I could supply some kind of divider between their beds. I spent forty dollars of my meager earnings on two four-by-six-foot sheets of half-inch plywood and some L-brackets and built them a partition. Ironically, it was exactly the same setup I'd shared with my brother, Alex, back home to divide our one large bedroom space into two.

My bedroom was right off the living room near the front door. It had light blue wallpaper and a small, empty closet—except for a single navy blue men's dress shirt hanging on the bar. Amazingly, it fit me perfectly. During the first week, I bought a six-foot poster of Jimmy Page and Robert Plant at a downtown shop and hung it on the wall. I also scavenged a battered but functional dresser from a burned-out building across the way. In one of the drawers, I found a striped tie that happened to match my new blue shirt perfectly. Both would come in handy later.

The third floor was occupied by a quiet, bearded guy of about thirty-five wearing wire-rimmed glasses—an eccentric academic named Bill who lived alone. One day in the middle of July, when the three of us were desperate for weed but there was none to be found anywhere, I spotted him walking past our kitchen window wearing a heavy green snorkel

jacket. Yeah. In the middle of July. I quickly threw open the back door just as he stepped into the rear stairwell.

"Hey, Bill, is it?" I asked, trying to sound casual. "Any chance you might have some weed to sell? We're bone-dry here and can't find anything, anywhere."

He paused, never confirming his name, and pondered my request as though I'd just asked him to calculate the square root of pi or explain the meaning of life.

"Hmm... I'll be right back," he said, disappearing up the stairs.

Five minutes later, there was a quick knock at the door. When I opened it, "Bill" simply thrust out a quart-sized Ziploc bag containing nearly a quarter-pound of green, homegrown weed. I was blown away. Without saying a word, he turned and headed back upstairs. By the time I thought to ask how much I owed him, he was already halfway up the stairs. I ended up thanking his back.

The weed wasn't great, honestly, but beggars can't be choosers.

Upstairs lived an old woman and her two teenage granddaughters, thirteen and fifteen. I wondered what the story was there and later learned that their parents had been killed in a car accident a few years earlier.

It wasn't long before we became acquainted.

Our sole bathroom was missing a massive chunk of sheetrock directly above the clawfoot tub / shower, giving us a perfect view of the floor joists and the underside of the upstairs neighbors' linoleum. The white porcelain sink and clawfoot tub were scarred with brown rust stains, chips, and cracks. But everything worked.

One afternoon while I was taking a shower, I happened to look up and saw two giggling faces peering down at me. One of the granddaughters

was holding back a curled edge of their bathroom linoleum, giving them both a ringside seat.

"Hey! What the...!" I yelled, launching my bar of soap at the ceiling. That only made them laugh harder, but they dropped the linoleum with a thunk, restoring my privacy.

It wasn't a one-time event, either. The girls pulled the same stunt several other times. I didn't really mind all that much. I'd always been a bit of an exhibitionist, and it was harmless enough fun. But we definitely needed that ceiling patched.

After months of complaining about the hole, we came home one day to discover that Mr. Greenberg had finally fixed it. His solution? He had entered our apartment without permission, torn down the divider I'd paid for and built between Bob's and Butch's beds, and used it to patch the bathroom ceiling with like 50 nails.

All of our follow-up calls complaining about the theft went unanswered. It was the same story when winter arrived and we begged him to fix the broken living room windows that let freezing air pour inside.

We stayed for a year and a half. During that time, Bob brought home an Alaskan Malamute named Kimo, who proved to be a pretty well-behaved dog—except when he was left alone. Whenever we went out, Kimo would knock over the trash can and drag garbage all over the apartment. Bob would fly into a rage and swat him repeatedly with a rolled-up magazine. Kimo would yelp and carry on, but never seemed to learn. Eventually, we just gave up on trying to stop him, locked the trash in a cupboard, and let him have the run of the place.

During our final three months there, Bob decided our slumlord had earned a little payback and stopped taking Kimo outside, letting him use the front room as his personal toilet instead. I thought it was disgusting, but somehow I went along with it. The front room opened into the living room through a big seven- or eight-foot-wide opening, so we hung a

heavy quilt across it, creating a makeshift wall. It helped keep the smell contained, but just as importantly, kept the freezing winter air from pouring into the rest of the apartment through the huge holes in the broken front windows that Greenberg refused to acknowledge.

Then, for our grand finale, we threw a big moving-out party. Somewhere during the festivities, things got a little out of hand, I suppose... We shoveled six inches of raw dirt into the bathtub, poked holes through the sheetrock walls, handed out markers and crayons, and let everyone write and draw whatever they wanted all over the walls.

Six months after we abandoned the wreckage, Butch happened to be walking past the old place on his way to visit Stoner when he ran into Mr. Greenberg on the sidewalk.

"Hey, Butch! The tenant that moved in after you guys left just gave his notice. If you want to move back in, let me know!"

White Punks On Dope

It was a bad neighborhood. Then again, to me, most of Providence seemed pretty rough back then, outside of the East Side near Brown University and the area around Providence College. Roaming gangs of white punks constantly targeted us, trying to rob us of our money or, more importantly, our weed. It got so bad that we eventually started carrying improvised clubs with us just to walk to the laundromat two blocks away.

One sunny summer day, we were shooting free throws on a broken concrete court choked with weeds when the same group of neighborhood punks we'd had run-ins with before came walking toward us.

"Uh-oh," I muttered to Butch. "This doesn't look good."

"Just be cool," Butch replied. "If we don't stand up to them now, it'll only get worse."

The tallest one approached us. "Mind if we play?"

"Nah, we're just doing some free throws," Butch said, casually dribbling the ball. "We don't have time for a game."

In one quick motion, the kid closed the gap between us, snatched the ball, and tossed it to one of his buddies. As Butch lunged after it, the same punk blindsided me with a punch to the left side of my face. I'd been watching Butch, not him. I stumbled backward and went down, and the guy was immediately on top of me. He landed several quick punches before I managed to get my hands up and grab both of his wrists.

We were at a stalemate: I wasn't letting go, and he couldn't free his hands to hit me again. Still holding his wrists, I brought my knee up into his crotch, though I didn't connect with nearly the force I could have—and he knew it.

"Get off me. The next one's going to be much harder."

He hesitated for a second, then relaxed, and even smirked a little. To his credit, when I let go, he didn't try a parting shot. Neither of us had really gotten the better of the other. I was taller, but I was also just a skinny kid bluffing his way through a fight with a guy who clearly had a lot more experience at it than I did.

We both got to our feet and turned toward Butch. He was chasing the punk with our basketball across the street, the rest of the pack—like hyenas—in hot pursuit. The chase ended when the guy with the ball got cornered against an old stone staircase. Butch lunged, slamming him backward against the steps where he fell into a sitting position, and started raining punches into the side of his head.

After taking several punches, the guy managed to scramble to his feet and whipped out a switchblade from his pocket. The blade snapped open with the push of a button.

That's when things got real.

Butch didn't back down. He grabbed a cantaloupe-sized rock, his face flushed and his chest heaving.

"Oh, you want to play with knives?! Come on! Come get me!"

One of the hyenas darted in from behind and batted the rock from Butch's hand. Butch spun around, looking for another weapon, and was just about to scoop up a smaller stone when someone yelled, "Cop!"

A police cruiser was slowly rolling past the far side of the court. We didn't know if the cops had seen the knife, but the mere sight of them was enough. The pack immediately turned and scattered, vanishing into the maze of dilapidated apartment buildings.

From that point forward, the physical attacks stopped. In fact, they'd sometimes wave to us from across the street. In some weirdly clichéd way, we'd earned their respect.

The whole thing felt like we'd acted out a scene from *West Side Story*—only without the dancing and singing. Which was probably a good thing, since I can't dance or sing to save my life anyway.

Of course, earning their respect didn't stop them from stealing from us later. Let's not get carried away here.

*

Oddly, over time, a few of the neighborhood punks began dropping by our apartment to buy weed—and sometimes they'd even stick around to share a smoke afterward.

One summer afternoon, Butch and I were doing bong hits in the living room, listening to CSNY's *So Far*. To this day, "Wooden Ships" instantly takes me back to that afternoon. There was a knock on our open front door.

"Hey, is Butch here?" called Jimmy, one of the neighborhood punks.

"Yeah, come in," Butch replied.

Jimmy stepped inside alone. From my spot on the living room couch, I could see through the front room and out the open door, where his two buddies were waiting on the stoop.

"Can you sell us a few joints, by any chance?" Jimmy asked.

"Sure, give me a minute and I'll roll a couple. Buck apiece," I said, pulling out the rolling papers and setting our open bag of weed on the coffee table.

"Can I try a quick bong hit while you do that?"

We figured, why not? He'd already laid his two dollars on the table. Butch handed him our homemade two-foot acrylic bong, and Jimmy took a huge hit.

"Whew! Wow. This is nice and buzzy!" he declared.

"Yeah. Colombian Gold," I said. Back then, that was considered top-shelf weed.

I finished twisting up the joints and handed them over. Butch and I were high and totally relaxed, so we were completely blindsided when Jimmy suddenly snatched the open bag of weed off the coffee table, got up and bolted towards and out through the open front door. By the time we recovered from the shock, scrambled around the coffee table, and reached the door, the three of them already had too much of a head start. No way we were going to catch them.

Not long after that, we came home to find that someone had broken into our apartment through my bedroom window. They stole the brand new \$600 stereo I'd scrimped and saved for. On my meager paycheck, that stereo represented six full weeks of labor. It was by far the single most valuable thing I owned, and had ever owned in my life.

Other than the day I'd come home to find my previous (used) stereo chopped to pieces with an axe, I'd never felt so violated. Having someone invade my space and take something I'd worked so hard for was a sickening new sensation.

Over the next few days, the street grapevine delivered a name: Ponzi, one of the local WPODs (White Punks On Dope). We had crossed paths with him several times. He was usually just another hyena in the pack and not a particularly intimidating one, so I was surprised he had the nerve to pull off a solo break-in—if the rumor was true, that is.

A few nights later, I spotted him walking toward me on the opposite side of the street. It was a cold winter night, and I was wearing a heavy, hooded leather jacket. I pulled up my hood, letting it shadow my face, then casually crossed over to his side of the street. He hadn't really noticed me before I pulled up the hood, and by the time he realized who I was, we were only six or seven feet apart.

When he finally looked up, his face registered pure, unadulterated panic. He spun to run, but I lunged forward, grabbed him by the jacket, spun him back around, and slammed him against the side of a house. I towered over him, letting every ounce of my anger show.

"Where's my fucking stereo?!" I demanded.

He was alone, trembling, and stripped of both his pack and his bravado.

"I don't know! I don't know what you're talking about!"

I pinned him against the wall with my forearm and drove my fist into his face.

He started pleading. "I don't know! I don't know!"

"I heard it was you. If it wasn't you, then who was it?!"

"I don't have it!" he stammered. "Last I heard, Jimmy was trying to sell it, but someone stole it from him! I swear, I have no idea where it is now!"

I hesitated for a second, absorbing what he'd said. That was all he needed. He twisted violently, broke free, and took off sprinting down the street. I didn't bother chasing him. There didn't seem to be much point.

I doubted Ponzi had pulled off the burglary alone. If Jimmy really had been trying to sell my stereo, I figured he'd probably been involved from the beginning. And knowing Jimmy, it was entirely possible he'd already sold it and simply stiffed Ponzi on whatever cut he'd promised him.

Maybe this was the universe's way of paying me back for the two cars I'd "borrowed" and that one break-in I'd stupidly gone along with. Having someone steal *my* shit felt a whole lot different.

Go figure.

The Economics of Survival

I did a lot of things during those days that I'm not proud of, but I rationalized some of them as necessary for survival. It's a lame excuse, especially since if I hadn't been blowing most of my money on drugs and Budweiser, I would have had plenty left over for crazy things like... well, food.

My weekly take-home pay from the Marriott was a meager \$90. The first expenditure on payday was \$20 for a quarter-ounce of weed. That left \$70. From that, I set aside \$5 for my share of the utilities and another \$10 for rent. It was an unbelievable bargain, even for the late 1970s, but then again, the place was a dump.

That left me with \$55. But Friday night quickly bled into Saturday night, which meant two nights of drinks and pool at Ye College Pub downtown. Toss in a few overdue debts to Bob or Butch from the previous week's extravaganzas, and I was invariably penniless by Monday or Tuesday—with no food in the house.

The hotel at least took care of one shift meal a day. I might scrape together enough change for milk and cereal for breakfast, or maybe a few wieners down the street for lunch or dinner. But during my first year or so in the 'hood, there were several days a week when I missed a meal or two.

*

In those hungry times, SPAM wasn't some unwanted junk in your inbox; it was dinner.

I eventually resorted to shoplifting from a local supermarket just to eat. I would walk into the store wearing a bulky jacket—it was winter, after all—and wander up and down the aisles, pretending to search for some elusive item, before finally slipping a can of SPAM under one armpit and a package of Kraft American White Singles under the other.

I'd walk out of the store, my heart pounding against the hard, rounded-square edge of the tin can held tight in my armpit.

Once safely back at the apartment, I'd stow my stolen goods and walk down the block to the local bakery. They sold whole loaves of perfectly good, day-old sliced bread for a whopping ten cents. Combined with the groceries, this was enough to sustain me for three full days' worth of sandwich-based meals. I'd toast the cheap bread, fry up thick-ish slices of the semi-meat product, melt a slice of the plastic-looking white cheese on top, and spread on a thin layer of mustard. Voilà! A somewhat greasy but surprisingly delicious meal for just a few pennies.

I don't recall exactly how many times I pulled this off, but it was at least three, maybe four. It was a terrifying thing to do, and I try not to think about what would have happened if I'd gotten caught. Getting caught could easily have changed the entire trajectory of my life. I would have been dragged home by my parents or, worse, thrown into Juvenile Hall.

But even then, I knew this wasn't going to be my life forever. I didn't know how I was going to get out of it. I just knew that somehow, eventually, I would.

Shaft

Stoner sold weed, but every so often the entire town seemed to run dry. When he did have it, he'd carefully weigh out an ounce on an Ohaus triple-beam scale—29.5 grams total, accounting for the 1.5-gram plastic baggie. He occasionally dealt speed or, rarely, cocaine, but his inventory at any one time was typically just marijuana.

One afternoon, Bob, Butch, and I were hanging out at a Black fraternity brother's apartment nearby with about ten of his fraternity brothers. Bob and I were the only white people in the place. We were all smoking and chatting over Kool & the Gang playing from a cheap stereo in the kitchen. I was sitting with a few others in a small room just off the kitchen, where it was slightly quieter. The place was thick with pot and cigarette smoke. If we'd opened a window, a neighbor probably would have seen white clouds billowing out and called the fire department. It was like a Cheech and Chong movie.

Suddenly, a loud knock at the door brought everything to a halt. Everyone went quiet, ready to hide any incriminating evidence if it turned out to be the cops. Someone finally got up, checked the peephole, and visibly relaxed before throwing the door open for a tall, imposing Black dude named John Johnson.

He came in wearing a long, black leather trench coat and dark jeans. With Rick James-style hair, only shorter, and a thick mustache, he looked like he'd just stepped off a movie set. The smoke parted around him as he walked through the kitchen. In my head, the "whaucka-whaucka" soundtrack from *Shaft* started playing.

Bob and Butch were already very high, and the minute John walked in, they both became embarrassingly star-struck.

"John! Hey, get John a beer!" Bob called out. "What's happening, man? Long time no see."

Meanwhile, the much shorter Butch was practically dancing circles around him, cracking jokes and trying to get his attention. Both of them were fawning all over him. I was genuinely embarrassed for them; I'd never seen either of them idolize anyone like that.

John, meanwhile, was pure Shaft. He acknowledged them just enough to be semi-respectful, then left them trailing in his wake. I'd met him once before at a party or something, but I didn't understand what the big deal was. Was he some movie star I didn't know about? Which was entirely possible. He looked like one. I later heard rumors he was a major drug dealer, though whether that was true or not, I never found out. To Bob and Butch's obvious chagrin, he walked straight over and sat in the chair across from me, our knees practically touching.

"Eric, right?" he asked.

"Yeah. Hi, John. Nice to see you again," I said, passing him the joint. "Want a hit?"

He took the joint, inhaled deeply, then slowly let the smoke drift from his lungs. "Thanks," he said after a brief cough. "Good weed."

We chatted for a bit—mostly small talk. I glanced toward the doorway and caught Bob and Butch sneaking looks at us. Why was John Johnson, apparently the coolest Black dude on the planet, talking to me and not them? I wasn't a "brother" in any sense of the word.

I could only conclude that he couldn't handle all the fawning, and I was the only person in the room who didn't seem to know what his big deal was.

I've never been much of the idolizing type, though I'll admit to being a big fan of a few movie stars, like Jack Nicholson and Clint Eastwood. Crazy as it would have seemed to me at seventeen, I would actually end up meeting both of them later in life.

*

The fraternity was a major part of Bob, Butch, and Stoner's social life. I can't recall the Greek letters, but it was basically a real-life version of *National Lampoon's Animal House*. It seemed to exist almost entirely for partying.

Every fall, the fraternity held something called "Hell Week," when new pledges subjected themselves to every embarrassing humiliation the fraternity could dream up. I suppose the idea, much like military boot camp, was to break everyone down to the same level and forge some kind of bond through shared misery.

One afternoon, I came home from work to find our apartment in full party mode—or so it initially seemed. Music was blasting, and there were probably thirty or forty people scattered around the place, along with the usual pot smoke and empty beer bottles. But I must have walked in just as the party ended and the torment began.

The first thing I saw was Butch sitting on the back of a sweating, overweight pledge who was desperately trying to push himself off the carpet. Butch was verbally brutalizing the guy.

"Come on, you wimp! Can't you do one lousy push-up?" he yelled. "What are you, some little Mama's boy?!"

Neither of them even acknowledged I was there as I worked my way through the small crowd in the living room. Everyone was so absorbed in the hazing that it was as if I were a ghost just passing through.

As I passed the bathroom, I peered over the heads jammed in the doorway to see what all the commotion was about. A pledge stood in the bathtub wearing nothing but a pair of white Fruit of the Loom briefs, blindfolded with a lampshade on his head, weakly singing "Mary Had a Little Lamb." The tub was half-full of water.

In the kitchen, several other pledges had been put to work mopping the floor, meticulously cleaning out our refrigerator, and scrubbing a

mountain of dishes—all while enduring a constant barrage of verbal abuse from Bob.

Hell Week was doing wonders for the apartment.

Ordinarily, Hell Week was closed off to outsiders. But since it was my apartment too, I was allowed to witness the "secret rituals". Eventually, the guys even made me an honorary member of the fraternity. Fine by me. I got the T-shirt without having to endure any of the hazing.

Part of the hazing involved a huge, thick wooden fraternity paddle, which hung on our living room wall right beside the kitchen doorway. Every once in a while, Bob or Butch would glance at it and say, "Hey, let's have a pick-me-up shot!"

They'd take turns bending over and bracing themselves against the wall while the other delivered one hard whack with the paddle. Then they'd stand up, rub their backsides, and grin through the pain.

"Oof! That was a good one!" one would pant.

"Yeah! Woo! That gets the adrenaline flowing!"

I respectfully declined whenever they offered me a "shot."

Beverly

We spent a lot of nights down at Ye College Pub, near Johnson & Wales. It drew the college crowd, of course, but Bob, Butch, and I were close enough in age to blend in—I was a year younger than a freshman, and my roommates were a year older than seniors. I was tall, the drinking age was only eighteen, and passing for eighteen wasn't exactly difficult. Besides, it was a total dive bar. Nobody checked IDs in places like that.

One night, Bob and I were sitting in a booth by the jukebox when two girls walked up and slid in next to us like they already knew us. Their names were Beverly and Lydia. Both were nurses, twenty-four years old. To me, they were older women—a massive seven-year gap.

Beverly liked my long hair—really liked it—and started running her fingers through it. After buying me a beer, she leaned in close.

“Do you want to come back to my apartment?”

That caught me completely off guard. Nobody had ever asked me that before. It wouldn't be the last time over the years, but it was certainly an unexpected first. And, of course, I went. We didn't even pretend to hang out; we walked straight into her bedroom.

I was seventeen, and Beverly was my first real sexual experience. I'd technically crossed that particular threshold once before, with Elaine, but it lasted all of a few seconds before we were interrupted.

Beverly and I "dated" for a little while after that night—if you could call it that. Mostly, I'd go to her place and we'd end up in bed. We got together three or four times over the course of a couple of weeks, limited mainly by our work schedules. Otherwise, I'm pretty sure it would have been every night. It wasn't serious—or at least, I didn't think it was.

Apparently, I was wrong.

*

One night, around two in the morning, Butch and another guy stumbled home from the bar with a girl. As usual, they woke me up by pounding on my bedroom door. My room opened directly into the living room anyway, so there was no escaping the noise. Half-awake, I finally dragged myself out and joined them. The girl was a cute, bubbly, 5'4" student at Johnson and Wales who introduced herself as Marlene.

Butch and his friend were falling all over themselves trying to impress her, while I mostly sat quietly, nursing a beer and buzzing from a hit of a joint being passed around. The girl kept glancing over at me while deflecting Butch and his friend's moves. When she finally got up to leave, we all stood, and she walked straight over to me.

"Do you want to get together sometime? I live downtown at the J&W dorms."

I was stunned. "That sounds great."

"Do you have something I can write my number on?"

Miraculously, I found a matchbook cover and a pen nearby and handed them to her. As she scribbled her number on the back, she said, "This is a shared line in the dorm, but just ask for me and someone will come get me."

Then she left.

I turned to the other two guys. They were standing there speechless. And, I suppose, more than a little jealous.

"What the fuck?" they said in unison.

I smiled and went back to bed.

Turned out Marlene wasn't a culinary student, like everyone else I knew from J&W, but was getting a fashion design degree. She had a beautifully curvy figure, milky white skin, a dimpled smile, and medium-length, straight dark hair parted down the middle. She was smart, with an

easy laugh, and we could talk about almost anything. She was cute, and the chemistry between us was instant. Within days, we were sleeping together—in both meanings of the phrase. Which was significant in that I'd never actually slept with a girl before, as in spent the entire night in the same bed, and I'd officially only lost my virginity a few weeks earlier.

The problem was, I was still technically seeing Beverly. Not officially—we never really went out anywhere—but the door wasn't closed.

The Closet

A few nights later, Marlene was in my bed when I heard the apartment's front door swing open. Two female voices echoed through the dark. I knew Bob and Butch were out, which could only mean one thing: Beverly and Lydia. Bob must have given Lydia a key—something I never would have expected, considering we'd only known them for a few weeks.

Thankfully, my room was pitch black when Beverly walked straight in. Marlene and I were both naked. I shot upright, blocking Beverly's view while Marlene ducked down behind me and pulled the covers over herself. She caught on instantly and didn't make a sound.

"Hey, are you awake?" Beverly asked quietly.

"Oh... hi. I didn't expect you to stop by tonight," I stammered, trying to sound like she'd just woken me up. "I was asleep. I have to get up at five. Can we talk tomorrow?"

"Okay, no problem. Sorry for waking you up."

Luckily, she didn't notice the suspiciously human-sized lump hiding beneath the covers behind me. She stepped back, shut the door, and went into the living room. I could hear the two girls talking and laughing out there, trying to keep their voices down. After a minute or so, I heard the front door open... then close. Finally, it was quiet again.

I lay there for a few seconds, waiting for my adrenaline to settle down. Marlene and I started whispering and laughing in half-disbelief until she finally had to pee. She pulled on her panties and a pink tank top and slipped out of the bedroom to use the bathroom—and walked straight into Lydia sitting on the couch.

Apparently, Lydia was waiting for Bob. Beverly had only gone out for a few minutes to buy cigarettes. The plan had been to hang out quietly in our living room while I "slept."

Marlene simply gave Lydia a cheery "Hello" and continued on to the bathroom as though nothing unusual had happened. A few minutes later she came back, quietly shut the bedroom door, and leaned against it.

"Oh shit," she whispered with a nervous laugh. "What are we gonna do?"

Neither of us wanted her to leave, and sneaking her out past Lydia wasn't exactly an option anyway. With Beverly due back any second, we came up with a ridiculous plan: hide Marlene in the hallway closet.

My bedroom actually had two doors: one opened into the living room, while the other opened onto a short hallway by the front entrance. The storage closet was just a few feet away.

I quietly cracked open the hallway door. The closet was surprisingly roomy—about three feet wide and six feet deep—and mostly empty except for a few coats. I quickly unrolled a sleeping bag on the floor, tossed one of my pillows inside, and Marlene climbed in without hesitation. I quietly shut the closet door, slipped back into bed, and hoped for the best.

It was perfect timing. Beverly walked through the front door minutes later. Lydia immediately dropped the dime on me, telling her I had a girl in my room. Beverly stormed in and flipped on the light.

Frozen Out

I don't remember exactly what was said over the next few minutes, but I must have blurted out that Marlene had left right after running into Lydia, or something equally unconvincing. Either way, it didn't matter. Before I knew it, I was standing on the front steps in nothing but my underwear while Beverly totally bitched me out. Outside. In Rhode Island. In January.

Standing there freezing my ass off, I remember saying, "I'm sorry. I didn't think we were that serious! We've only gotten together, like, four times. I didn't expect you to have a key to my apartment and just let yourself in at three o'clock in the morning!"

She was furious, and since she had the house keys, I actually had to beg her to let me back inside before I froze to death. Finally, she relented, threw open the door, and left me with one final parting shot.

"Well, I'm still going to come by to see Bob."

I assumed she meant she'd still be coming around with Lydia. Apparently, that wasn't what she meant.

To my surprise, Bob quickly ditched Lydia for Beverly. So much for that friendship. When our lease was up, the two of them moved into a nicer place on the East Side near Brown University.

Bob and Beverly were married about a year later. I wasn't invited.

*

Years later, I looked Bob up and discovered that he and Beverly were still together, at least ten years after they'd married. More recently, I learned they'd eventually divorced. Somewhere along the way, Bob apparently found Jesus and went into drug abuse recovery.

I never saw Lydia again after that night, and never heard anything more about her. As for Beverly, I don't know what became of her after she and Bob divorced. I hope she's had a happy life.

Marlene

Marlene came from a Jewish family. Her estranged father, who owned one of New York City's largest electrical contracting companies, claimed his firm had wired Radio City Music Hall and Lincoln Center. He threatened to cut her out of his will if she didn't reconcile with him, but she refused. Every year, he still sent her a thousand-dollar birthday check. She wouldn't cash it.

To me, a thousand dollars might as well have been a million, and I tried to talk her into cashing the one that arrived while we were together. She wouldn't budge.

*

My favorite memory of Marlene—and the point when I was pretty much hooked—was when she took me to Thanksgiving dinner at her mother's house in Brooklyn. From the outside, it looked like a fairly modest home. Inside was another story. There was a baby grand piano in the living room and a fourteen-seat dining table beneath a beautiful cut-glass chandelier.

About an hour before dinner, we were sitting on the couch in the living room when the doorbell rang. Marlene answered it, and in walked this tall, thin, elderly man wearing a dark suit with tails and a crisp white shirt. His hair matched the shirt, so he was probably around seventy. He carried an old-fashioned black doctor's bag, the kind physicians used to bring on house calls.

"Is he a doctor?" I asked Marlene after he'd disappeared into the kitchen.

"No!" she laughed. "That's Mel, the butler! He's been serving Thanksgiving dinner—and other big family dinners—for as long as I can remember."

Okay... that was a new one for me. I hadn't expected a butler because the house wasn't some huge mansion or anything. It was just a nice house on a typical Brooklyn street with small lots. You know... Brooklyn, not the Hamptons.

It was my first trip to New York City, and the day after Thanksgiving was my first time in Manhattan. Better yet, I got to experience it with someone who actually lived there. Marlene was the perfect guide.

It was an overcast day with a little nip in the air, and it looked like snow at any moment. Marlene wore a fur jacket, while I had on my buckskin fringe jacket, like something Davy Crockett might have worn. I'd picked it up at a Salvation Army thrift store for fifteen dollars. It was warm, and I thought I looked pretty cool.

But... yeah.

It was 1977.

It worked then.

The first thing we did was take a horse-drawn carriage ride from The Plaza Hotel through Central Park.

I remember feeling very much at ease with her that day. She had a way of making me feel like I belonged in her world, and for once I wasn't thinking about where my life was going or what came next. I was eighteen years old, in Manhattan for the first time, with a girl I could see some sort of real future with.

I was happy. Surprisingly happy.

Whenever I think back on that afternoon, I'm reminded of Joan Baez's "Diamonds and Rust." There's a stanza that always makes me think of that day. She ends it by saying that, speaking only for herself, they could have died right then and there.

When we reached Central Park, it began to snow. Just lightly. And like the song, our breath came out in white clouds, mingled together, and hung in the air. Every time I hear that song, I'm transported back to that carriage ride.

I'm not sure either of us would have happily died right there and then, but... it was definitely romantic, and we were clearly happy together and into each other.

After the carriage ride, we walked down Fifth Avenue past the high-end stores and Christmas decorations that seemed to have appeared overnight. They didn't waste any time switching from Thanksgiving to Christmas. I loved the elaborate window displays with their animated figures and moving trains, along with Christmas music drifting out onto the sidewalks. There's really nothing like Christmas in Manhattan. Or Thanksgiving, for that matter.

Over the next few days, we visited places like Coney Island, Jones Beach, and the Empire State Building—and even went bowling with some of her friends. We also spent an evening at one friend's tiny apartment in a high-rise. That gave me my first glimpse of what it was actually like to live in New York instead of just seeing the sights.

We stayed at her mother's house for the four-day weekend, then took the train back to Providence. While we were there, we slept in separate bedrooms. Of course. It felt a little funny considering we'd already spent plenty of nights together, but we were only eighteen, and her mother wasn't about to let any hanky-panky go on under her roof.

Over the years, I came to know New York fairly well. I've always said, "It's a great place to live... if you're rich."

*

We dated for about six months, and breaking up with her remains one of my biggest regrets. I was barely eighteen, and she was everything I

thought I was looking for. But at the time, I didn't think I was ready for a real relationship. I was in trade school, preparing for a career, and had my sights firmly set on moving to California as soon as an opportunity arose. In my eighteen-year-old head, I'd spend a few years there as a single guy, have some fun, and settle down sometime in my thirties.

I'd missed out on the whole dating experience in high school, and my first real girlfriend had come along only about a year before I met Marlene. So there I was with someone I could actually picture spending my life with, while another part of me kept thinking, *But I haven't done anything yet.*

Looking back, that probably sounds pretty stupid. Maybe it was. But I was eighteen, trying to make up for lost time, and I wanted to have other experiences before making what felt like a lifelong commitment.

I broke up with Marlene, then went back to her, three times. Eventually, she'd had enough and refused to take me back.

I don't blame her.

The Hair

After six months of washing dishes, I was finally up for review and a well-earned promotion. I advanced from the dish pit to Cold Side Cook on the kitchen's front line—a huge step up. My new responsibilities included making the Marriott's should-have-been famous clam chowder, assembling BLTs, shucking oysters on the half shell, and keeping the salad bar and coffee stations stocked and running smoothly.

The clam chowder base was made by the pastry chef using canned clams, potatoes, celery, oregano, and a few other staples. My job was to make the roux and cream sauce that transformed that simple base into something special.

Making it wasn't as easy as it sounded. First came the butter, melted down and carefully skimmed before flour was whisked in and cooked just long enough to develop a rich, nutty flavor. Then came the heavy cream, added slowly until the sauce reached the perfect consistency. Rush any step, and the whole thing would turn into a lumpy mess.

Once it was ready, I'd stir it into the base. As someone who's spent a lifetime eating New England clam chowder, that recipe became the benchmark against which I've judged every bowl I've had since. In my completely biased and wildly un-humble opinion, I've never had a better bowl of clam chowder.

*

One afternoon, I was walking home after a rare morning shift. It was one of those stifling hot days—though still a little cooler than the Marriott kitchen. An early-'70s Chevy Impala carrying what looked like four guys cruised up behind me. As it passed, someone let out a loud, classic wolf whistle.

I was horrified, to say the least.

I'd seen that Impala around the neighborhood before—it was always full of the local punks. From behind, all they'd seen was my long blond hair hanging a third of the way down my back, jeans, and a denim shirt. By sixteen, I'd hit 6'2" and figured I was done growing. Apparently not. Somewhere over the next couple of years, I shot up another two inches and topped out at the 6'4" I am today.

At that point, I was probably somewhere in between, but from a moving car they had no real way to judge my size—or, clearly, my gender.

The mustache probably cleared things up for them as they passed.

I like to think his buddies never let him live it down—even if they'd all been thinking exactly the same thing and simply had the good sense not to whistle first.

There happened to be a barbershop right along my route home. On pure impulse, I walked in, spotted an open chair, and sat down. The barber came over and snapped the cape around my neck.

"So, what are we doing?"

"Cut it off."

Without a word, he went to work. I suspect barbers live for moments like that—the rare license to lop off a foot of hair in one clean pass.

I walked out twenty minutes later with a conventional, collar-length cut. Growing it that long had probably been my private rebellion against all those mandatory brush cuts of my youth, and up until that afternoon, I'd loved every inch of it. Apparently a lot of women did, too.

I immediately started growing it back out, but it never got much past shoulder length again. My days of getting catcalled from moving sedans were officially behind me.

*

By March of 1977, I had settled into my new role as a cold-side cook on the kitchen's front line, working shoulder-to-shoulder with the grill and fry-station cooks. I still didn't quite feel like I deserved the title of "cook," though nobody else seemed to care. My duties also included breaking down the salad bar, cleaning the coffee machine, and sweeping the floors. At the end of every shift, each of us was responsible for scrubbing down our own station.

My "working supervisor" was a man named Tyrone. He was in his mid-thirties and had epilepsy. He was also, without a doubt, the laziest human being I have ever encountered before or since—a remarkably high bar, given that I'm sixty-six years old now.

Tyrone had limited authority over me—essentially just verifying that my stations were clean before I could punch out—but he quickly settled into a comfortable routine: Eric does his work, and mine, while I take smoke breaks.

One afternoon, we were sitting side-by-side in the employee hallway on a scheduled break. I'd just finished the last bite of a sandwich when he casually turned to me.

"When we get back," he said, "I need you to take out the trash and straighten up the walk-in."

Neither of those jobs was mine, and after weeks of silently taking on more and more of his work, I'd had enough.

"You're supposed to be a *working* supervisor, Tyrone! You don't get to dump your job on me! I'm not doing your work anymore, you lazy fucking scumbag!"

Without a word, he launched his mostly full Coke into my face.

This remains the one and only time in my life that I literally "saw red." I lost it. Tyrone must have seen the shock on my face quickly turn to fury,

because he jumped to his feet and took off sprinting down the long hallway. I was right behind him.

Mid-stride, I hurled the ceramic plate still in my hand at him from maybe eight feet away. The plate struck him squarely on the back of his head, shattering into a dozen pieces. He never broke stride.

I still laugh whenever I think about it. There was something very satisfying about that plate exploding off his afro. It was just a perfect shot.

Seconds later, two hotel security guards rounded the corner and cut off our chase. They quickly separated us. Once the adrenaline settled, I went back and finished my shift. I didn't do any of his work, of course.

The next morning, I was called into the HR office to meet with a woman I'd only met once before, during the hiring process.

"I understand you and Tyrone had a bit of a fight last night," she said.

"Yes," I said. "He's been pushing all his work onto me because he thinks he's my boss, which he isn't. He also threw a drink in my face."

"Well, I'm very sorry, Eric, but because this was an altercation between a white person and a Black person, company policy requires us to fire both of you. It's standard procedure when there's an interracial situation like this."

I couldn't believe what I was hearing. Tyrone had been dumping his work on me for weeks, he'd thrown a drink in my face, and now I was being fired along with him because he was Black and I was white? Though... I *had* heaved a plate into the back of his head. But... you know. Whatever.

I was a bit pissed, but I kept my cool. I knew throwing the plate wouldn't exactly absolve me of all wrongdoing, but Tyrone had started the whole thing, and from the way she was talking to me, she seemed almost as unhappy about firing me as I was.

"Between you and me, we've been looking for an excuse to get rid of Tyrone for a long time," she continued. "But because of his race and his medical condition, it was a legal minefield. You're a hard worker, and we really hate to let you go. I am truly sorry."

That explained a lot. I was still irritated that I'd become the convenient way for them to get rid of someone they'd wanted to fire anyway, but at least I knew they didn't consider me the problem.

Before I could fully absorb what was happening, she slid a piece of paper across the desk.

"I put this together for you," she said.

It was a formal letter of reference.

"I hope it helps you find something else quickly. Also, we're officially processing this as a layoff, so you'll be eligible to collect unemployment. Between us, we didn't give Tyrone any such letter. It certainly wasn't warranted. Please don't mention any of this to anyone—especially Tyrone, if you happen to cross paths with him."

That took a lot of the sting out of being fired.

"Thank you. Thank you so much—for both," I said. Even at seventeen, I knew this wasn't something companies normally did.

Almost immediately, my mind shifted to the practical problem of staying afloat. How long would it take me to find another job? How much would unemployment pay, and how long could I collect it? And there was another concern that most seventeen-year-olds filing for unemployment probably didn't have: would putting my name into another government system somehow make it easier for the police to find me?

I'd skipped out on juvenile probation, which meant a warrant for my arrest had automatically been issued. What I didn't know was whether anyone was actively looking for me—or whether filing for unemployment might put me back on their radar.

In the end, I decided I needed the money and took my chances. I walked out of the hotel and headed immediately to the unemployment office downtown to file a claim. The amount I qualified for was pitiful, but it was just enough to keep me afloat until I found my next job.

University Of Hamburger

It was May of 1977, and I was freshly unemployed. Finding one wasn't easy, but within a month, I landed a job as a "cook" at McDonald's. I was really moving up in the glamorous world of fine dining.

My uniform consisted of a brown-and-white vertically striped shirt and a paper hat. I spent my entire first day crammed into a tiny back office, watching hours of corporate training videos on a small video monitor. To make matters worse, my shifts started at a miserable 7:00 AM. I hated getting up early, but I desperately needed the money.

While the morning crowd was manageable, the lunch hour was chaotic. As a cook, you had to work the fry station—managing the french fries, Filet-O-Fish sandwiches, and hot apple and cherry pies—while simultaneously setting up trays of buns to toast, throwing regular and Quarter Pounder patties onto the grill, and dressing burgers with pickles, onions, ketchup, mustard, and special sauce. The kitchen was designed to operate with three cooks, but when someone inevitably called in sick, trying to handle a slammed lunch rush with just two was pure madness.

Like most fast-food operations, they intentionally capped our schedules at thirty hours a week to avoid having to provide healthcare benefits. They did, however, offer a group insurance plan that you could pay for entirely out of your own pocket. How generous.

I was pulling in the minimum wage of \$2.20 an hour, but I took any extra hours they threw my way. Before long, I was one of the most productive workers in the store. Just as I had at the Marriott, I turned the entire operation into a game, challenging myself to see how fast I could complete every task. It kept my brain engaged and made the hours fly.

Our main manager was a guy named Bill Daly, though everyone behind the counter called him "Brain Damage" because he was a notorious pothead. You wouldn't know it just by looking at him—he was clean-cut and thoroughly professional whenever he was on the clock. Off

the clock, though, he frequently invited a few crew members back to his apartment to party. It quickly became a routine, and I spent a fair number of nights hanging out there before making the long walk home buzzed, drunk, or both.

*

One night at Bill's place, a girl who was hanging out with us casually offered to pierce my ear. I thought it might look interesting, right up until she produced her choice of tools: a raw potato, a sewing needle, and a book of matches.

She sliced the potato in half, struck a match, and "sterilized" the tip of the needle in the open flame. Then she held the flat side of the potato behind my earlobe to act as a backstop. With one swift motion, she plunged the hot needle straight through my earlobe and into the potato, pulled it free, and immediately shoved a fake diamond stud into the fresh hole.

I walked out of that apartment feeling like a pirate.

Yaaarrrr.

I rocked the earring for a few months, but one night I forgot to take it out before going to sleep. I woke up the next morning to a few small drops of blood on my pillowcase—the stud had caught on the fabric and torn through my earlobe. I decided to just let it heal over and never tried piercing it again. My pirate days were officially over.

The Blizzard of '78

On February 6, 1978, a legendary blizzard slammed into New England, raging for almost thirty-six hours and dumping twenty-seven inches of snow on Rhode Island. I happened to be working the afternoon-to-closing shift that day. With the city grinding to a halt and zero business coming through the door, most of the staff was sent home early, but I

volunteered to stay behind. I knew I'd get paid for my time, and there was nothing else to do but watch the relentless snowfall anyway. Might as well get paid for it.

During the height of the storm, the owner of our five-store franchise actually flew in and landed a helicopter right outside. Given that the roads were already impassable and there wasn't a customer in sight, none of us could figure out what the hell he was doing there. Why would anyone risk flying a helicopter through a raging blizzard just to check on an empty McDonald's?

We finally closed up around 8:00 PM, and I began my trek home on foot. The wind was howling, visibility was practically zero, and despite the snowplows trying to keep up, four or five inches of fresh snow was already piling up on the main roads.

When I finally reached my neighborhood, Orms Street looked like an Olympic snowboarding half-pipe. The wind had whipped down the street so fiercely that it swept the center of the road clean down to the black asphalt, pushing massive drifts all the way to the tops of the front doors as far down the street as I could see.

I made my way down the driveway of our apartment building and slipped in through the back door. Once inside, I walked through the house and opened our front door out of curiosity. A seamless wall of snow stood in front of me, filling the entire doorway—and didn't fall in. Luckily.

*

Shortly after the blizzard, walking home from another exhausting shift, I realized I couldn't keep this up. I was spent. Bob and Butch were still rolling in from the second shift at two or three in the morning, ready to party, and the constant loud music and drunken knocks on my door meant sleep was a luxury I just wasn't getting.

Unlike them, I had to be out of bed at 6:00 AM to open the restaurant. After eight straight months of averaging about four hours of sleep a night, it was catching up to me. I don't know how my body survived on so little rest, but I knew I had to get out of that early-morning fast-food grind.

By March of 1978, the local job market finally seemed to be picking up. I spotted an ad in the Providence Journal for a position at a popular downtown sandwich shop called Riccotti's. It was a bustling spot down the block from Johnson & Wales College and, conveniently enough, right around the corner from Ye College Pub. I submitted an application, interviewed with the owner, Dave Garagiola, and got hired on the spot.

I gave the McDonald's general manager a proper two-week notice in person. He seemed impressed by the gesture, since most fast-food employees back then just stopped showing up for work. But really, what did corporations expect when they paid people nowhere near a living wage and offered no healthcare?

He looked disappointed but tried to put on a happy face.

"Let me start by saying how impressed I've been with your work ethic and how quickly you learned the job," he began. "We see a real future for you here at McDonald's, and we'd like you to reconsider. We can give you a raise immediately and promote you to Crew Chief in six months. After that, I see you as a candidate for Hamburger University. We'd send you to Chicago for two weeks of training, and you'd come back as a salaried manager with benefits."

I got a kick out of the phrase "Hamburger University." I immediately pictured a bunch of Hamburglers sitting in a classroom while Ronald McDonald used a pointer to walk them through charts and graphs on the blackboard.

But the money they were talking about was surprisingly serious. I had no idea at the time that a seasoned McDonald's manager could eventually make a pretty respectable living.

As slightly tempting as the raise alone might have sounded, I turned it down without a second thought. I knew from firsthand experience that those managers could easily work sixty hours a week, including almost every weekend. I was only eighteen years old. I didn't want to spend sixty hours a week working at McDonald's while everybody else my age was out having a life.

Riccotti's

Riccotti's was a relatively small storefront, but it was very popular and always busy—essentially an upscale version of today's Subway. We had a great old jukebox in the corner that pumped out the big hits of the day like the Bee Gees' "Stayin' Alive," Rose Royce's "Car Wash," Earth, Wind & Fire's "Fantasy," and Boston's "More Than a Feeling."

My manager was a young guy named John, and my main coworker was Reggie. Both were heavily into karate. Whenever the shop was empty, Reggie, who was quite the acrobat, would show off. He'd take a running start toward the front counter, plant his hands on the edge, vault into a handstand, and seamlessly somersault over it, landing perfectly on his feet behind the cash register.

I also worked alongside a young Black woman named Diane working her way through Johnson & Wales College. I didn't know her well and probably wouldn't remember her name today if our paths hadn't unexpectedly crossed again later.

*

Within a few months, I was promoted to Assistant Manager, which came with a nice bump in pay. Along with the raise came more responsibility, including scheduling the staff, training new employees, and helping with the hiring process.

That last responsibility came in particularly handy when Stoner got laid off (or fired—who really knows but him?) from his cooking job at the Marriott. He didn't mention anything about them giving him a letter of recommendation.

At first, he was reluctant to take a job at a sub shop. But after several frustrating weeks of pounding the pavement and striking out interview after interview, his pride finally gave way. He decided he needed the paycheck more than he needed the prestige of being a restaurant cook.

Fortunately, Riccotti's paid well, and the work wasn't difficult. It was certainly a hell of a lot less stressful than working in the Marriott kitchen. I suspect Stoner was a little embarrassed that I, of all people, was the one hiring him—especially since he was five years older than me and had a college degree.

The Ramones

Riccotti's downtown location meant we regularly caught the crowds coming out of the nearby music clubs, especially Lupo's Heartbreak Hotel and The Living Room. One evening, while I was closing by myself, the front doorbell jingled and four long-haired guys wearing matching T-shirts and black leather motorcycle jackets shuffled inside.

As I stood behind the counter taking their orders, I finally noticed what was printed on their shirts: *The Ramones Europe '76*. I had no idea who they were, so I made some casual comment about the name. They chuckled among themselves and told me they were playing a gig at The Living Room in an hour. That didn't impress me much. Lots of bands played there, most of them groups I'd never heard of. It's not like Led Zeppelin or Pink Floyd ever played there.

They ordered a bunch of sandwiches, chips, and sodas, then put some money in the jukebox and picked a few rock songs I didn't usually hear played in the place. They sat down to eat and eventually headed out, leaving behind a table covered in crumpled sandwich wrappers, shredded lettuce, and dirty napkins—and almost eight dollars in loose change. In 1978, tipping at a sandwich shop like Riccotti's was practically unheard of. I'm pretty sure we didn't even have a tip jar on the counter.

It wasn't until much later, when I noticed one of my roommates owned a Ramones album, that it finally clicked. Those guys really had been The Ramones. I immediately recognized Joey Ramone as the lanky guy who had placed the order. Doh.

One night, Bob, Butch, and I were down at Ye College Pub playing pool. Butch pointed out a girl who lived in the apartments upstairs, assuring me she was "always game." I figured I'd give it a shot. Mind you, I was no player. I had no game then, and frankly, I never really developed much of one. Oddly enough, I was pretty decent at breaking the ice—I just lacked the follow-through required to "close the deal."

I don't remember her name. She wasn't particularly pretty, but she wasn't unattractive either—just average, a bit chubby, and maybe a little "trampy-looking." But given what I'd heard about her, I figured she might find me worth considering.

I went over to her seat by the pool table. "Hi... I hear you live upstairs..." I began.

She looked me up and down, mumbled a flat "Yeah," then immediately turned back to the pool game—a swift, brutal shutdown. I hung around like an idiot for another few minutes, trying to actively engage her, but she was clearly not having it, so I finally gave up and did the Walk of Shame back to the bar.

Hours later, we were among the last few stragglers left in the place. I staggered over to where she was leaning against the bar, now, and tried a desperate new tactic. "Hey, I'm pretty hammered, I don't have a car, and it's a very long walk home. Any chance I could crash on your couch? Butch can vouch for me."

Surprisingly, though reluctantly, she agreed.

We headed upstairs, and she led me into her living room, pointing toward a sectional couch. "There you go. I'll get you a blanket and pillow," she said, walking away. A minute later, she came back with both. "The bathroom is over on your left. I have two roommates, so try not to walk

into the wrong door if you need to use it." With that, she ducked into the bathroom herself.

Determined to be Mr. Smooth, I quickly laid out the blanket, tossed the pillow to the side, stripped off every stitch of my clothes, and lay across the sofa. I posed like I was a centerfold in Playgirl magazine—properly fluffed, confident, and waiting.

When she finally stepped out of the bathroom, she paused. She looked at my naked, posed frame, said nothing, turned around, flicked off the light, and walked into her bedroom.

I lay there in the now pitch-black room, drunk and deflated. Geez, I thought, I can't even get a nymphomaniac to have sex with me. I snuck out at the crack of dawn the next morning, hungover and humiliated, my career as a stud muffin apparently over before it had begun.

*

Two weeks later, I was back at the Pub—alone, nursing a Budweiser at the bar while eating a tiny bar-sized bag of chips. The same girl who had walked out on my centerfold pose suddenly walked right up to me, all smiles and high energy.

Before I had a chance to feel embarrassed, she sat down next to me and asked, "Do you want to go upstairs and smoke a joint?"

Color me shocked. I still have no idea what changed her mind. Two weeks earlier, she'd barely acknowledged my existence. Either way, upstairs we went—and this time, straight to her bedroom.

We took a few hits of decent weed, and we were high by the time I bent down and untied my shoes. Sliding them off felt like a silent, confident gesture. Apparently, this was really going to happen. She didn't say a word but started tossing her own clothes aside.

Shortly after, we were right in the middle of a long session—knees and elbows rhythmically banging against the wallpaper—when I caught

something out of the corner of my eye. I paused mid-stroke and looked left. A very large Black woman was sitting in a chair so close to the bed it was practically touching it. Stark naked.

I hadn't heard or seen her come into the room. She could have been sitting there for ten seconds or ten minutes. Somehow, despite the chair being so close to the bed, I'd never noticed her. When she saw the surprised look on my face, she let out a loud laugh and announced, "I'm next!"

"Ohhhh noooo you're not," I thought.

I decoupled immediately, scrambled off the bed, grabbed my pile of clothes, and bolted for the living room. My "date" didn't seem the least bit bothered. She just lay there smiling and laughing at my frantic retreat. I had a sneaking suspicion this wasn't the first time an audience had materialized in her bedroom.

*

The next day, I was working a noon-to-closing shift at Riccotti's. I was in the back prep area mixing a big batch of egg salad when I overheard Diane venting to another employee about her "slutty roommate," who had brought a guy home the night before.

She went on about how she'd had to lie awake listening to the moaning and grunting coming through the paper-thin bedroom wall, along with all the banging and thumping going on against it.

I paused and looked up mid-stir, egg salad clinging to my plastic-gloved hands. Holy shit. Was she talking about me?! Later that day, I casually asked a few questions around the shop and confirmed that, yes, Diane lived in the apartment directly upstairs from Ye College Pub.

My knees and elbows had officially made the local gossip circuit. My fifteen minutes of fame had arrived...! Sort of.

The glory of my neighborhood fame lasted exactly a few days, right up until taking a pee suddenly felt like liquid fire. I shelled out twenty dollars for a clinic visit and a prescription for antibiotics, discovering I'd scored a textbook case of...

Gonorrhea.

As soon as I learned I had gonorrhea, I dragged myself downtown to Ye College Pub to do the responsible thing and tell her she needed treatment. Apparently, the neighborhood grapevine had beaten me to it. That's when I learned a few other guys had come down with the same souvenir, and everyone assumed she was the source. She had apparently skipped town in a hurry.

That little neighborhood had a better communications network than AT&T.

But the universe wasn't done with me yet. Just as the antibiotics were running their course, I developed a maddening itch in my private parts. After several days of scratching myself half-crazy, I finally took a closer look and discovered a cluster of dark brown raised spots that looked like tiny moles, or something. Back to the doctor I went, to discover I had...

Crabs.

My first real experience with casual sex—not counting Beverly, who had basically picked me up—had gifted me both V.D. and a parasite. Getting rid of crabs in 1978 was a nightmare. I had to boil every piece of clothing I owned, wash my bed sheets in heavily bleached water, and shave my privates bald. Super fun!

Needless to say, I was a hell of a lot more careful after that. I never caught either souvenir again.

My GED

About a year after moving to Providence, I decided to get my GED. Running away had forced me to quit high school halfway through my senior year. By one of those strange, life-altering coincidences, the Rhode Island GED testing center was only a block and a half from our apartment.

I'd walked past the building dozens of times. It sat just two doors down from the New York System Coney Island Wieners diner, on Smith Street. It was an old brick municipal-looking building with a dozen concrete steps leading up to the entrance. For some reason, it always reminded me a little of a church.

I climbed the steps and walked inside. The place looked more like an old county courthouse than a testing center, with a row of century-old bank-teller windows separated by worn wood-and-glass partitions and a velvet rope stretched across the front. I walked up to one of the windows.

"Hi. I understand this is where you take the GED?" I asked.

The clerk gave me a quick look, then explained the rules. "Tests are given Monday through Thursday. You can retake the test, but after three tries you need to wait sixty days. There are practice tests, too, if you want to prepare."

"Is there any charge?"

"No charge."

"Can I take the test right now?"

"If you're 18 and can prove it, yes."

Ugh. I hadn't even considered that. I was still several agonizing months away from my eighteenth birthday: March 30.

I walked out and paused on the steps, where a few dispirited guys were flipping through what looked like study material. "Did you pass?" I

asked one. He looked up with a defeated expression. "No. Third time I've failed. Now I have to wait another two months. They gave me this stuff to study," and he waved the pamphlet in his hand at me.

His story made me wonder if I had underestimated the test, but it didn't change my plan. If I failed, I'd just study and take it again.

"Can I take a look at the stuff they gave you?" I asked, pointing to one of the pamphlets he was thumbing through.

Back then, the GED was a five-subject, ten-hour marathon. Even the official names of the tests sounded as bureaucratic as the government office that administered them:

- * *Correctness and Effectiveness of Expression*
- * *Interpretation of Reading Materials in the Social Studies*
- * *Interpretation of Reading Materials in the Natural Sciences*
- * *Interpretation of Literary Materials*
- * *General Mathematical Ability.*

The pamphlet included a handful of sample questions, along with a disclaimer that none of them would appear on the actual exam. The sheer length of the test probably discouraged a lot of people. Ten hours sounded like an eternity to sit in one room, but I figured it still beat six more months of high school classes I was successfully avoiding.

Three months before I could take the test suddenly felt like a long, long time. Finally, on my eighteenth birthday, I walked back in, presented my old learner's permit, and took the test.

I didn't study. I figured I had a decent chance of passing, but I did have one concern. I'd just spent the last fourteen months blowing my brains out with drugs, alcohol, and loud music. Outside of work, my life mostly revolved around finding weed, smoking weed, and drinking cheap beer.

Around that time, I accidentally tuned into an AM radio talk show. The host was discussing the habitual use of marijuana, claiming it led to "...a sense of goallessness. You don't set goals. You don't make any big plans for the future." He argued that your world shrinks until it's entirely about... "finding weed and smoking weed."

Bingo.

Getting my GED was when I finally decided it was time to quit smoking pot.

Real soon.

Not that there was any *huge* hurry, but, you know... Very soon. Ish.

*

It took a few weeks for the results to arrive. My roommates were home and, naturally, we were all very high when I picked the envelope up from beneath the mail slot in the front door. I opened it slowly, prolonging the tension just a tiny bit. Bob and Butch walked over and stood close, waiting for the Big Reveal.

I wasn't overly worried—I thought I'd passed—but I had no idea by how much. Then again, after the previous fourteen months, maybe I'd completely overestimated myself. Bob spotted the numbers before I even got to them.

"Ninety-six average on all tests!" he yelled out.

There were high-fives all around. The impressed looks on their faces actually embarrassed me a bit. Did they think I was an idiot?

*

"Let's do a bong!"

Vinnie's GED Dreams

It wasn't all bad in the 'hood, but there was a sharp distinction between street smarts and the kind of smarts that could help you find a way out. Vinnie and Freddie had plenty of the first kind and none of the second.

Vinnie and Freddie were brothers—literally and figuratively. Vinnie, the older and chunkier of the two, had a darker complexion and a somewhat bigger afro. Freddie had much lighter skin and a blond afro. They were perpetually broke and eternally looking for work, filling the gaps by hustling whatever they could. Some of what they sold was almost certainly stolen. Occasionally, they'd pool their loose change to buy a joint or two from us.

I had many conversations with Vinnie, usually while we sat around getting seriously stoned on bong hits. He was almost always focused, in theory only, on finding a job.

"I've been looking," he'd complain, "but they all want 'experience' or a 'high school diploma'..."

"Then get your GED!" I told him, taking a swig of my beer. After all, I was a high school dropout too. I left out the part about being a straight-A student before I quit. The last thing Vinnie needed was some kid ten years younger bragging about his grades.

"I just got mine," I said. "The testing place is literally two blocks away... right on Smith Street!"

"Really? Well, I didn't do very well in school, though, so I don't know if I'd pass."

"Did Freddie graduate?"

"No, but he's talked about getting his, too."

"I'll help you," I insisted. "They give you practice tests, and I know the material. I can help both you and Freddie at the same time!"

Vinnie got all fired up, smoke leaking out of the corners of his mouth as he tried to talk while still holding in a massive bong hit.

"I really need to get a job and get some money coming in. I'm sick of living with my mom. She's great and all that, but I'm almost thirty and it's embarrassing. I can't even afford to take a girl out."

The conversation always circled back to the same place. He was convinced that if he could just land a job, it would turn his whole life around. For some reason, he looked up to me—again, a guy ten years his junior—because I was working at McDonald's, flipping burgers and pulling down ninety bucks a week with overtime. I couldn't understand it. McDonald's would hire just about anybody. I kept telling him to apply.

*

Each time Vinnie left our apartment, he was convinced this time was going to be different. This time he was serious about getting his shit together. This time he was actually going to follow through. I rooted for him. But after the third or fourth version of that same conversation, I began to realize it probably wasn't going to happen.

The irony was that the radio host had been describing me, too. Marijuana had quietly stolen my sense of direction. I'd escaped home and managed to support myself, but beyond that, I had no concrete plan. My life had settled into a holding pattern of working, getting high, drinking beer, and doing it all over again the next day.

*

Another memorable character who briefly drifted through our apartment was JuJu, Butch's younger brother. He genuinely scared me. JuJu was a good-looking, clean-cut guy, in shape and well dressed, with a light-brown complexion. He could be cool and somewhat charming one minute, then turn genuinely menacing the next.

One afternoon, I was hanging out at home, alone, when there was a knock at the door. I opened it to find him on the stoop.

"Is Butch around?" he said. "I'm his brother, JuJu. I just hitchhiked here from New Bedford."

I invited him in and told him Butch would be off work at 3:00. He could hang out and wait for him if he liked. All I knew about JuJu was what Butch had told me: he'd spent about a year in some kind of juvenile detention facility and was a guy you didn't want to mess with. But the guy in front of me looked pretty harmless at first glance.

I sat at one end of the couch while he took a chair beside the coffee table.

"Want a beer?" I asked.

"Sure, but do you have any weed? I was hoping to score some while I'm here."

I told him I did, tossed a baggie onto the coffee table, then headed into the kitchen to grab us a couple of beers.

By the time I got back a minute later, he was already rolling a joint. I passed him an open beer and sat back down.

"So, what did Butch tell you about me?" he asked, his eyes narrowing.

"Not much, really," I lied. "Just mentioned he had a brother named JuJu. Said something about you getting into some trouble a few years back, but he didn't go into any details."

He gave me a slight smile—more of a creepy smirk, really—that seemed to say, "Yeah, right."

He casually pulled a switchblade from a holster on his belt that I'd completely missed beneath his untucked shirt. He started twirling it through his fingers, then suddenly snapped the blade open, looked me right in the eye, and said, "BOO!" before laughing.

I went along with the "joke" and laughed too, though inside I was a little freaked out. "Wow. Cool knife!" I said, doing my best to sound impressed.

He didn't respond. He just turned the blade downward and stabbed it into a magazine on the coffee table, leaving the knife standing upright. A few seconds later, he pulled it out of the magazine, tossed it onto the table, and picked up his beer.

By now, I was totally leery of this guy, but I figured if there was one thing weed was good for, it was mellowing people out. I quickly packed the bong, passed it to him, and even lit it for him. He took a big hit and said, "Thanks." Within thirty seconds, he was visibly more relaxed, though the menacing edge never fully went away.

In the middle of a perfectly normal conversation, he'd suddenly look at me and quietly say something like, "There were kids in Juvie that killed people. I never killed anyone... that you know of."

Then he'd look away and laugh, then turn back to me again and say. "Or maybe I did." Dead seriously. Then back to the smirk.

I was very happy when Butch finally showed up.

I met JuJu once or twice more after that, and our interactions always had that same unsettling mix of laughter and veiled threat.

The Weasel

Phil was another fraternity brother, like most of the people in my immediate circle at the time. I never particularly liked him. Around Bob and Butch, he was a shameless suck-up, and as a friend he turned out to be totally two-faced. He came from an upper-middle-class family—his father owned a large locksmith company—and he had the one thing no one else did: a car. It was a big, three- or four-year-old Oldsmobile Cutlass, brown with a plush cream interior.

Phil dealt a little speed and some weed, strictly small-time, but acted like he was some kind of player—a big man on campus—when he was really just a weasel. I have two stories about him that I've never forgotten.

*

One night, Phil and I ended up back at his apartment in Pawtucket with another friend of his whose name I've long since forgotten. It was a slight step up from our tenement, but still far from respectable. We were sitting at his kitchen table, taking big hits off a small bong, listening to music, and playing poker.

It was around 12:30 in the morning when someone knocked on the door. Phil looked up at me with a concerned expression. Neither of us was expecting anyone, and at that hour, sitting there stoned with a bong on the table, an unexpected knock wasn't exactly welcome. He got up and peered through the peephole, then seemed to relax at whatever he saw and opened the door.

The instant he cracked it open, the door flew inward, knocking him back. Three rough-looking guys burst into the apartment. One of them quickly shut the door behind them. The three of us were pretty wasted and had no idea what the hell was happening, but the adrenaline kicked in and killed a fair portion of our buzz.

One of the intruders pulled a knife.

"Where are the drugs?!" he said to Phil.

Phil came unglued, staring at the knife, crying and begging. "I don't have any! I'm... I'm... out! I'm out!"

The guy with the knife grabbed Phil by the arm, dragged him into the bedroom, threw him onto the mattress, and screamed, "Where are the drugs?!" Then he started hurling anything he could get his hands on at him, including handfuls of spare change from a jar, while Phil cowered on the bed, screaming like a little girl.

I kept my hands down and stayed calm. I'd gotten lucky in bad spots before, but standing there against the wall, I just read the room and hoped I was reading it right. I figured the smartest move was to stay relaxed, look confident, and make it clear that I was just a casual acquaintance passing through and no threat to anyone. Everything in my posture said:

Don't look at me. I barely know the guy.

They clearly knew Phil, and I assumed he'd sold drugs to at least one of them before. Whoever he'd seen through that peephole was someone he knew well enough to open the door for. They knew his friend, too. They didn't know me. So, for the most part, they left me alone. In fact, I had some cash in my pocket and a wallet they never even searched me for, while they got Phil's and his friends. It was pretty funny, in a way. To me, at least. Luck of the Irish, I guess.

*

In the end, the robbers made off with \$600 in cash, which they found in Phil's clever hiding place: beneath the garbage bag at the bottom of his kitchen trash can. I thought it was interesting that the punks even thought to look there. They also stole jewelry, six of his suits, the speed Phil had lied about, the bong we'd been using, and his car keys. Most incredibly, they even stole his six-week-old Doberman puppy.

Phil's beat-up friend left, and Phil started packing a bag. We headed downstairs to his car, where he used a wire coat hanger to pop open the driver's-side door. Then his locksmith training took over. With a hammer and screwdriver, he smashed out the ignition switch and started the car, leaving the screwdriver jutting ridiculously out of the steering column. Probably not the procedure recommended in the *Official Guide to Locksmithing*... but it worked.

Before taking off, I walked around to the passenger side and noticed something sticking out of a snowbank a few feet away from the car. I reached down and pulled it out.

It was his car keys.

Apparently, the punks had decided not to steal the car after all and had simply tossed the keys into the snowbank.

We both stood there staring at the keys in my hand. Then, without saying a word, both our heads swiveled in sync toward the screwdriver sticking out of his freshly mangled steering column.

Super funny. Now.

We drove straight to his parents' house near Boston. He never slept another night in his Pawtucket apartment. Within a week, he'd moved into a new place, nowhere near Pawtucket.

I was shocked that I'd come through the whole thing without a scratch. Phil had been terrorized and robbed, his friend had been beaten up, and somehow, I'd walked away unharmed and still had everything I went in with.

The Trip

The second story is harder to tell. I wasn't in any physical danger, but it scared the living shit out of me at the time.

One night, Phil and I were hanging out. We didn't have any weed, but he had some LSD. I'd never done acid before and had no idea how important it was to be with someone I trusted.

Unfortunately, Phil knew a hell of a lot more about the trials and tribulations of taking acid than I did, and proceeded to have fun playing with my head all night.

He started by putting on an album called *The Worst of Jefferson Airplane*, loaded with the kind of late-'60s psychedelic sounds that really fuck with your head when you're tripping. Before long, I was hallucinating. The stereo seemed to sprout green plants, and the lightly striped wallpaper began to melt before my eyes. I was seriously freaked out.

Then he put on a robe, pulled the hood over his head, and turned to face me. Whether it was the acid or the darkness, his face seemed to disappear completely. All I could see were two tiny points of light where his eyes should have been, piercing the darkness beneath his hood. That's when he began repeating, "I am Jesus," weaving in a stream of religious-sounding quotations he was probably making up on the spot. I just sat there staring at him, scared shitless and having no idea what to do.

Later, he put on a Beatles album, and I heard what sounded like my family singing "All You Need Is Love"—a desperate, distant message meant only for me. I can still remember how real it sounded.

The trip finally wore off sometime the next morning, and Phil drove me back to the apartment. Once we got there, he went into the kitchen and started quietly bragging to Bob and Butch about how he'd spent the night fucking with my head. Apparently, he didn't realize I could hear him. To their credit, Bob and Butch didn't seem very impressed.

Hearing him brag about it somehow made the whole thing worse. He hadn't just gotten carried away while we were tripping. He'd known exactly what he was doing.

Bob Shits His Pants

It's a good thing I'm not using last names in this book—I don't think Bob would appreciate this story getting out.

Yes, we partied pretty hard back then, but mostly it was just pot and beer. We dabbled in harder drugs sometimes, mostly on the occasional weekend when the local weed supply completely dried up and nobody had anything to sell.

One night, nobody had any weed, so Butch and I ended up at a neighbor's apartment doing cocaine. It was my first time trying it. Bob was looking for a much bigger buzz than a few lines could offer, so he decided to drop a hit of LSD the dealer happened to have.

Big mistake.

As we were finally leaving the party, the cops showed up. We had just hit the sidewalk outside the house when two police cruisers pulled up out of nowhere, tires screeching. Bob freaked out and took off running. Butch and I didn't have anything on us, but we were pretty pumped up on coke and had zero desire to deal with the cops. I had an outstanding juvenile warrant hanging over my head, so I had even more reason to run. We were right behind him.

The cops jumped out and came after us on foot, but we had a few seconds' head start and knew the neighborhood a hell of a lot better than they did. We sprinted through dark driveways, cut through backyards, and jumped fences. Somehow, we managed to outrun them. We crashed through our back door, slammed it shut, and locked it behind us.

While Butch and I were catching our breath, Bob just stood there, completely unmoored by the acid and the adrenaline, muttering over and over, "I'm sorry, Butch... I'm sorry. I shit my pants. I'm sorry."

I had no idea why he kept apologizing specifically to Butch. It certainly wasn't Butch's fault he'd shit his pants. My first thought was that the acid had simply *convinced* Bob that he'd shit his pants.

It hadn't.

Bob had, in fact, shit his pants.

When he finally pulled down his pants right there in the kitchen, I was treated to the sight of a wide, liquid-looking black streak running down the back of one leg. That was my cue to leave the room. Immediately.

For my part, the adrenaline from the chase eventually gave way to the lingering effects of the cocaine. Wow. No wonder people get hooked on it; it was an *incredible* high.

The catch is that, for me, the very first time really was the best. Every time afterward, I found myself chasing that first-time rush, and it never quite measured up.

Over the next twenty years, I did cocaine occasionally, usually at parties. I was never a full-blown cokehead, but if it was around, I usually wasn't inclined to say no. Fortunately, I never developed a dependence on it.

Eventually, I got tired of chasing it. It simply wasn't worth the physical toll—staying up all night doing lines, then drinking alcohol just to try to level back out.

As the years passed, cocaine became an increasingly rare occurrence for me—eventually maybe once a year. By the time I was in my late 30s I was more than ready to leave that part of my life behind. And, with rare exceptions, I did.

I'm Eighteen

On March 30, 1978, Alice Cooper and I finally turned eighteen.

Or at least I did.

It was a day I'd been waiting for most of my life. When I was seven or eight years old, eighteen seemed so impossibly far away that I honestly wasn't sure I'd ever live to see it.

Yet here it was.

Until that day, I'd carefully hidden my long-expired learner's permit, which I'd kept solely as proof of my identity. Everyone I worked with, lived with, or hung around with believed I was two years older than I really was.

To celebrate my "20th" birthday, Bob, Butch, and I headed down to Ye College Pub for beer and pool. We walked into the bar, and a huge "HAPPY BIRTHDAY!" banner stretched across the room, hanging from the ceiling. Someone lit seven shots of Jack Daniel's on fire and slid them toward me. My assignment was simple: drink all seven.

Oof.

I blew out the first one and knocked it back, then did the same with two more in rapid succession, chasing them with a few long pulls from the Budweiser someone handed me. Then I blew out the remaining four.

"I gotta take a break," I said. "I'll pass out if I drink four more shots right now."

"No! You gotta drink all of them!" Bob and several others protested. But I refused, and we wandered over to the pool table with the remaining shots and a beer in tow.

I finished the remaining shots over the next few hours, along with several more beers. By closing time, I literally couldn't walk. Unfortunately, home was a mile and a half away, including a fairly steep climb past the State Capitol Building.

Bob and Butch each threw one of my arms over their shoulders and half-carried, half-dragged me up the hill.

Somewhere along the way, I decided it was finally time to tell them the truth about my age.

"Hey... there's something I need to tell you. I'm sorry I never told you before, but I couldn't..."

"I'm only eighteen. Not twenty. I was a runaway, and I couldn't tell anyone my real age. Even the people I worked for thought I was two years older."

Their response?

"Yeah... sure you are."

Apparently, they didn't believe me. I pulled out my old learner's permit and tried to show them, but after a quick glance, they just laughed it off.

"You... don't believe me?" I asked, completely baffled. "Why would I lie to make myself younger?"

They still weren't buying it. It wouldn't really surprise me if they'd discovered the truth long before that—maybe by snooping through my room while I was out and finding the permit hidden in my dresser drawer. I never carried it with me, so that would have been the only way.

To this day, I have no idea... but it seems pretty likely they snooped. They may have even told Stoner at some point—possibly pretty early on, for all I know.

I told Stoner the next day. He just looked at me and said, "Wow... really? That's cool, man." Then he changed the subject.

No big deal.

It pretty much blew my mind. I'd spent more than a year guarding this huge secret, terrified of what might happen if anyone found out. Now I could finally tell the truth, and nobody seemed to give a shit.

*

When summer hit, Stoner and I would sometimes hop on his bike and roar toward the coast. I didn't know how to ride a motorcycle and certainly didn't have a motorcycle license, but his bike had a double seat and a sturdy sissy bar on the back to lean against. Thankfully, this meant I wasn't forced to hug him from behind while we rode.

We'd fill a gallon beverage cooler with "refreshment"—Genesee Cream Ale, poured directly from our own beer tap in the living room. Then we'd pull on our heavy leather jackets in the suffocating ninety-degree heat and humidity and blast off toward the southern Rhode Island coast. Some of the greatest beaches in New England—Narragansett, Sand Hill Cove, Scarborough, and Misquamicut—were only a forty-minute ride away.

We also brought along plastic cups, of course, because how else were we going to drink and drive at sixty miles an hour? On a motorcycle. The true test of physical coordination was pouring draft beer from a sloshing cooler into a flimsy plastic cup without losing most of it to the wind or spraying the lucky driver trailing behind us. I quickly figured out the trick: I had to angle the cup at forty-five degrees while carefully pouring, stop when it was about half full, and then pass the cup up to Stoner. Once he was set, I'd pour one for myself.

There was something wonderfully freeing about those rides. I was eighteen, finally legal, with nowhere I had to be and nobody waiting for me at home. But there was something else, too. It felt strange just getting out of the city. My world had gradually shrunk to whatever I could reach on foot—work, the apartment, the pub, downtown Providence. I'd almost forgotten there was another whole world out there.

Just leaving Providence for a few hours felt like a big adventure.

*

One afternoon along the way, Stoner spotted a huge, dark snake lying dead in the middle of the main road through a small town. Just off the road was a bench beneath a shady tree, and he suggested we pull over and take a break. It was a good opportunity to have more than half a small plastic cup of beer without trying to pour it at sixty miles an hour.

We parked the Harley under the tree, grabbed our cooler, and settled onto the bench. After a few minutes, Stoner looked back at the dead snake in the road and was suddenly inspired.

Without saying a word, he got up, waited for a break in the passing cars, and walked out onto the asphalt. He casually picked up the limp carcass and tossed it over a low-hanging tree branch that stretched over the road. Then he came and sat back down beside me as we both cracked up.

The snake hung high enough that it wouldn't actually hit anyone's windshield, but low enough that there was no way you could miss it.

We sat there drinking our beer and watching people's reactions as they drove by and spotted the snake. Mostly confusion. Occasionally horror.

Eventually, we climbed back on the bike and roared off toward the coast, leaving the snake hanging there.

Taking A Spin With Stoner

I had settled into a pretty good rhythm at Riccotti's. The hours were normal, the pay was pretty good compared with the minimum wage I'd made at McDonald's or the Marriott, and Stoner was now working there, too—though by pure chance, we never actually worked the same shifts.

Unfortunately, Riccotti's filed for Chapter 11 just four months after I was hired. Being one of several higher-paid assistant managers, I was laid off while, ironically, Stoner was kept on. I had only been on the payroll for about four months, but I really liked that job. Of the few jobs I'd had by then, it was hands-down my favorite. As disappointed as I was, losing the job definitely worked out for the best in the long run.

*

One beautiful summer Saturday, Stoner and I both happened to have the day off. Stoner had started dating a girl named Robin who, by a wild coincidence, I'd gone to high school with and knew from Bernon Park, right behind my childhood home. She was short—maybe 5'3" max—thin, with a feisty personality to match her fiery red hair. She was average in the looks department and definitely more tomboy than girly-girl, but she was fun to be around and Stoner seemed to be really into her. She also had a cute little terrier that she took everywhere. He was a smart little guy—kind of like Eddie from *Frasier*, years later.

Butch was still living with us, at this point. He was locked in an on-again, off-again relationship with a wild city girl named Lori. She was only seventeen to Butch's twenty-one—underage, as it were—but Butch didn't seem to lose any sleep over that. Lori was cute, tough, and very street-smart, with long brown hair tucked under a bandanna, and enough cheap jewelry to give her a kind of gypsy look. She could be loud and opinionated one minute and soft as a kitten the next.

I didn't trust her as far as I could throw her.

She was a total little hooligan. She'd regularly come back to the apartment and proudly show us the random things she'd shoplifted. Before long, I started noticing little things going missing around our place, too—a pack of cigarettes, a nice lighter, bits of weed. But she was charming and sexy, so she got away with it.

For my part, I had just started seeing a girl named Annie. I can't recall exactly how we met, though it was likely through Robin. Annie was also from Woonsocket, but she was two years behind me in school. She was attractive, outgoing and fun. All in all, it was an interesting, lively group.

On this particular Saturday, all six of us somehow had the day free, so we decided to head for the coast. Robin had a four-door sedan built for five, but there were six of us. Stoner drove, with Robin in the passenger seat holding her terrier on her lap. The other four of us were crammed into the back. I sat directly behind Stoner, next to the door, with Annie beside me, Butch beside her, and Lori against the opposite door.

We headed for Scarborough Beach at the southern tip of Rhode Island, about a forty-minute drive from Providence. It was scorching—high eighties with thick humidity—and the beach was packed.

We only stayed for a few hours before the heat and suffocating humidity—not to mention the sand coating every inch of our sticky skin—became too much. We packed up our gear and headed back to the car.

To this day, I've never been a fan of actually sitting on a beach. As much as I absolutely love being near the ocean, sitting on a blanket in the sand all day has zero appeal to me.

*

We piled back into the sedan around 4:00 PM. The weekend traffic was building, so Stoner decided to bypass the main highway and take the back roads. The route was beautiful—semi-rural, lined with historic stone walls built back in the 1700s and shaded by apple, maple, and oak trees.

We had good music playing on the radio and a warm summer breeze blowing through the wide-open windows.

Unfortunately, the roads were also narrow and curvy. Crammed into the back seat, the constant swaying was making us a bit queasy, and Stoner wasn't helping matters by taking the curves a little too fast.

Suddenly, as we whipped around a sharp bend at about 50 miles per hour, the tires hit a big patch of loose sand and Stoner lost control of the car.

The car went into a... deeply concerning, let's say... 360-degree spin. Just as we whipped back around to face the direction we'd been going, the driver's-side front quarter panel slammed into a huge boulder at the edge of someone's driveway. The impact bounced us off the rock and sent us head-on into a tree.

There were no airbags back then. The interior became a blur of shattering glass and bouncing bodies.

Robin was thrown violently forward and got pretty banged up, with cuts and bruises but nothing broken. But her little terrier punched a hole in the windshield and sailed right through it. I don't recall what happened to the poor dog, but I have a vague recollection that he didn't survive.

Stoner somehow broke two fingers and ended up with deep bruising across his chest.

In the back seat, Butch suffered a broken rib, and Lori's head and hands were badly cut by the jagged metal of the window frame. Annie had tried to brace herself by stiff-arming the back of the front seat as we spun; one of the impacts snapped her forearm like a dry twig.

As for me...

I was the only person in the vehicle who walked away completely unscathed.

*

The strangest thing about the entire ordeal was what happened the moment the car started to spin. Somehow, I managed to stay calm. I remembered hearing that stiffening up during a crash was the worst thing you could do, so I made a conscious effort to stay loose and just go with it. At the same time, the entire world seemed to shift into a strange, hyper-vivid slow motion.

Whether staying loose actually saved me from getting hurt or I was just incredibly lucky, I don't know. At the time, though, I was convinced it had worked.

The slow-motion phenomenon reminded me of a bizarre incident from my childhood. My sister and I were playing in the driveway, using hockey sticks to slap a ball against the garage door. At one point, I turned away from her for a second. For reasons I don't recall, she chose that exact moment to wind up and swing her hockey stick like a baseball bat.

I turned back around just in time to see the blade of the stick traveling at maximum velocity, maybe two inches from my upper lip.

Just like the car crash, the entire universe ground to a halt. Time stretched out. I could see the stick perfectly, but my body was powerless to move away from it. I watched it frame by frame in that last split second as it smashed hard into my mouth.

It hurt like hell, of course, but I was so awestruck by the slowing down of time that the pain was almost an afterthought.

I suppose that says something about me. I'm just not entirely sure what.

Life With Stoner

Our living situation shifted once Bob had left our dump to live with Beverly on the much-nicer East Side, prompting Butch and me to move in with Stoner a few doors away. A month later, Butch moved in with Bob and Beverly, leaving just Stoner and me sharing the apartment. My rent jumped to a staggering \$45 a month, but it was nice to only have to share a bathroom with one roommate instead of two.

I was unemployed for the entire summer of 1978. My sudden layoff from Riccotti's left me in the uncomfortable position of borrowing money from Stoner just to cover the bare essentials—rent, groceries, utilities, and what little I was spending on weed and beer.

Borrowing money from Stoner changed the dynamic between us. He started keeping closer tabs on me—where I was going, what I was doing, and who I was with. I got the distinct feeling he was worried I wasn't looking hard enough for work, which wasn't the case at all. I've never been good at sitting around doing nothing, and being unemployed only made me more restless.

Now that I was unemployed, I kept thinking about that radio psychologist I'd heard a few months earlier and what he'd said about "goallessness." The more I thought about it, the more I realized he had perfectly described my new circle of friends—and, to a lesser extent, me. Until recently, we'd all had jobs, but outside of work, our lives revolved around little more than finding weed and smoking weed. And drinking beer, of course.

I had vague long-term goals, but up to that point, I hadn't actually done much to move toward them besides earning my GED. Just holding down a job didn't count. Being unemployed didn't mean I cared any less about finding work, or that I was content to sit around mooching off my roommate.

I didn't fully quit smoking weed, but I cut back quite a bit. Having no money certainly helped. Still, if I asked, Stoner would front me a small amount, and there was always the household keg of beer on tap. Both went straight onto my growing ledger of debt. And by "ledger," I mean he kept a yellow legal pad with every debt I owed him written on it.

Outside of the financial strain, we still got along very well. I think he viewed me as a sort of protégé—a younger friend he could mentor in all things hippie. What I don't think he understood was that I had no interest in being his protégé long-term.

I liked Stoner and had no desire to judge him for his choices. But in five years I'd be his age—twenty-four at that point—and I didn't want to still be living in a rundown tenement house where robberies and assaults were common.

I kept that mostly to myself.

Blood Brothers

One warm summer night in August, Stoner and I were hanging around the apartment listening to music, bored and looking for something to do, when a lightbulb went off in his head.

"Hey, man," he said. "I scored some LSD a few days ago. Are you up for a trip?"

After what had happened with Phil the first time I took acid, I was extremely hesitant. I reminded him how badly that had gone, but Stoner waved it off. According to him, the problem hadn't been the acid. The problem was Phil.

"You were mind-fucked by that asshole, Phil," Stoner insisted. "You don't have to worry about that with me, man. It's a beautiful experience if you actually know how to approach it."

Enough time had passed since that first disaster, and my curiosity eventually got the better of me. I gave in, and we both dropped.

It took quite a while to kick in, but I vividly remember the exact moment the drug took hold. We were sitting on the dining room floor, leaning back against the dark purple Victorian wallpaper, with the heavy Queen Anne-style dining table looming over us to my left. Suddenly, the entire room took on a vibrant, electric glow. Ritchie Blackmore's Rainbow was playing "Man on the Silver Mountain" on the turntable, and suddenly the music sounded impossibly sharp and crystal clear, as if the band were playing right there in the room with us.

When the album ended, Stoner switched over to the AM radio. We spent the next hour laughing hysterically over stupid things and trying to dial into a local call-in station to request "Hotel California" by the Eagles. Incredibly, on our third try, we actually got through to the DJ.

By the time our request finally came through, we were seriously tripping out. At some point, the conversation somehow turned to American Indian rituals Stoner had read about.

"They'd trip out on peyote, sit around the fire, and have this blood-brother ritual," he explained. "They'd take out a hunting knife, make a clean cut right across the palm of one hand, and then clasp their hands together to mix the blood."

I would later find out that Stoner's version of the ritual owed more to Hollywood than American Indian tradition, but in the middle of an acid trip in 1978, it sounded totally legit.

Before I could object, Stoner went into the kitchen and produced a knife.

The details are a bit hazy now, but I remember lightly scratching my palm—just enough to draw a tiny bit of blood. Stoner did the same. I know we didn't cut very deep, because I don't even remember needing a Band-

Aid afterward. The next day, the only evidence was a few blood-spotted tissues and a tiny mark on my palm.

Not exactly the Hollywood version of blood brothers, but close enough.

Suffice it to say that we were, at the very least, good friends. That's worth remembering, considering what happened between us just a few months later.

Hall Institute

Sometime in the first few months of 1978, my parents finally found me.

By then, I was only a month or two away from turning eighteen and had already been living on my own for more than a year. My parents apparently made the practical decision not to force me back home. They knew it was pointless; even if they dragged me back, I'd only turn around and leave again the second I turned eighteen.

To this day, I never did find out exactly how they tracked me down. I suspect word simply leaked out on the grapevine, since a handful of people in Woonsocket knew where I was living by then. If I had to place a bet, I'd say my brother Mark found out through mutual connections and broke the news to them.

Even though my parents had decided to leave me alone, I still worried about having skipped out on my juvenile probation. I kept wondering if the authorities were still actively looking for me, and whether the warrant would simply disappear once I turned eighteen. I assumed my juvenile record would be wiped clean, but I had no way of knowing. We didn't have cell phones and Google to look up legal statutes in a matter of seconds like we do today.

My mother, to her credit, actually came down to visit me a few times, usually bringing something she'd cooked for me. She was a good cook, and I appreciated the free food. She always politely declined the beer I offered her, though.

I remained leery about her knowing exactly where I lived. Knowing how controlling she could be, I expected the worst. Surprisingly, though, she left me alone. It might have been a different story if I'd been living around the corner from them in a nicer neighborhood, but the distance and the grime seemed to keep her impulses at bay.

I know I've written a lot of harsh things about my mother in these pages, but I love her, and I know she loved me. I just couldn't live under the same roof with her. As a kid, though, your choices are limited.

*

For my father's part, he never did come to visit me in Providence. But he did do one thing that literally changed the course of my life: he sent me a letter.

That may not sound like much, but it meant he'd seen something in the newspaper, thought of me, clipped it out, written me a note, and gone to the trouble of mailing it. My father wasn't a man who said much, especially when it came to feelings. Every once in a while, though, he found another way.

Inside the envelope was a little yellow note with the words, "Check this out, Dad" written in his familiar handwriting. Along with it was a torn-out corner from the classified employment section of the *Providence Journal*. A small, three-inch-square advertisement had been circled several times in pen.

The ad was for the Comprehensive Employment and Training Act (CETA), a federal program administered locally to provide job training and employment opportunities for unemployed and underemployed people. The ad listed a phone number to call for more information.

By that point, I'd been out of work for four months and was desperate for any opportunity that might lead to a steady paycheck, so I called the number first thing the next morning.

The person on the other end walked me through what would happen next. I'd start with an aptitude test designed to identify my natural strengths and abilities. Then I'd meet with a career counselor to go over the results and choose from dozens of technical courses offered by local trade schools and community colleges. Best of all, when I finished the

course—anywhere from a few weeks to nearly a year later, depending—the program would even help place me in a job in my new field.

The icing on the cake was that they would actually pay me \$100 a week to attend classes.

After four months of unemployment, that last detail immediately caught my attention.

I had no idea what to expect from it, or whether it would actually lead to a real career... but I was definitely interested.

*

I made an appointment for the aptitude test, but the earliest opening was an agonizing two weeks away. When the day finally arrived, the exam turned out to be nothing like any test I'd ever taken. Some of it involved strictly timed exercises—flipping over wooden pegs or fitting pegs into corresponding holes as quickly as possible—to gauge various aptitudes. There were more conventional questions, too, some of which reminded me of the IQ test I'd taken five years earlier.

As I raced against the clock, I remember thinking that if I was one second too slow sticking a round peg into a round hole, they'd probably assign me to the "Dish Washing 101" training program.

The results came back a few days later. I sat down with the career counselor, who pulled out a long list of occupations, each with a percentage showing how closely my test results matched. Surprisingly, my highest score was for nursing. Yeah, that was an immediate, hard "no" for me.

The next strong match on the list was auto mechanic.

"I love cars. I like working on cars," I told him, sitting up. "I'll take it! When does it start?"

The counselor shook his head. "That course actually just started a few days ago. There won't be another opening for two months."

I couldn't wait that long. I needed to get started as soon as possible and get some money coming in.

We kept scanning down the page. Frustratingly, every course I was a good match for started too far in the future. Finally, the counselor sighed and took another look at the list.

"Well," he said, "there's Drafting. But your scores only show about a fifty percent match for it. So... it's not a great fit."

I remembered the angled desks and heavy wooden drafting boards I'd seen in a high school classroom. The title "Draftsman" sounded vaguely familiar and, more importantly, it sounded "professional." Beyond that, I had no idea what the job actually involved.

"When does it start?"

"In two weeks."

"I'll take it."

The Selection

It's strange to think how much of my future came down to a series of coincidences: my father spotting that little newspaper ad, the auto mechanic course being unavailable, and a drafting class I knew nothing about and barely qualified for starting at exactly the right time.

There was just one problem: choosing the course didn't mean the school was going to accept me. Before I could start collecting that \$100 a week, I had to pass a three-day "Mini-Course" trial at the Hall Institute of Drafting and Design.

Forty people were competing for only twenty spots.

There was also the minor logistical hurdle of getting to and from the school every day. I didn't own a car, but after studying the local bus schedules, I pieced together a combination of bus routes that would get me there on time. It meant forty-five minutes and two bus transfers each way, but it worked.

*

Hall Institute of Drafting and Design was an expensive private technical school—the tuition alone was \$4,000—but CETA covered everything, from tuition and books to my \$100 weekly stipend.

The structure was pretty unusual for a technical school. We had to punch in and out on a timecard just like we were going to work, and classes ran eight hours a day. Blue jeans were strictly forbidden; we were required to wear a collared shirt and a tie. The administration's philosophy was clear: they weren't just teaching us drafting; they were teaching us how to function in a professional workplace.

To meet the requirement, I had to get creative. I showed up to the three-day mini-course wearing the blue button-down shirt I'd found in my bedroom closet at my first apartment, a tie I'd literally scavenged from the burnt-out building behind our tenement house and hung onto for some reason, a pair of brown, threadbare corduroy pants I'd owned forever, and old blue Reebok sneakers. My shoulder-length hair completed the look. It wasn't exactly GQ, but everything was clean and ironed.

By the end of the third day, I was seriously sweating my chances. Half of us weren't going to make the cut, and I really had no idea if I would be one of them. This wasn't just taking a test; I was good at those. This was about whether you actually had the raw skills to do the job.

One by one, the candidates were called into the admissions office to meet with both the admissions counselor, Bob Burns, and the school's vice president, Charlie Townsend. My quick chat with Charlie was pleasant but uneventful. I suspect his role was mostly to make sure

everyone left feeling they'd been treated fairly, whether they made the cut or not.

Finally, it was my turn. I was shown into Bob's office and took a seat directly in front of his desk. After a minute of polite small talk, he looked down at my work, then back up at me.

"So, Eric... In drafting, there are two main things: line work and printing," Bob said evenly. "Your lines need to be perfectly even and consistent, and your lettering needs to be neat and legible. To be honest with you—your line work is pretty bad. And your printing is worse."

My stomach dropped, but I tried not to panic. Bob seemed to be leading up to something I very much didn't want to hear. Like I wasn't going to make the cut.

Somewhere over those three days, it had stopped being about the hundred dollars a week. This felt like my first real chance to start building some kind of future for myself, and I was terrified that door was about to close.

At that point, there was nothing left to do but tell him exactly what I was feeling.

"Bob, I don't know what else to say, but... please let me in. This could change my life..."

He didn't say anything for several seconds. He just studied me.

I don't know exactly what Bob saw in me at that moment. My line work was bad, my printing was worse, and even the CETA aptitude test had said I was barely a match for drafting. Maybe he could tell how badly I wanted it.

Finally, his expression softened slightly.

"I'll see what I can do," he said.

It wasn't a yes, but it wasn't a no, either. For the first time since I'd sat down, I felt a little hope.

"We'll get back to you by mail within ten days."

For the next ten days, I checked the mail every day, hoping to see an envelope from Hall. When it finally arrived—on the tenth day—my heart was pounding so hard I could hear it in my ears. I tore the envelope open.

I was in.

For the first time in months, I felt like my life was finally moving forward again.

But, getting accepted was only the beginning. Now I had to graduate in a profession whose two most important skills I apparently sucked at.

*

My first day of class at Hall finally arrived. Taking the bus wasn't much fun, but I figured it would be temporary until I made other arrangements. As it turned out, I only rode it two or three times.

The class of forty was split into two groups: the paying twenty and the paid twenty. I was more than happy to be on the right side of that equation. I suspect some of the paying students looked down on us a little. We were the ones whose tuition was being picked up by Uncle Sam.

Not that it mattered much. The two groups mostly kept to themselves anyway. I quickly fell in with two guys named Danny D. and Eddie P. We went out to lunch together almost every day and sometimes grabbed a beer after school, (or even at lunch). They were both in their early twenties; I was eighteen when we started.

The legal drinking age was eighteen when we started. When I turned nineteen, Rhode Island raised it to nineteen. The next year it went to twenty, then eventually twenty-one. Fortunately for me, the state raised it one year at a time instead of all at once, so I stayed legal the entire way.

Lucky me!

Danny played guitar and drove a pristine blue '68 Camaro with a newly rebuilt engine and chrome rims. He had that classic Providence Italian tough-guy vibe—about six feet tall, lean and muscular, with a beard, blue eyes, a hawk-like nose, and thick but decent-looking glasses, much like mine.

Eddie invented "metrosexual" about ten years before anybody had heard the word. He always looked like he'd just stepped out of a salon. His clothes fit perfectly, his blond hair was always neatly trimmed, his tan looked permanent, and he somehow managed to make skin care look masculine.

Despite all that, nobody messed with Eddie. He was skinny, but tough in a way that made you think he'd fight dirty—and probably win. He seemed pretty easy-going, but I'd seen the look in his eye and the set of his mouth when someone crossed the line. He could be pretty scary. I used to think of him as a kind of 1930s Pretty Boy Floyd gangster. Of course, he got all the women.

One of the other characters in our little group of twenty government-sponsored losers was Gary, a Vietnam veteran in his mid-thirties with long hair and a drinking problem. He'd pound several beers in his car before class and often demolish a six-pack at lunch. He lived in a tenement with his wife, who I met once when we went to his house during lunch. All I really remember about her was a pair of pink-and-white checkered stretch pants trying heroically to contain a huge bubble butt that fully left the room twenty seconds after she did.

Over lunch one day, he casually mentioned that he had a "nylon fetish", and loved it when she "rubs her nylons against my Johnson", which brought the house down. That was the first time I'd ever heard that term for a guy's manhood...ly...ness... Thing.

Another student was Cindy, a twenty-seven-year-old single woman who sat directly across from me all day. She was 5'8", with long, straight brown hair and brown eyes. Sitting across from each other for eight hours a day, we couldn't help but notice each other. I got the feeling she was interested in me, although I wasn't quite sure yet how I felt about her.

By our third day, I'd let it be known that I was looking for a ride to school and would help pay for gas.

Cindy jumped at the chance.

The Flop House

Life with Stoner got progressively more and more weird after I got laid off. He started giving me a hard time about where I was going and what I was doing. Before long, it felt like I was living back at home.

So one weekend while he was at work, I grabbed some clothes and toiletries, stuffed them into a small duffel bag, and took off. I left him a note saying I'd be staying with some people I'd met nearby until I could find a more permanent place to live. I'd be back for the rest of my things.

The "some people I'd met" were a few young guys who lived about four blocks away in an even worse apartment. It made Stoner's place look luxurious. About the only thing this apartment had going for it was electricity. There was no heat, no hot water, no working stove, and no working refrigerator. There was a hot plate and two portable electric heaters that barely warmed up a room. There were only two beds and four guys living there, including me. One guy slept on the couch. I slept on a bare twin mattress on the bare wood floor. No sheets, just a blanket and a cheap pillow.

There were holes in the sheetrock big enough to see through from the living room into the "formal dining room," where I slept. We're talking a foot or more in diameter. There was almost no furniture except two motley old couches and a couple of beat-up, overstuffed chairs, with blankets thrown over huge rips where the stuffing bulged out.

I don't even know if anyone paid rent for the place. It was, by any definition, a flop house.

The other three guys were all in their early twenties. They were day laborers who went down to the Manpower office every morning and signed up for whatever work was available. Some days they found work; other days they came back empty-handed. When they did work, they got paid at the end of the day. It was menial labor: picking up trash at a park or cleaning bathrooms at a school when the janitor called in sick.

Nights were spent drinking cheap beer and smoking weed. These guys were always running some kind of scam—selling drugs on the side, buying and selling stolen goods, whatever they could do to make enough money to eat and survive.

Given my background, I fit right in. There was one big difference: I was due to start drafting school in a matter of days.

I lived like that for about two weeks while I searched for a decent place to live. The school paid us every Friday but held back the first week's stipend, so it would be two weeks before I finally saw my first check.

*

While crashing at the Flop House, I met a nice couple next door named Peter and Becky. Their apartment was in much better shape than the one I was staying in. They had carpeting, for one. And hot water. And heat. The luxuries of American life.

They invited me over for dinner and drinks a bunch of times. It was nice having "normal" friends. I hoped that someday I'd have a circle of friends like them.

One hot summer day, not long after the car accident with Stoner, they invited me to the beach with them and a few other people. We had two cars full, so it was a rolling party. I rode with their friend Patrick. About all I remember about him is his nicely restored orange 1970 Dodge Super Bee with white stripes.

"What beach are we going to?" I asked.

"Well... we're thinking of Moonstone Beach. Is that cool with you?" Peter replied.

"I've... never heard of it. Are we talking Rhode Island or Mass?"

"It's a little west of Sand Hill Cove."

That worked for me. I knew Sand Hill Cove; my mother had taken us there a bunch of times.

"Okay, cool. Sounds like fun!"

We packed the trunks, piled into the cars, and headed south. It was always nice to get out of the grimy city and smell fresh air—especially when that air was coming off the ocean.

On the drive there, someone lit up a joint and passed it around, so we caught a nice little buzz. It was hot even with the windows open, but the Super Bee had no air conditioning, so I spent the entire forty-five-minute ride in the back seat being pummeled by seventy-mile-an-hour, desert-like wind.

But it was great.

When we got there, we parked, unloaded, and dragged all our gear up a long sandy path through the shrubbery and over a small hill. We crested the hill and looked out over the sea grass and sand dunes to the beach and sparkling ocean beyond. A smattering of people were scattered along the sand, throwing Frisbees, playing volleyball, and soaking up the sun.

Naked.

Every. Single. One of them.

Peter had somehow neglected to mention one tiny detail... Moonstone Beach was a nudist beach.

Now, as I mentioned earlier, I'd been known to be a bit of an exhibitionist. I'd even "streaked" around Bernon Park once on a dare. But just once. It was all the rage for a while.

I'd never been to a nudist beach before, though, and I had no idea what the... "etiquette" was. Was it okay to look, but not stare? No pointing and laughing, I suppose? No taking pictures? The answers seemed pretty obvious, but...

I remember one of the guys with us—Jimmy, one of the Flop House guys—wasn't comfortable taking off his shorts. He didn't own a bathing suit, so he unbuttoned them, unzipped the fly a little, and pulled them down some. It was kinda silly. I mean, really? Why bother?

I, on the other hand, immediately went Full Monty. It was a little awkward, but only because these were still fairly new friends and neighbors.

Peter and Becky rolled out their blanket, nonchalantly shed every stitch of clothing, and lay down. I spread my towel next to them.

Peter quickly rubbed on some tanning lotion, then got up and headed down to the water, leaving me alone with Becky. The others had either headed for the water or were stretched out soaking up the sun.

A minute after Peter left, Becky flipped onto her stomach and turned to me.

"Can you rub some lotion on my back? I can't reach everywhere back there."

Now... I was an eighteen-year-old male with raging hormones, and this was going to be... interesting.

I couldn't say, "I wouldn't feel right doing that, with your husband 100 feet away." But who was I to deny the needs of a woman in distress?

I gave the matter the careful consideration it deserved—about three nanoseconds.

"Sure," I said, in an embarrassingly high-pitched voice that I hoped she didn't notice.

I followed it with a quick cough to clear my throat. Just a grain of sand in there, I tried to project. Not that I'm nervous about anything. Anything at all.

I grabbed the tube of Coppertone, squeezed a good serpentine design across her back, then rubbed it in as "professionally" as I could. No staring at the naughty parts. No lingering too long... anywhere. Strictly professional.

Unfortunately, Mother Nature had other ideas, and I had to stop before I made it all the way down to the backs of her calves—which, judging by the smile on her face, seemed to amuse Becky.

I coughed again and rolled away from her.

"There you go! Where did I put my water? Oh, there it is..."

I quickly turned away, took a long swig of cold water, and decided that lying on my stomach for a while would probably be a good idea.

Peter came back not too long after, glanced at Becky, then looked over at me. I didn't say anything. I just pretended to be snoozing.

Thank God for dark sunglasses.

Crazy Joe

At some point during those two weeks at the Flop House, I ran into a friend of Butch's down at Ye College Pub. His name was Joe. He was a rangy Vietnam vet in his mid-twenties with short, wavy brown hair, close-set dark eyes, and a bit of a crazy streak. Sober, he was mellow—especially if he'd been smoking weed. Drunk, he could turn mean in a hurry.

It was a Saturday night, and the three "roommates" at the flop house were out somewhere... probably making a drug deal or robbing a 7-Eleven. Hard to say with them.

I was bored and not interested in staring at the huge holes in the walls and the cockroaches, so I had hoofed it downtown to the Pub. As soon as I walked in, I spotted Joe sitting alone at the bar. The seat next to him was open, so I sat down.

"Joe!" I said, slapping him on the back—but not too hard.

He turned and lit up. "Eric! Great to see you, man! It's been a while. What have you been up to?"

"Well, I just started a course at a technical school for Drafting and Design. They pay me \$100 a week and cover my books and tuition. City training program."

"Wow! That's great! Can I buy you a beer?"

"Does the Pope wear a funny hat?"

He flagged down Donna, our matronly—and favorite—bartender.

"A shot of Jack and a Bud for Eric, on me, and another refill for me."

I didn't really want the shot after my last experience with Jack at this same bar six months earlier, but I figured I'd knock it back, chase it with the Bud, and stick to beer after that.

"I went by your house to get some weed and Stoner told me he didn't know where you were."

"Yeah, we had a bit of a falling out. He was getting weirdly controlling. Probably because I owe him a chunk of money."

"Where are you living?"

"At a flop house, for now. Not far from Stoner's."

"Well... I moved in with my girlfriend and her two little kids. We have an extra bedroom you could rent from us. We could use the money, and you'd have a much better place to live."

It wasn't exactly my dream living arrangement, but I was definitely interested.

The next afternoon, Joe came by the flop house just as Cindy was dropping me off. We drove straight over to his place, about ten minutes away, and parked in a small lot mainly used by patrons of the dive bar next door. Joe lived on the third floor of—of course—an old tenement building.

I met his girlfriend, Joyce, who was surprisingly very nice. Given what I knew of Joe, she wasn't at all what I'd expected. She was attractive, intelligent, kind, and a great mother to her two cute little kids—a three-year-old girl and a four-year-old boy.

I've never wanted kids—or even a dog—but both tend to want me. I'm a sucker for both, to be honest. And they instinctively know it.

I was a little wary about moving in with Joe. I knew what he could be like when he drank, but he'd never turned that side of himself on me, and compared to the flop house, this had to be an improvement. I figured I'd stay until I found something else, or perhaps until I graduated from school.

After all, I figured if I could sleep in the dirt beneath tenement stairs and in Salvation Army boxes, I could handle living with Joe and his little family.

I was wrong.

Joe worked weekends at what I think was a factory job. Day shift. He left around 7:00 AM and got home around 4:00 PM. Joyce worked as a hairdresser during the week, although she didn't have a regular chair at a salon. She mostly went to women's houses and cut their hair for under-the-table cash.

One Saturday morning, Joyce, the kids, and I were sitting around the breakfast (and lunch and dinner) table talking. I'd just bought a junker car from my friend Patrick for \$125. It had been sitting abandoned beside his parents' house in Smithfield for almost two years. I bought a new battery, threw on some retread tires, and fired it up. Surprisingly, it ran.

Ironically, it was a Buick Skylark—the same car I'd won for my brother in a church raffle two years earlier. Except his was brand new. This one was nine years old.

The kids were bored and wanted to do something, so I said, "How about if we go to the mall?"

The kids loved the idea. Joyce was a little hesitant, though. She worried that Joe might not like me taking her and the kids out without him. I laughed it off and may have given her a raised eyebrow or made some equally innocent little gesture, but whatever I did, it was entirely in jest. There was no way I was going to make a move on Joe's girlfriend. That would have been way too dangerous. And, as I've said, I wasn't much of a move-maker anyway.

So we piled into my shit-box car and drove to Lincoln Mall. I bought the kids some little toys and ice cream, and we spent a nice few hours

away from the apartment. They loved it. To them, going to the mall was a big adventure.

Later that night, when Joe got home... from the bar... I was asleep. It was 12:30 AM when I was awakened by a full glass of water hitting me square in the head, soaking my face and hair, the pillow, and half the bed.

"Get up!" Joe roared.

I bolted awake, completely disoriented. *Why was Joe yelling at me? And, why the hell had he just thrown a glass of water in my face?*

"Were you flirting with Joyce this morning?!"

Uh-oh.

"No! Absolutely not!"

"She told me you made a pass at her!"

Uh-oh times ten.

"I did NOT make a pass at her, Joe! Come on! I would never do that! Maybe I said something or did something she took that way, but if I did, I absolutely didn't mean it like that!"

Joe stormed out of the bedroom yelling for Joyce, with me close behind. She was in the bathroom, sitting fully dressed on the closed toilet seat, terrified and crying.

"Are you lying to me?!"

He slapped her hard across the face.

"Whoa! JOE! Calm down, man! Nothing happened! I'm sure this was just a misunderstanding. There's no reason to hit her!"

He hit her again.

"Joe! Listen, let's cool it. I have some weed. Let's go smoke a joint and chill out, okay?"

The mention of weed got his attention. He slowly backed off, and I coaxed him into the living room, continuing to insist that the whole thing had been a misunderstanding.

We sat on the couch for a few minutes while I tried to talk some sense into him, and finally he said, "Okay, let's go across the street to the park and light one up."

We headed down the two flights of stairs, crossed the street, and sat on a park bench. I lit the joint, and we sat there for at least half an hour getting high while Joe gradually calmed down.

Once he was relaxed, I said, "Joe, I can't live in a house with this kind of drama and violence. It's not cool to hit women. Joyce is a sweetheart, and so are those kids. You gotta get your rage under control when you're drinking."

He was all kinds of remorseful now that he was high. He apologized profusely and begged me not to move out.

"I really can't deal with this," I told him. Eventually, though, I agreed to think about it.

Within a few days, I moved out while Joe was at work, without notice. I left him a full month's rent even though I'd only been there two weeks.

Moving out of Joe's apartment—in a hurry, which is the only sensible way to move out of a violent nut-job's apartment—was the easy part. The problem was where to go next.

Two weeks earlier, I'd left the Flop House thinking I was moving on to something better. Now I was hauling my stuff right back there. There really wasn't anywhere else to go.

So, back to Jimmy and the gang. Back to the cockroaches, no hot water, and the bare, damp mattress on the cold wood floor.

At least nobody there was throwing water in my face or slapping women around in the bathroom.

Not long after moving back in, I was passed out one Saturday morning after a hard night of partying when a foot slammed into my stomach.

It was Butch.

"Get up!" he shouted, kicking me in the gut again.

I snapped to, fighting my way through the hangover fog. Every cell in my body screamed in protest.

"What the fuck are you doing?!"

"Why did you beat up Stoner?!"

I shook my head to clear the fog, trying to process this insanity. Was I dreaming?

The accusation was so completely out of left field, it actually cleared my headache for a second.

"WHAT?! I didn't beat up Stoner! I didn't beat up anybody! What the hell are you talking about? Who told you this?"

"Two people. Ruth from across the street and Paul from next door. They both said it was you."

"What the hell happened?"

Butch finally gave me the basic story. Stoner had been walking home very drunk sometime around one or two in the morning when two guys in a white panel van pulled up and jumped him. He'd been blindsided and never saw what—or who—hit him.

"So how the hell did my name get into this?"

"I just told you. Ruth from across the street and Paul from next door. They said there were two guys, and one of them was tall with blond hair. They both said it was you."

I was scrambling to make sense of it and figure out how to respond. This was uncharted territory. No one had ever accused me of anything like this before. My confused reaction must have gotten through to him a little. His temperature came down, but not nearly as much as I'd hoped. He still looked at me like a suspect, not a friend.

I pressed him for anything else he knew, but that was about it.

"Is Stoner working today? I'll go down and see him right now and sort this out. I did not do this! This is insane."

He finally left, and I dragged myself to a shower—cold, of course, because what else would it be at the Flop House?—got dressed, and started the mile-and-a-half walk downtown to Riccotti's.

My hangover was back in full, righteous fury.

Riccotti's was quiet when I walked in, just before the lunch rush. Diane, the thin Black girl who lived in the apartment above Ye College Pub, was working the counter.

"Is Stoner here?" I asked.

"Yeah, he's in the back."

I walked straight behind the counter and into the prep area like I owned the place—or at least still worked there. I found Stoner standing at the big prep table, both gloved hands wrist-deep in chicken salad. He'd probably heard me asking for him, but he kept his head down as I approached, purposefully refusing to look at me. He seemed fully absorbed in the mayonnaise and the unnatural little cubes of chicken.

"Stoner! Butch just woke me up by kicking me in the gut, saying I beat you up last night. What's that all about? You must know it wasn't me. For one, I was partying at the Flop House with at least three witnesses, and for two, how could you even think I'd do something like that?!"

He answered in a low, beaten-down voice. He hadn't seen anything himself. He'd been jumped and blindsided, just as Butch had told me, so all he really had to go on was what the neighbors had said.

"I don't know, man. All I know is two witnesses said it was you."

Then, finally, he looked up at me.

I wasn't prepared for what I saw. Both eyes were black and blue, his cheeks were swollen, and he had a huge, nasty-looking knot right in the middle of his forehead.

I was surprised he still had his teeth.

I left the shop dazed and confused. Here were two people who knew me well—one of whom I'd lived with for more than a year—yet the word of two eyewitnesses was apparently enough to outweigh everything they knew about me.

I only pieced together the rest of what had happened over the next few days. Stoner hadn't cut his hair in seven years. Before I hired him at Riccotti's, he'd been laid off and couldn't find another job as a real cook in an actual restaurant—not just making chicken salad out of processed chicken cubelets. He'd finally started to wonder if his long hair was part of the problem.

So that afternoon, he'd done something almost unthinkable for a committed hippie like Stoner: he'd gotten it cut.

Short.

Which, of course, called for getting raging drunk on tequila.

Sometime around one or two in the morning, while walking home, he'd been jumped on the street outside his apartment building and beaten with a baseball bat. The only reason my name entered the picture was that two questionable eyewitnesses claimed they'd seen me there.

From what I was hearing, they hadn't actually claimed they'd seen "me" hit him. They'd only claimed they'd seen me there. Regardless, of course, I wasn't there.

Eventually, another piece of the puzzle fell into place. Joe was apparently pissed off because he'd been counting on my rent money and thought Stoner had talked me into moving back in with him. He had no idea I'd actually gone back to the Flop House.

Then I learned something even more interesting. Joe's brother was a former Providence cop who'd been thrown off the force for beating up suspects and stealing drugs from dealers. He happened to have blond hair like mine and was about my height, though considerably more muscular.

And he drove a white panel van.

*

Few things bother me more than being accused of something I didn't do. My finely honed—but constantly battered—sense of fairness kicks into high gear. And nothing makes it worse than being unable to prove I didn't do it. Granted, I did have the Flop House guys to vouch for me, but I can imagine a prosecutor ripping my alibi to shreds given we were all pretty thrashed from hours of drinking and smoking weed. I had no idea the exact time I finally crashed, and the other guys probably didn't, either.

Luckily, no police report was ever filed, and the only real fallout was a total severance of my ties to Stoner, Bob, Butch—and Joe. That wasn't necessarily a bad thing. What bothered me was knowing there were people out there who believed I was capable of doing something like that.

These were people who knew me. They should have known better.

Cindy

After moving out of Joe's apartment—more like running for my life than "moving"—and retreating briefly to the Flop House, I was in a bad spot. I needed somewhere warm, clean, and non-cockroach-infested before the Providence winter truly kicked in.

I couldn't keep showing up to class dead tired every morning from being kept up half the night. I'd stopped smoking pot and saved my excessive drinking for the weekends. I was taking school seriously, and I couldn't afford to screw this up.

During the first six weeks of school, Cindy served as my unofficial chauffeur, picking me up whenever my semi-resuscitated Skylark decided it preferred spending time in the shop instead of paying me back for bringing it back from the dead.

Turns out, Cindy's romantic life was as complicated as my living situation. She was single when I met her, but her ex-boyfriend of many years, Frank, happened, by crazy coincidence, to hang out at the bar literally next door to Joe's place. Not only that, but the bartender and owner of the place was Frank's... lover.

Frank was the classic tall, dark, and handsome construction worker type—not at all what my seventeen-year-old brain pictured when I thought of a bisexual guy. It was kind of like finding out Rock Hudson was gay.

I met Frank a few times at the bar, and he was... a cool guy. If I'd met him without knowing anything about his personal life, it never would have occurred to me that he was bisexual. He gave me a ride to school once when Cindy was sick, and somewhere along the way, he made a pass at me. It wasn't the first time a guy had come onto me, so it wasn't exactly a world-shaking event.

"Sorry, Frank, I'm just not that way. I have a brother who's gay, and I don't judge, but I'm strictly into women."

To his credit, he was very cool about it. He backed off immediately and completely, and we went right back to normal conversation for the rest of the ride. No harm, no foul.

One thing I remember taking from that experience was that Frank had a certain sadness about him. A bit of melancholy. He struck me as a guy who knew there was nothing wrong with who he was, but also knew the world didn't necessarily see it that way, and there wasn't much, if anything, he could do about it.

When I got out of his truck and watched him pull away, I felt bad for him. He struck me as a guy who knew there was nothing wrong with who he was, but also knew the world didn't necessarily see it that way, and there wasn't much, if anything, he could do about it.

Not everyone gets to leave that behind.

Meanwhile, I was still living at the Flop House, and it was wearing thin. What had once been almost an adventure was now just exhausting. I was trying to get through school during the day while living in a place where sleep, hot water, and basic sanitation were all pretty much optional.

Finally, after another couple of weeks of Flop House misery, I made a move on Cindy. I found that move-making was a lot easier when you weren't really all that into someone. I was trying to convince myself I could make it work with her. She was a nice person who had been genuinely good to me.

She was very receptive, and given my horrific living situation—not to mention the looming prospect of cold showers getting much, much colder—I soon laid out a case for moving in together.

This was very, very quick, but I was in dire straits here. I had to talk her into it, to a certain degree, because she had a major hurdle: she was living with her divorced father, and she'd already moved out and back in several times over the previous few years.

The last time she'd returned, her father had given her an ultimatum: if she moved out again, she couldn't come back.

To make things even more interesting, her father was almost certainly connected to the Mob. Full-blooded Italian, no visible job, a gorgeous house on acres of land, and a big boat he casually sailed down to Florida. Throw in the fact that he lived about a quarter-mile down the road from Raymond Patriarca, Sr., the boss of the New England Mafia, and you didn't need to be Sherlock Holmes to connect the dots.

I decided to try and not think too much about his ultimatum.

We managed to find a small apartment in a nice neighborhood near Providence College. It was a dormer-type place on the upper floor of a small cottage, with an old lady living downstairs. The sloped ceilings meant I couldn't stand up fully if I got too close to the walls, but it was clean, in good condition, and the rent was reasonable.

It was a big step up from a dirty hardwood floor, but a step down from actually wanting to be there.

We moved in on November 1st.

The minute the moving boxes were unpacked, the internal conflict began. During the almost two months we lived together, I grew more and more unhappy with my decision. I wasn't being completely honest with myself—or with Cindy. I didn't really see myself with her long-term, and she was almost ten years older than me—a fact that, at eighteen, felt like a real generation gap.

Apparently, the internal conflict was intense enough to come out while I slept. Cindy would tell me in the morning that I'd been beating her up in my sleep. Oops. She said I'd roll over and accidentally punch her as my arm swung across, or stretch out a leg and kick her.

I, of course, wasn't doing any of this knowingly, but apparently my subconscious had already figured out what my conscious mind was still trying to deny.

It was staging a prison break.

By Christmas, I was ready to move out. I couldn't keep punching my "girlfriend" in my sleep.

The decision was tough, though. I'd talked her into moving out of her father's Mob-adjacent house knowing she couldn't go back, and now I was leaving her stuck with the entire rent on this little dormer apartment. To top it all off, we still had to face each other across our drafting tables every day for another eight miserable months. I was more bothered by that than by having to find another place to live.

Wherever I ended up next, it had to be reasonably comfortable, safe, and not filled with a bunch of wild party animals.

There was only one place I could think of that might work.

It was my last resort...

Home Sweet Home?

I reached out to Leslie and told her what was going on with Cindy and that I needed to find another place to live. Of all my siblings, Leslie probably understood better than anyone why I'd left. She suggested something I hadn't seriously considered: maybe I could move back home for the eight months I had left at Hall.

Things were different now. I'd been living on my own for almost exactly two years, and if I went back, it would have to be on different terms. I was legally an adult now, and my mother had already visited me a few times in Providence. I'd left the nest. Going home temporarily didn't have to mean moving backward.

Leslie came up with a plan to test the waters. I'd sneak into my parents' house on Christmas Eve and surprise my mother the next morning. I would be her "present."

Christmas morning, I went downstairs with Mark, Leslie, and Alex, hanging back so I'd be the last one into the living room. My mother was genuinely surprised and happy to see me, and rushed up to me and gave me a big hug and made a big fuss about my being there. My father was happy my mother was happy.

Over the course of the day, the idea of my moving back came up. To my mother's credit, what mattered most to her was that I finish school, get a steady job, and hopefully turn all of this into an actual career.

We worked out some pretty reasonable ground rules. I'd have free rein to come and go as I pleased, as long as I didn't wander in at three in the morning and wake everyone up. I think we settled on 1:00 AM, or a phone call if I was going to stay out for the night.

Fair enough! I was only expecting to be there for the eight months I had left of school, and in return for a warm, clean, rent-free place to live, respecting a few reasonable rules didn't seem like much to ask.

As for my sleeping quarters, my brother had taken over the entire room we used to share, so I carved out a space for myself in the attic. I cleaned it up as best I could. I couldn't fully stand up in there, but there was enough room to throw a mattress on the floor and hang a Ghost Ship blacklight poster on the wall.

I only slept up there; I didn't hang out. It was too hot in the summer and way too cold in the winter, but I had an electric heater, some extra blankets, and I made do. Compared to some of the places I'd slept over the previous two years, the attic wasn't half bad.

It was definitely a little awkward at first. I felt like a stranger. Little things had changed, as they do over time in every house. Sitting down to

my first meal with the rest of the family was... odd. They were different. Things were different.

Alex was a high school track-and-field star now. He had his driver's license, used the family car regularly, and had way more freedom than I'd ever had at his age. He was officially my mother's "favorite," and she made that insensitively clear, one might say, but I didn't really care. I figured I already had one foot out the door anyway. Once school ended, I'd be gone for good. Away from all the drama.

And... I was different.

I'd just gone through two years of crazy experiences that none of these people sitting around the dinner table could even fathom. Yet there I was, sitting in my old spot at the table again, having dinner with my family like I'd never left.

If they only knew what I'd been through.

I was still only eighteen, but I felt a fair bit older than that.

*

During the six months I was back home, I actually visited Vinnie and Freddie once or twice. I think part of me wanted them to see what could happen if they just applied themselves a little. I'd gotten out of the 'hood, I was going to technical school, and by then I was driving around in my own set of wheels instead of walking everywhere. In my eighteen-year-old mind, I was practically a success story.

Okay, maybe I was showing off a little.

But I also wanted to inspire them. If I could start turning my life around, why couldn't they?

It was probably foolish. Vinnie and Freddie were still stuck in the same rut, with no apparent sign that anything was going to change. But I hadn't

completely given up on them yet. As screwed up as they were, I honestly wanted to help them get out, too.

Lee-Ann

It was a few days before Christmas, 1978, when I went to a party downstairs from Peter and Becky, who I had kept in touch with after moving back home. The guy throwing it was an assistant manager at a McDonald's in East Providence, and he'd invited his work crew, along with a few friends.

There were about twenty people there, with music blasting and lots of food and alcohol. I ended up in a drinking game called "acey-deucy." I'd never heard of it before, but somebody explained the rules as we went along.

Between the booze and the rules, people gradually dropped out. It was one of those games where, after a while, you stopped caring whether you had to drink or not. You just took the shot anyway.

Soon enough, there were just the two of us left: me and a girl named Lee-Ann. She was the last person I expected to meet in that kind of neighborhood.

Lee-Ann was about five-foot-two soaking wet, and she looked like a super-cute porcelain doll. Heartbreakingly cute. Long, shiny brown hair pulled back in a ponytail, dimpled cheeks, and flawless alabaster skin. Oh, and a killer body. Just enough curves in all the right places.

I was totally trashed—and totally smitten.

At one point, she staggered to her feet and announced she needed to use the bathroom. She was so drunk she could barely walk, so I played the gentleman and helped her down the hallway. When I got her into the bathroom, she asked me to stay, so I closed the door and became, for a few gentlemanly minutes, the world's most dedicated hair-holder-backer-er.

After she finished getting sick and rinsed out her mouth, we staggered back down the hall.

Somewhere along the way, instead of heading back to the living room, I pushed open a random bedroom door. We went in and just fell onto the floor, making out. I managed to kick the door shut behind us. The room was dark and full of junk—obviously some kind of storage room. But it was carpeted, which helped. Rug burn being better than splinters.

Somehow or other, we quickly ended up de-pantsed and at least going through some sort of motions. Our bodies were trying to cash checks our brains were in no condition to write—insufficient funds, as it turned out, in every department.

I don't know how long we lay there, fondling and fumbling while the room spun, but suddenly the music got louder and a puff of fresh air blew into the room. I looked over my right shoulder, and there were three heads lined up in a six-inch crack in the door, staring at my white cheeks.

Not the ones on my face.

They were having a good-natured laugh, and a few jokes were thrown our way before I managed to reach back and kick the door shut again.

A while later, her ride was leaving. She rattled off her number, and I promised I'd remember it, as neither of us had a pen.

It wasn't the first time I'd been instantly infatuated with a girl, but this was the strongest I'd ever felt it. And this time, there was one very important difference: she was into me, too.

The problem, of course, was me. I was painfully inexperienced. I didn't look like a player, but with enough alcohol in me, I could apparently act like one. Sober was another story. I was definitely not the stud I think she thought I was.

*

To my surprise—and I mean that with a capital S—there was a first date. I remembered her phone number. (I'm surprised I don't still

remember it almost fifty years later, considering how many times I repeated it to myself before I got home and could write it down.)

She invited me to her parents' house in Great Barrington the following Saturday afternoon. Her parents and little brother would all be out, leaving the house to the two of us for a few hours.

I drove my beat-up, but could-be-worse Skylark to her craftsman-style suburban home. She lived in the kind of neighborhood I often fantasized living in as a kid.

Normal.

The kind of neighborhood where everybody seemed to have their lives together. Upper middle class, for sure.

I was pretty nervous as I walked up to the door. This was the kind of girl I'd always dreamed of. Maybe I was finally going to be part of that elusive Long-term Relationship Club. I knew from our phone calls leading up to this that she was into me.

This was mine to blow. And I knew it.

Then she opened the door, and my brain went from "nervous" to "complete system shutdown."

She was wearing a navy-blue T-shirt that said *Reach for the Stars*, with two white stars printed right where her nipples happened, not coincidentally, to be. She wasn't wearing a bra, and she was a rather generously proportioned eighteen-year-old, let's just say. To finish off the ensemble, she had on short navy-blue gym shorts and little white socks, no shoes. To my eighteen-year-old brain, it seemed to be sending the clearest signal possible. I mean, come on. She might as well have had a T-shirt on that said, "Please have sex with me before my parents get home."

She welcomed me with a huge, gorgeous smile and said, "Hi Eric! I'm so glad you found the place. People often end up next door for some reason. We have the place to ourselves. Do you want a beer?"

"Umm... Sure! Sounds good," I managed, sounding less like the confident guy who'd been fumbling with her on a bedroom floor and more like a teenager who suddenly had no idea what the hell he was doing.

"Have a seat on the couch. I'll be right back," she said, turning toward the kitchen.

I sat down, panicked, trying to figure out how to handle this.

When she came back, she sat down next to me on the couch. And we had this... this get-to-know-you conversation. A conversation. A polite, chatty, entirely unnecessary conversation.

I was operating in "best behavior" mode because I was an idiot. I was so terrified of making the wrong move that I wasn't making any move at all.

It was pretty clear that she was expecting the guy she'd met at the party—the confident, funny guy she'd been making out with on the bedroom floor a few nights earlier. Instead, she was getting Mr. Polite Conversationalist, apparently determined to spend the afternoon discussing anything and everything except why we were both there.

Over the next couple of hours, I could feel her excitement fading. She was still nice, but the energy in the room had changed. I left just before her parents got home, fully convinced she'd never want to see me again.

I drove home kicking myself. Embarrassed. Heartsick. And totally obsessed.

*

Somehow, I hadn't blown it completely. Lee-Ann still wanted to see me. She was a freshman at Bryant College, where her father worked in

the Human Resources Department, and she worked part-time at McDonald's. She stayed in a dorm during the week and at home with her parents on weekends. So between both our academic schedules, the forty-five-minute drive between us, and her job, we didn't actually see each other all that often.

We talked on the phone a lot, though—sometimes for hours. I suppose we were technically dating for maybe three months, although I think we only actually got together three or four times. I remember taking her to the movies once, and another time we went out for pizza.

The pizza place had one of those little jukebox selectors mounted on the wall at each table, with pages you flipped through to pick a song. We played "Fantasy" by Earth, Wind & Fire, but the song I remember most was "Reminiscing" by Little River Band. It was a romantic song, and somehow it became attached to Lee-Ann in my head. It still reminds me of her today.

One unseasonably warm afternoon, I met her at Bryant and we ended up on the grass together, kissing. I was lying there looking into her beautiful green eyes. I still remember the smell of the grass, the slanted late-afternoon sunlight, the chill in the air, and the sound of students talking in the distance.

It was a magical afternoon. I was totally infatuated with this girl, and she clearly, at the very least, "liked" me, too.

On our last date, I met her at Bryant College for some kind of school dance. I walked into the hall with the band playing and spotted her sitting at a round table with maybe ten people. There was one open seat right next to her.

On her other side was a guy... and she had her hand on his knee.

I leaned in and asked her about it. She told me he was "just a friend."

And suddenly I was feeling this new, hot, ugly emotion called jealousy. I'd never felt it before, and I didn't like it at all. I recognized it for what it was and tried to shove it back in its box.

I thought I had.

We went back to her room and had a bit of an argument about what 'just a friend' actually meant, and finally I told her I thought it would be better if we didn't see each other anymore. I started to walk out.

To my ongoing surprise, she said, "Eric, please don't do this."

I stopped with my hand on the doorknob. For a moment, I just stood there staring at it. Then I opened the door and walked out without looking back.

Because if I'd looked back at her, I wouldn't have left. I knew that. I would have stayed—and prolonged the torture.

I'll never forget the drive home. It was around 10:00 at night, and the glow from the dashboard radio barely lit the inside of the car. And then, because apparently the universe had a sense of humor, "Reminiscing" came on.

I couldn't believe it. Of all the songs that could have been playing, it had to be that one.

The feeling I had was very strange. It wasn't the searing pain you'd expect from walking away from a gorgeous girl who actually liked you. No, the overwhelming feeling was...

Freedom.

It was like a huge burden had been lifted from my shoulders. I'd been obsessed with her from the moment she opened the door on our first date. I literally couldn't sleep. I couldn't eat. I couldn't think about anything or anyone else, 24x7.

"Reminiscing" became a kind of torture song for me after that. I loved hearing it, but every time I did, it brought Lee-Ann back and left me with this melancholy feeling that I'd blown my chance—that I'd never have someone like her again.

Looking back, I think I sabotaged the relationship because I never really believed I could keep a girl like her. I wanted it too much. I was so afraid of making the wrong move and blowing it that I barely made any moves at all. And once I had her, instead of enjoying it, I worried about losing her.

That's what I think the feeling of freedom was about. I wasn't relieved to be rid of Lee-Ann. I was relieved to be rid of the anxiety of trying to keep Lee-Ann.

The strange thing is, I didn't consciously think there was anything wrong with me. I was tall, reasonably smart, fairly funny, decent-looking. I knew that. I didn't walk around thinking I was defective or unlikable.

But there was an insecurity in there somewhere. Maybe it's one most people have to some degree. Mine just seemed to surface at the worst possible times, especially when I really cared about the outcome.

It was like a quiet little voice whose premise I rejected, but somehow still felt compelled to prove wrong:

No one really likes you.

Heads Up

The classroom work at Hall wasn't particularly difficult. The hardest part for me was exactly what Bob Burns had warned me about: learning to draw perfectly straight, consistent lines and print neat, uniform lettering.

We weren't designing automobile parts or anything like that. An engineer might hand us a rough sketch of a part, and our job was to turn it into a precise technical drawing that somebody could actually manufacture.

Once I got the hang of the line work and lettering, I settled into the routine pretty quickly. Danny, Eddie, and I would often walk next door to the Ground Round for lunch, split a pitcher of beer over burgers, and head back to class sometimes more than a little buzzed.

Other times, we'd get together after school and listen to Danny play guitar. He was pretty good and had been playing in a band for a while, but he'd given it up when he started at Hall. Late nights were not conducive to early mornings.

One Friday at lunch, Danny mentioned that a friend's band was playing at a club in North Attleboro that night and asked if I wanted to go. A couple of his friends were going with him, and he had room in the Camaro for one more.

The band started at 9:30, but we planned to get there early enough to grab a table.

The back seat of a '68 Camaro is pretty tight for a tall guy. The other two guys weren't short, but I was the tallest, so I got shotgun. Which is not always the best seat in certain situations.

The band was good, and we stayed until closing, but we played it pretty cool on the drinking. Danny had to drive, and he was very conscientious about that kind of thing, so he barely drank anything at all. We helped the band load up their equipment while we talked about how

the show went, then piled back into the Camaro for the ride back to Providence.

It was about 1:00 AM, and there was very little traffic. We were heading through Pawtucket at about 45 mph—just 5 mph over the speed limit. Perfectly acceptable.

In that part of Pawtucket, tall buildings—mostly old factories—came right up to the street, blocking any view of cross traffic until you were practically in the intersection.

At one intersection, the traffic light was out. We didn't know it, and apparently neither did the truck driver coming from the cross street. Neither of us slowed down.

None of us saw the semi until we couldn't miss seeing it.

Then... BAM.

We slammed into the side of the truck at full speed, right into one of its big, drum-shaped fuel tanks. Somehow, it didn't explode.

The Camaro was destroyed. Danny had just had it painted and the engine rebuilt, and he absolutely loved that car. And for good reason—it was a gorgeous car.

As for us... we hit the truck so hard that Danny's upper chest and shoulder broke the steering wheel in half, leaving a massive bruise across the whole area.

Again, this was a 1968 automobile. No airbags, and no shoulder harnesses on the seat belts. All we had was the one belt across the waist. My face slammed full-force into the thinly padded metal dashboard, somehow managing not to break my nose or knock out my front teeth.

I hit it hard enough to leave a noticeable dent. My upper lip wasn't so lucky—it swelled up instantly and hurt like hell.

The guys in the back got away with just a few bumps and bruises. The police arrived fairly quickly, and one of the cops pointed out just how narrowly we'd avoided something much worse.

"If you'd been going even half a mile an hour slower, or the truck a little faster—a split second either way—you would've gone underneath it. The trailer would've hit right about here," he said, indicating the base of the windshield. "It would've taken your heads off."

Not that any of us particularly needed that pointed out.

He called for an ambulance and took our statements while we waited. The truck driver was fine, and the damage to the semi was, shockingly, mostly cosmetic. Once the cop finished with him, he let him leave.

Danny just stood there staring at what was left of his Camaro. He didn't say much. He didn't have to.

A tow truck came and unceremoniously hauled the car away. Once we'd given our statements, the cop said, "The ambulance should be here any minute. I have another call. Good luck."

And with that, he left the four of us standing on a street corner at 1:30 in the morning, battered and moaning.

The ambulance finally showed up and took all four of us to the ER at a local hospital. After sitting in the waiting room for two hours, we eventually convinced ourselves that none of us had any broken bones or life-threatening injuries...

So we called a cab and walked out.

I'm Probably Going To Hell For This

Sometime after Christmas, I went out to start my Skylark, but it wasn't in the mood. I turned the key, and it coughed a few times, whined a bit, then sputtered to life for a few last moments before saying, "Aw, fuck it. I give up.", and died.

It had 130,000 miles on it, though, so it had lived a good, if somewhat under-appreciated, life. It served me briefly but well.

Fortunately, I discovered two fellow students who lived near my parents' place, and I started commuting to school with them. Shortly thereafter, I bought a 1965 Plymouth Satellite from my sister's boyfriend, Jim. He'd gotten it from his grandmother, and it still had the original thick plastic seat covers. The seats underneath looked brand new.

I removed them immediately.

It was a great car. Six-cylinder, decent on gas, and it ran really well. The only problem was that before long, the brakes got mushy and I had to pump them several times to come to a stop. I learned to start braking well before I actually needed to.

I'd blown every penny I had on the car, so I didn't have any money left to fix the brakes.

One day, I was returning to school from lunch. I was doing about 35 mph in a 40 mph zone and got distracted for a second. When I looked back at the road, the car in front of me had stopped at a stop sign.

I hit the brakes hard and... nothing happened.

I frantically pumped them, but the car just kept coasting. I finally smashed into the back of the car at about 20 mph—hard enough to cave in my front end and puncture the radiator. The old Buick in front of me got a dent in its big metal bumper. Not that big a deal.

Once we came to a stop, the driver got out, and so did I. That's when I noticed he was wearing a priest's collar.

Then I noticed his three passengers were... all nuns.

To make things even crazier, the priest didn't speak English and was babbling away in Portuguese. I gathered that he wanted me to follow them to the hospital because the nuns were complaining of whiplash.

Being Catholic myself, I did the right thing.

Once we took off—my car overheating and smoking like crazy—I took a right after they went straight through the next light...

I made it back to school, just barely, but the car was not long for this world. It would have cost more to fix than the car was worth, so off to the scrap heap it went.

I spent the next few days looking for a new car and ended up with a beauty: a 1970 Lincoln Continental Town Car. Power windows! Leather seats! Four-door luxury! Compared to everything I'd been driving, it felt like I'd won the lottery.

It cost me \$300, had only 70,000 miles on it, and was in great condition. It was like rolling around in a leather-lined tank.

Finally, I thought my transportation problems were over.

The Confession

Shortly after Mark turned twenty, we were having lunch at a Howard Johnson's when he suddenly looked across the table at me.

"I'm gay," he blurted out.

I laughed—not at him, but because I couldn't believe he thought I didn't already know. "Mark, I figured that out a long time ago," I said. "I'm totally okay with it. I just don't necessarily want to hear all the graphic details."

Naturally, he immediately gave me details.

"Once, I kissed a boyfriend—on the lips—right out in front of the house, just to completely freak out Mr. Frechette," he said, referring to our nosy old neighbor.

"Whoa, whoa..." I laughed. "That's exactly the kind of thing I don't want to hear!"

For the most part, that boundary held. There were a few exceptions over the years, but those conversations were much more serious.

In the years that followed, Mark sincerely—and repeatedly—apologized to the rest of us for making our childhood miserable. As an adult, he was quite a character—stubborn as hell, but also ridiculously positive and genuinely empathetic.

Unfortunately, my mother came to rely heavily on that empathy. For years, she pulled Mark into one crisis after another, unloading her anxieties and problems onto him until he'd finally had enough. He did the one thing she probably never expected: he cut off all contact with her for the rest of his life.

The Library

Sometime in February, I talked Mark into going out for a few drinks with me. Just before we left, my friend Jon called and ended up coming over to join us.

It was one of the few times in my entire life, before or since, that Mark and I ever went out drinking together. We had very different ideas about who we hoped to meet at the end of the night.

We decided to go to The Library, a popular college bar near Bryant College. Lee-Ann was still very much on my mind, and I suppose I was hoping I might accidentally-on-purpose run into her.

We pulled into the dirt parking lot, which was packed, but I got lucky and found a good spot at the end of a row close to the entrance. Mark wasn't feeling well and decided to take a nap in the back seat, so Jon and I went in alone.

Classic '70s rock was blasting and the place was packed, but after waiting a few minutes, we got lucky and grabbed a table just as a group was leaving.

I grabbed a couple more beers and a few shots of Jose Cuervo Gold and happily continued the already substantial buzz we'd been working on all evening. At one point, I said, "I gotta hit the head."

Somehow, I made it to my feet and weaved my way toward the men's room. For some crazy tequila-based reason, instead of just pushing the door open like a normal person, I kicked it open.

Unfortunately, this left a hole in the door about the size of the front half of my shoe.

The door banged open onto five or six guys crammed into this tiny bathroom with two urinals, one toilet, and a sink. Just as I walked in, one of the guys finished up at a urinal, so I took his place, unzipped, and started chatting with the drunk guy next to me.

He was wearing a Washington State sweatshirt and seemed like a really nice guy. Friendly. We joked around a little as we unloaded the beer we'd rented.

Suddenly, the bathroom door burst open and two or three guys came in—two were cops and one was probably a bouncer.

"Who kicked the hole in the door?!" one of the cops said.

No one said a word.

"No one leaves this bathroom until we find out who kicked the door in!"

Again, no one said a word.

I'm standing there thinking, *Everyone in this room knows I did it, but no one's ratting me out!*

Finally, after the cop repeated himself, I looked apologetically at the guy from Washington State, pointed to him and said, "He did it."

Two cops grabbed him by the arms and literally dragged him out of the bathroom, across the bar, down the three steps, and onto the dirt parking lot—straight into the back of the cop car.

I'll never forget the look on his face. Total disbelief. He just stared at me, wide-eyed, as they literally dragged him backwards out of the bathroom and through the bar, too stunned to even tell the cops, "I didn't do it!" I don't think he even knew I'd kicked in the door. He simply couldn't understand why I'd pointed at him.

I've felt guilty about that ever since. It was a horrible thing to do, but at the time, it felt like survival. I didn't want to go to jail.

If you're reading this, Washington State guy, I'm really sorry.

I went back to the table where Jon was waiting.

"What was all the commotion about?" he asked. "Looked like they were dragging some guy out of the bar."

"Uh... well..." I told him the story. He thought it was hilarious, which got me laughing, too.

Unfortunately, Washington State guy's buddies were sitting at the table right next to us. And they weren't laughing. They also weren't tiny little guys. They looked like football players.

One of them took his empty plastic cup, turned it upside down, and smashed it flat on the table.

Jon, who was still cracking up, laughed even harder. "Ooohhh, tough guy!" Then he turned his own cup upside down and smashed it flat, too.

Then they stood up.

All three of them.

Then we got up.

And started running for our lives.

Luckily, a few bouncers intervened just in time and helped escort us through the packed crowd and out the front door, but the three guys were right behind them. We hit the stairs running and used our five-second head start to make a dash for the car.

The locked car.

Mark had the keys and was asleep in the back seat.

We started hammering on the windows, screaming, "Mark!! Open the door!! Hurry!!"

He finally came to and pulled up the door lock, then had the presence of mind to reach over and unlock the driver's side door. We jumped in, slammed the doors shut, and punched the lock buttons down just as our pursuers reached the car.

They were pounding on the windows and trying to open the doors as I started the car and tore out of the parking lot. I had no idea whether they

ran for their own car to chase us, or not, and I wasn't about to stick around long enough to find out.

I made a few quick turns, just in case.

A few weeks after what I would sometimes refer to as "The Incident at The Library," I stopped by to see Vinnie and Freddie on my way home from school. We ended up going out for a few beers, and then I took them for a drive to show off the car.

Around 9:00 that night, we crossed into Massachusetts. I still didn't have a valid driver's license, and the Lincoln wasn't insured. The registration, at least, was current, since I'd just bought it.

We pulled into a turnaround to head back home. I looked left and saw a vehicle approaching, but I apparently misjudged how fast it was coming and pulled out to complete my U-turn. At the same time, instead of slowing down and staying in his lane, the other driver swerved into the oncoming lane. Whether he misjudged what I was doing or had some other reason, I don't know.

He slammed into my left front fender and spun the Lincoln around. We were the only two cars on the road.

Once we came to a stop, I told Vinnie and Freddie to get out and pretend they were just a couple of pedestrians walking by. We'd all been drinking and smoking weed, and they definitely still had some on them. I wasn't overly "impaired", and whatever small buzz I'd had disappeared instantly with the adrenaline rush of the crash.

There were a few houses in the immediate area on one side of the street; the other side was just open fields. A small group of people came out to see what all the noise was about, with Vinnie and Freddie mingling in with them.

The driver of the brand-new, two-day-old, \$8,000 pickup (in 1979 money) was understandably pretty pissed off. The police showed up, and

when the truck driver found out I didn't have insurance, he went ballistic. The cops had to physically hold him back.

I was taken to the police station, and the Lincoln was towed away, never to be seen again.

Vinnie and Freddie ended up walking home—a good ten or fifteen miles. I doubt two Black guys hitchhiking on a country road late at night in 1979 had much luck getting anyone to stop.

I spent the night in jail and was hauled before a judge the next morning. At one point, I had to take the witness stand and was given a chance to tell my side of the story. I told the truth.

To my huge surprise, the judge fined me \$78 for not having insurance and let me go. I was ordered to come back and show proof of insurance, but I no longer had a car to insure and, to be honest, I never followed through.

That would also be the last time I saw Vinnie and Freddie—not because there were any hard feelings over their very long walk home, but because I knew it was time for me to move on.

*

Cars came and went so fast during those years that I can barely keep them straight anymore. Every few months I'd be driving something different. Some I wrecked. Some I traded. Some I sold.

After the Town Car debacle, I ended up buying an old Firebird from my classmate Danny. To this day I regret getting rid of that car.

It was a light green 1967 hardtop with an automatic transmission and a slant-six OHC engine. It was also good on gas. I loved the compact size of it, and it handled beautifully. It wasn't a super "fast" car, by any means, but it was fast enough and definitely a lot of fun to drive.

And, it only cost me \$250.

I'm still a bit sick to my stomach thinking about how cheap it was and how dumb I was to get rid of it. Then again, if I had a time machine, I'd probably buy Apple stock before saving the Firebird.

I only had it for maybe four months when a guy approached me about trading it for his quarter-mile race car, a 1964 Dodge Coronet 440. It was jacked up all the way around, with nice chrome rims and a super-throaty engine. Surprisingly, it was an automatic.

It was also horrible on gas, which was why he wanted the Firebird. He was moving to Florida and wanted something that wouldn't cost him a fortune just to get there.

At one time, the Coronet had been the fastest quarter-mile car in my hometown. Unfortunately, I blew the engine in no time.

Before doing that, though, I did have a few adventures in it.

One night, my friend Jon and I took it to Providence. We were three sheets to the wind, I was driving, and before long we found ourselves in unfamiliar territory.

The car had one small problem. It was trying to kill us.

The exhaust leaked so badly into the cabin that the only way to drive it was with both windows down and our heads hanging halfway out.

As we got into town, I got a bit lost and ended up driving the wrong way down a one-way street. I got pulled over by the cops and somehow talked my way out of a ticket. I honestly don't remember how I managed that. As I recall, I just apologized, told them I was unfamiliar with the area, and said I hadn't seen the sign. I think the adrenaline rush of getting pulled over sobered me up enough to bullshit my way through it.

As I said, the Coronet didn't last long. After I blew the engine, I ended up trading it to a guy for his Dodge Challenger.

I changed my mind and tried to undo the deal the next day. That didn't go particularly well. He threatened to burn down my mother's antique store if I tried to renege on the deal.

And he was serious.

So... I kept the Challenger.

It was a 1970 with a power sunroof and a 340 engine. Another automatic. Within a few months, I'd blown that engine too, racing it.

The funny part was that my original \$250 Firebird had somehow morphed into three different cars.

The Escape

While training to be a draftsman, I discovered something fairly important: I wasn't very good at drawing perfectly straight lines or printing neatly. No matter how much I practiced, I just couldn't seem to master either one.

Bob Burns had been right to hesitate about letting me into the course. I was doing fine otherwise, but this was a pretty serious problem for someone trying to become a draftsman.

Luckily for me, the course wasn't just mechanical drafting; it was electro-mechanical drafting. That turned out to be an important distinction. There was a two-month section devoted to Printed Circuit Board (PCB) design and drafting, including electrical schematics and board layouts.

And suddenly, my shortcomings weren't nearly as much of a problem. The line work didn't have to be perfect, and I could do the printing with a lettering template. It took longer, but electrical drawings also required a lot less printing than mechanical ones.

So, when it came time to prepare my portfolio and decide what kind of jobs I wanted to interview for, I chose electrical drafting. But the real key was finding companies that either had—or were planning to buy—a Computer Aided Design (CAD) system for electrical drafting and PCB layout.

Why? Because a computer would solve my line-work and printing problem completely. It would do all the drawing and printing for me!

Take that, Bob!!

As an added bonus, electrical drafting and design jobs paid a little more, especially if CAD and PCB design were involved.

I figured, “Hmmm... computers are the way of the future. This could be my way into a truly 'professional' career.”

And I was right.

Remember, this was 1979. Personal computers were still a curiosity. Microsoft and Apple were tiny companies that hardly anyone outside the industry had heard of. Most engineering work still revolved around giant mainframes or newer "mini-computers" the size of refrigerators. I was stepping into a world I knew almost nothing about.

But that decision wasn't just part of my escape plan. Without fully realizing it, I'd just chosen my career.

*

While the school's Placement Office was lining up interviews for me, I started looking on my own. I targeted one company about twenty minutes from home in North Attleboro, Massachusetts—I've long since forgotten its name—along with Honeywell, in the opposite direction in Rhode Island.

I interviewed at Honeywell and thought it went well, but they were dragging their feet on making a decision.

The Massachusetts company looked promising: beautiful campus, nice office building. The problem was getting in to see the department manager. I kept calling, but he was always out.

I was determined to at least get an interview, so I found out what time he went to lunch, had my mother drive me there—which tells you everything about my transportation options at that particular time—and waited in the lobby for him to come back. Fortunately, the girl at the front desk was helpful. When he walked through the lobby, she stopped him and called me over.

"This is Eric Lynch. He's been trying for two weeks to get in to see you about the PCB design position," she told him.

He turned to me, seemingly impressed by my borderline-stalking determination, and said, "Let's go grab a cup of coffee in the cafeteria."

Which we did. We talked for about forty-five minutes, and he gave me a quick tour of the department, including the CAD system they were using. It looked pretty intimidating, but I still loved the idea.

At the end, he shook my hand and said, "I'll let you know within a week. I have a few other people to interview." He sounded sincere. The job paid \$4.50 an hour—almost double minimum wage. I left feeling pretty optimistic.

A few days after my North Attleboro interview, a posting went up at the school looking for five students to interview with a company in Danbury, Connecticut, called Graphic Sciences, Inc. They manufactured some of the early fax machines.

They were looking for both mechanical and electrical draftsmen, but Danbury was a three-hour drive away, way out on the western edge of Connecticut on the New York State line. Not many people wanted to move three hours away from their family and friends in Rhode Island.

For me, of course, that was perfect.

A fresh start, with no temptations or family obligations.

The company rented us a big black Lincoln Town Car, and five of us made the long drive. Four were interviewing for mechanical positions; I was the only electrical guy.

I loved the drive. The rolling hills, the tree-lined highways, the colonial New England feel of the architecture—it all seemed upscale and different. By the time we pulled into Danbury, I already knew I wanted the job.

The interviews went well, and within a few days I got the call: four of us were offered jobs, and I was one of them. The position paid \$5.50 an hour.

The next day, the Massachusetts company called and offered me their position, too.

Now I actually had a decision to make. I could take the closer job and stay at home until I'd saved enough for my own apartment, or take the bigger chance in Connecticut—for more money—and start over somewhere completely new.

It wasn't really that hard a choice.

The only downside to Danbury was that they didn't have a CAD system yet, although one was supposedly on the way. During my interview, I made it clear that CAD was where I wanted to end up, and I wanted to know I'd have a chance to work my way into it once the system arrived. There were no guarantees, but PCB design was my goal.

The company had offered jobs to four of the five of us. Three accepted. Two actually showed up to start work a week later. The other guy quit after two weeks and moved back to Rhode Island.

That would leave me as the sole survivor.

*

The first problem was that I didn't have a car, and I had absolutely no money. My mother, bless her semi-black heart, co-signed a \$1,500 bank loan for me.

I quickly found a solid car—a 1972 Chevy Impala, red with a white vinyl top and white interior with black carpeting. It was a big, four-door land yacht that got maybe 15 mpg, but it was in great shape with only 70,000 miles on it, and I got it for \$700.

I hung onto that car for three years—the longest I'd ever owned a car up to that point. It served me very well.

Next, I rented a small U-Haul trailer, hooked it up to the hitch that was fortunately already on the car, and packed my meager belongings into it.

Finally, I said my goodbyes and pulled away from the house I'd wanted to leave since I was seven years old. Or even younger than that.

I was free. Truly free. Not runaway-free, but legally free, with a real job and a hopeful career waiting for me three hours away.

It was an intoxicating feeling. Leaving everything familiar behind was a bit scary, but the excitement easily outweighed the fear.

I did, however, have one stop to make before I left Rhode Island.

356 Orms Street.

The Dark Tower

I pulled up along the curb outside Stoner's tenement building. I hadn't been inside in at least eight months. I hadn't seen Stoner in just as long. The last time I'd seen him, he was wrist-deep in chicken salad, with two black eyes and a huge knot on his forehead.

A lot had changed in those eight months. I got out of my new-to-me car and looked back at the little U-Haul trailer carrying everything I owned. I briefly considered how much time I had before I was robbed.

I walked up the front steps, the afternoon sun slanting across the neighborhood the unflattering way it always does on a hot summer day in the inner city, magnifying the dirt, the ugliness, and the decay.

I climbed the two flights of foot-worn, rickety stairs to the Dark Tower and knocked. I had no idea if he was home, but after a minute, the door opened.

Stoner stood there looking at me with a mix of surprise, confusion, and... wariness?

That made me a little sad. Was he actually afraid of me? It was mind-blowing to think that anyone who knew me could be afraid of me.

"Eric! Holy shit, man. Long time no see. Come on in, man, have a seat. Do you want a beer?"

"Yeah, I'll have a quick beer, but I'm just passing through. I have a car sitting out front with a U-Haul, and I don't want to leave it there too long. Not in this neighborhood."

We both laughed at the dark joke.

I sat on the couch while he poured me a Genesee Cream Ale from the tap, then settled into a chair across the coffee table from me. I took a deep swig of the cold beer, pulled an envelope out of my pocket, and handed it to him.

"What's this?" he asked, confused.

"It's the \$600 I owe you."

He looked at me in disbelief as he opened the envelope and slowly pulled out the six \$100 bills. I wanted to give him cash so there could be no doubt that this was real.

He was blown away. Six hundred dollars was a lot of money then—it was almost what I'd paid for my new-to-me car.

I tried one last time to clear my name.

"I hope you don't think of this as 'guilt money.' I don't know how I can convince you that I didn't—and would never—attack you or anyone else, and most certainly not with a baseball bat."

Again, he repeated that familiar refrain: "I only know what I heard..."

I patiently went through the theory I'd heard from others about Joe's brother, the ex-Providence cop who drove a white van, along with the other circumstantial evidence I'd been able to piece together.

This time, Stoner seemed to really consider it. For the first time, I got the sense that he was at least open to the possibility that the witnesses had been wrong.

I don't think he was fully convinced. But he was considering it.

I left him that way, not feeling fully vindicated, but knowing I'd done the best I could. Whether he believed me or not was up to him.

For a while, Stoner and I had been very good friends. I truly loved the guy. We'd even become blood brothers, for whatever that was worth. Sitting there having a beer with him again, it was sad to think that one terrible night and a misunderstanding had ended our friendship.

But the truth was, our lives were already heading in different directions. Stoner didn't know about my dreams or what I wanted to do with my life. I'm not sure I ever told him. As much as I loved him, I didn't want the life he was living. I wanted something different.

In a way, I was escaping that life, too.

Not Stoner. The life.

*

Between the car and the cost to register it, the \$600 I'd just handed Stoner, and everything else it took to get myself on the road, I had \$140 left to my name.

But at least I had a car, a job, and somewhere to go.

I was only there for maybe 20 minutes before I said my goodbyes to Stoner and walked down those rickety, dirty stairs one last time. I crossed the street and stopped to make sure the trailer hitch was still secure, got back in the car, and started the engine.

As I looked over my left shoulder to check my blind spot, my eyes settled briefly on the dirty white latticework framing the front steps. Behind it was the patch of dirt where, two and a half years earlier, I'd lain awake thinking, *It's all on me now.*

"Two and a half years," I thought. It felt like ten.

I'd spent most of my childhood dreaming of Freedom. Then I'd spent the last two and a half years trying to figure out how to get there.

And now I knew.

I pulled away from the curb, heading west.

Epilogue

I didn't grow up poor, but we were definitely lower middle class and struggling to stay there. During those two-plus years in Providence, though, I lived poor, and sometimes dangerously. It was a dirty, gritty existence fueled by drugs and alcohol. I scraped by from one week to the next.

What shocked me was eventually realizing that for many of the people around me, this wasn't a temporary detour.

It was their life.

I was just there undercover, looking over my shoulder for police cars slowing down to take a look at me, doing and saying what I had to do to get through it all.

My next stop was Danbury, Connecticut. Within five years, I finally landed in California.

Along the way, I also changed my name. Not to distance myself from my family or anything dramatic like that. I'd simply never particularly liked the sound of "Lynch," and changing it was something I could do. So, eventually, I did.

In 1994, I was working on a consulting engagement for Charles Schwab in San Francisco, staying in the city during the week and driving home to San Jose on weekends. One morning, for reasons I can't remember, I started thinking about surnames while I was in the shower.

I thought about how, in the old days, surnames often came from what people did—Smith, Taylor, and so on. I'd always thought I'd like to be a writer someday, so I started playing with that.

Writer. Writer. Writer... That wasn't a last name. But if you say it fast and a bunch of times, it might sound like...

Writer. Rider. Ryder...

Oh. Like the moving trucks. And the Ryder Cup. That works.

My legal first name was still Eric-Jon, even though I'd dropped the "-Jon" sometime around third grade, so I figured I could legally make my first name simply "Eric." I didn't want to change it to something else. That gets weird with people you know, and besides, I didn't have a problem with Eric.

For a middle name, I remembered a programmer I'd worked with years earlier named Zachary. I'd always liked the name and used to joke that if I ever had a son—"God forbid"—I'd name him Zachary.

So: Eric Zachary Ryder.

I got out of the shower, wrapped a towel around myself, sat on the edge of the hotel bed, and started trying out variations on a notepad:

Eric Zachary Ryder

Eric Z. Ryder

E. Zachary Ryder

E. Z. Ryder

I stared at that last one.

Then I started laughing.

I sat there in a towel, alone in a San Francisco hotel room, laughing my ass off for probably ten minutes. It was perfect. Completely accidental, completely ridiculous, and exactly my sense of humor.

So that's the name I went with.

Over the years, whenever someone saw my name and said something like, "Your parents must have had quite a sense of humor," I'd just shrug and say, "It was a coincidence."

Which, technically, was the truth.

I married twice, never had kids, and eventually built a career in the software business. I traveled to fifteen countries and forty-seven states and met a slew of famous people along the way, including Jack Nicholson on my wedding day and Clint Eastwood on my wedding anniversary—and then twice more in the years that followed. I even accidentally ended up having dinner with Francis Ford Coppola and his wife at their table. There were quite a few other people I never expected to meet.

The seventeen-year-old version of me living on Orms Street couldn't have imagined any of it. At the time, I was just trying to make it to the next paycheck, the next meal, and find a way out.

And I did get out.

What happened after that is another story.

*

Over the years, whenever I went back to Rhode Island to visit, I'd sometimes take a detour through Providence and drive past 356 Orms Street.

The first time, I learned from some neighbors that Stoner had actually bought the place for \$10,000 through a city program that sold old buildings slated for demolition to people willing to restore them. He was still living on the third floor. The second floor was still condemned, and someone, I think, was living on the first.

I parked and rang his doorbell, but he wasn't there. It had been a spur-of-the-moment decision to stop by, so I hadn't called ahead.

The next time I went by, huge twenty-foot 4x6 posts had been installed to hold up the third-floor balcony—the same condemned balcony we'd spent countless nights sitting on at three or four in the morning, drinking, getting high, and apparently trusting our lives to optimism.

I didn't stop.

The third time I went back, the Dark Tower was gone.

I never found out what happened to it. Maybe there'd been a fire. Maybe the city finally condemned the whole place. Or maybe Stoner simply decided the lot was worth more than the building and had it torn down.

It was really strange seeing the empty space where it had been. Those three-story tenements were jammed together so tightly along the street that the gap looked oddly out of place. Like a missing tooth.

The lot was overgrown with weeds, with no real sign there had ever been a house there at all.

For a split second, it almost felt as though I'd imagined the whole thing.

Almost.